Social Movements that Care

Empathy, Solidarity, and Empowerment in the Fight Against Evictions

Felipe G. Santos



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'Based on a most insightful analysis of one of the most inspiring and consequential networks of activists against house evictions in Spain, this book originally investigates the practices of care developed in order to overcome the immobilising effects of some grievances and emotions. Adopting a relational, strategic and dynamic perspective, it shows the empowering effects of affective care, identity care and participation care.'

—Donatella della Porta, *Professor of Political Science, and Director of the Center on Social Movement Studies (Cosmos), Scuola Normale Superiore*

"How do grievances lead to grassroots mobilisation? This excellent book offers a new theoretical explanation which is unusual in social movement studies: there is a fundamental "logic of care" when solidarity early-risers politicise the grievances of those more affected by social injustice, and mobilise together. The case of the anti-home evictions struggles in Spain, led by the PAH (Platform for People Affected by Mortgages) provides a solid empirical ground for this argument. This book also helps understand how the PAH overcame the risks of being a mere assistance-based or self-help organisation, with an exemplar autonomous and caring way of organising. And they impressively did so in the midst of a dramatic wave of housing dispossession for the impoverished working class, while facing brutal post-2008 austerity policies. A must-read for housing and social movement scholars and activists!'

—Miguel A. Martínez, *Professor in Sociology, Institute for Housing and Urban Research, Uppsala University*

"Felipe G. Santos has written a compelling account of the ways in which Platform for those Affected by Mortgages (PAH)—a highly impactful social movement in Spain—organizes for successful contentious politics through care. As a participant observer, he shows how different forms of care help to transform "debtors of good faith" from their initial grievances to solidarity. This is one of the best books I have read about how caring makes social movements successful."

—Joan C. Tronto, *Professor Emerita, University of Minnesota, and author of Moral Boundaries: A Political Argument for an Ethic of Care, and Caring Democracy: Markets, Equality, and Justice*

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ISBN 978-3-031-74295-8 ISBN 978-3-031-74296-5 (eBook)
https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-031-74296-5

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Cover illustration: Pablo Pino

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To Lucia, for all the care we have shared throughout the years

Acknowledgments

Even if only one author appears on the cover of this book, every creative work is the outcome of many collective exchanges and the support of many caring people. This is especially true for a book that is the result of someone's PhD, a period that is a particular combination of freedom, care, and empowerment, but also substantial vulnerability. First and foremost, I thank Bèla Greskovits, my PhD supervisor at Central European University, for his guidance throughout these years and his support after I graduated with the PhD. Not only did Bèla encourage me to be the best researcher I could be, but his outstanding analytical eye also served as a great inspiration for me to achieve this.

I have also been incredibly fortunate that the other two people who were part of my supervisory committee, Erin Jenne and Austin Choi-Fitzpatrick, were just as committed to my project as Bèla was. Erin inspired my passion for methods in her course Research Methods and Design during the first year of my PhD. Her feedback helped me to see the bigger picture of my research, something that becomes increasingly difficult when one is so immersed in a topic. I particularly wish to thank Erin for her kind words and support during a moment when the PhD seemed like a project too big to tackle and I was close to quitting. Her understanding and support during that moment provided me with the encouragement I needed to continue with this project.

Austin introduced me to two incredibly exciting topics: the study of social movements and contentious politics, as well as San Diego's craft beer scene. If I am able to engage with and contribute to the academic debates on social movements and contentious politics, it is foremost

thanks to Austin's guidance. Austin's radical and always different way of looking at research and life has been an inspiration to do research with my feet on the ground and my mind outside the box. I am also tremendously thankful to Austin for continuing to support me from a distance after he moved away from Budapest, and for being the best possible host during my time at the University of San Diego.

I was fortunate to encounter many other brilliant minds who have given me support during these years. David S. Meyer sponsored my visit to the University of California, Irvine, and gave me constructive and detailed feedback during my time there. Olga Onuch was incredibly accommodating in transitioning to my postdoc position at the University of Manchester and gave me space to put the final touches on my PhD thesis. Finally, Dan Mercea—beyond being an outstanding mentor and colleague with whom I have discussed at lenght about social movements, protests and politcs—has given me ample space to develop my own research interests parallel to the projects in which we are working together at City St. George's, University of London; and Babeș-Bolyai University. This has allowed me to further reflect on housing, care, and empowerment also after I finished my PhD and be able to refine and expand the theory and analysis I had developed.

My friends and family celebrated the highs and supported me in the lows during these years. Lucia, to whom this book is dedicated, lived through every important moment of my academic career with me, many of them as if they were her own. Doing justice to all the support and care she offered would fill the pages of another book. Together with Lucia, Sasha and Jonathan completed my Budapest family, with whom I discovered, enjoyed, and loved the amazing city in which I developed many of the ideas contained in this book. Felix was a great flatmate and colleague, as well as a dear friend, who was always ready to look at the perils that we went through during our PhD and continue to experience during our academic careers. My childhood friend Ángel, besides numerous other things, helped a poor PhD student, bringing him cheap secondhand books from the UK every time we saw each other. Wayuu, my dog, greets me with joy every time I return home, and walks me out daily, making sure I have plenty of moments of reflection and disconnect in the middle of nature. Many of my ideas appeared during our walks in the forest. My parents and my brother have been supporting me since even before I can remember. I am incredibly lucky to have grown around such a caring family as they have been and continue to be.

I am also grateful for the funding I have received that allowed me to write this book. I am thankful to the Central European University for the generous stipend and research grants; to the Open Research Area (ORA) Scheme, which funded my postdoctoral position at the University of Manchester through the MOBILISE project; to the Volkswagen Foundation, which provided the funds for my postdoctoral fellowship at City, University of London, as part of the ProDem project (grant no. 98144); and to the European Union and the Romanian Government, who contributed the resources for my postdoctoral fellowship at Babeș-Bolyai University as part of the TakePart project, financed through the NextGenerationEU scheme under the National Recovery and Resilience Plan for Romania (contract no. 760038/23.05.2023, cod PNRR-C9-I8-CF204/29.11.2022), disbursed by the Romanian Ministry of Research, Innovation and Digitalization, within Component 9, Investment I8.

Most importantly, I would like to thank the activists of PAH Barcelona and PAH, more generally. I had a better grasp of the care dynamics in the organization because I experienced many of them myself. They were incredibly welcoming since the first moment I stepped into their space. They have inspired me in so many ways and showed me that, when little people share their vulnerabilities and care for each other, those who are many can stand a chance against those who have money.

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Housing Crisis, Care, and Empowerment

It is 9 a.m. and I arrive at one of the many eviction blockades organized by the Platform of Those Affected by Mortgages (PAH) in El Raval, a neighborhood of Barcelona that has become the perfect picture of the contradictions of gentrification. El Raval used to be a working-class area that grew during the second half of the XVIII century and homed many of the people who moved to Barcelona to work for its burgeoning industry. It soon became one of the most populous neighborhoods in the city, where humble local and migrant families lived. El Raval starts as you move west from the Ramblas Boulevard, the most touristic street in Barcelona. The growing international popularity of the city after the 1992 Olympic Games flooded the area with tourists. Today, expensive hotels share the road with cheap rentals where their inhabitants live in precariousness, and eviction can occur next to a coffee shop that sells overpriced lattes to tourists.

While we waited for the judicial entourage to arrive, I started a conversation with Jorge,[1] a professional photographer from Barcelona who used to work on development cooperation and who has been collaborating with PAH for several years. We were soon joined by Lidia, a Bolivian migrant who moved to Spain during the housing boom, who became indebted to buy a home, defaulted on her mortgage after she and her

[1] All names used throughout the book are pseudonyms. The only exception to this rule are the names of PAH founders used in Chapter "Caring Movements and Care in Movements".

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F. G. Santos, *Social Movements that Care*,
https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-031-74296-5_1

husband fell into unemployment during the crisis, and is now fighting her bank to avoid being evicted. I asked them about how they ended up in PAH. Jorge moved back from his last job in Colombia, and he wanted to engage in activism. As evictions were at their peak when he returned to Spain, he decided to join PAH. What leads somebody not affected by a problem to join a social movement to defend other people's rights?

Lidia told me about how she contracted a mortgage and the problems she faced during the crisis. Both she and her husband had stable jobs. She was a cleaner and her partner worked in construction, where he was making considerable money. When the crisis came, her husband lost his job, placing them in a difficult financial situation, as he earned much more than her. When they failed to pay their first mortgage installment, their bank started to pressure them. As the deed in lieu of foreclosure is not a common figure in Spanish mortgage contracts, and housing prices had fallen substantially since the crisis broke, giving up their home was not enough to cancel their debt. Lidia and her husband imagined what their lives would look like, pushed into homelessness, and still having to repay a debt they could never return. One day, Lidia's husband disappeared. Later on, she discovered he had returned to Bolivia, escaping from his financial troubles and abandoning her. The bank did not care about this and continued pressuring her with daily calls demanding the money she owned. Lidia fell into depression and tried to commit suicide. 'Look at these cuts. They are from a previous time when the bank drove me mad. I was depressed and didn't know what to do. I tried to kill myself twice. Now I am fine, and I am fighting them because they cannot do these sorts of things'. She went on to speak about how difficult it was for her to join PAH. She mentioned how she thought protests would change nothing and that she preferred to find other solutions by herself. She also mentioned that she approached PAH when she saw no other solution and, once she joined the organization, she did not know what to do and was too embarrassed to speak with anyone.

Jorge knew Lidia's story already, but I was in shock. While I could not imagine how I would recover after her experience, she spoke about such a terrible episode of her life so easily and in such a calm manner. It almost felt like she was talking about somebody else. Moreover, it was impressive to see the conviction with which she spoke during assemblies and how she organized other people during eviction blockades. How did she overcome her problems and find the power to confront financial institutions and contribute to PAH with the energy and good mood she had?

This book is about how Lidia and Jorge ended up in the same social movement organization and the processes they followed to do so. It is obvious that Lidia was aggrieved, but her troubles were so overwhelming that they complicated her mobilization. Jorge also experienced a grievance, even if he did not live through it. He saw the situation of many people like Lidia, empathized with them and felt the need to act. The origin of Lidia's and Jorge's grievance is the same: an unjust model of housing and finance that pushes people into debt and throws them to the streets once they are not financially profitable. However, the way they experienced the grievance and reacted to it was poles apart.

In order to fully understand how Jorge and Lidia connected, I spent one year as a participant observer at PAH Barcelona and interviewed 71 members of the organization from all over Spain. This book is the result of some things I learned during this time and how I sought to make sense of them theoretically. During this process, I found that Jorge's and Lidia's stories are the stories of many more PAH members. Indeed, as I argue in this book, they are the stories of members of many more social movement organizations and their connection can help explain the mobilization of many other groups involved in a great variety of topics.

Different Mobilization from Different Sufferings

Most people join social movements because they are aggrieved and decide to collaborate with other similarly affected people to solve their common problems. For this, individuals need to experience emotions like anger, anxiety, hope, and a sense of mistreatment, which are feelings that urge them to act and approach others (Goodwin et al., 2001b). Moreover, they need to identify with others who are similarly troubled and be ready to dedicate time and energy to advance the group's demands (Polletta & Jasper, 2001). Collectives whose grievances encourage them to approach others and identify with them are likely to mobilize once they have the opportunity and resources to do so. Aggrieved individuals who are reached by the mobilization attempts of social movement entrepreneurs and have enough time and energy are more likely to engage in contentious collective action. These types of successful and relatively straightforward mobilizations are those that have inspired most academic discussions and have been the seeds of groundbreaking social movement theories, such as strain and breakdown (Davies, 1962; Gurr, 1970; Kornhauser, 1959; Piven & Cloward, 1977; Smelser, 1963; Snow et al., 1998) political process

(McAdam, 1999 [1982]; McAdam et al., 2001), resource mobilization (McCarthy & Zald, 1977), framing (Benford & Snow, 2000; Snow et al., 1986; Snow & Benford, 1988), and micromobilization (Beyerlein & Hipp, 2006; Klandermans, 1984; Klandermans & Oegema, 1987; McAdam, 1986; Snow et al., 1980). Even if these are the types of grievances that have attracted the most attention from students of protests and social movements, neither Jorge's nor Lidia's experiences are fully explained by these approaches.

On the one hand, Jorge did not mobilize for a grievance he experienced himself, but acted in solidarity with another collective. He empathized with the struggle of those affected by mortgages and was dissatisfied with their situation, so he decided to take action. Jorge could have probably joined an organization that defended his own interests, like a trade union that fights for better working conditions for photographers, but he decided to dedicate his time to a cause from which he would not benefit directly. On the other hand, Lidia was immobilized by her grievance. Financial distress and being at risk of eviction destabilized her life to a degree that she could not react to her situation. Instead of encouraging her to mobilize collectively, her mortgage problems overwhelmed her and complicated her mobilization. Social movement scholarship would say that Lidia was 'biographically unavailable' (McAdam, 1986). Lidia dedicated all her efforts to finding a job and making small gigs that would help her repay her mortgage and she did not have time or energy left for activism. Moreover, mortgage problems often break people's relationships with their networks. They may bring conflicts with family, as it was Lidia's case to the extent that her husband abandoned her. They may also distance people from their friends, as financial difficulties reduce their resources for leisure and many people cut ties with their acquaintances because they are ashamed to let them know about their economic troubles. In academic jargon, Lidia turned 'structurally unavailable' (Klandermans & Oegema, 1987; Snow et al., 1986). Moreover, some grievances generate immobilizing emotions and stigmatize identities, some of the features that I categorize in this book under the label of *personal unavailability*. As I elaborate further during this work, I define personal availability as the absence of emotional, identity, and knowledge constraints that pose barriers to participation in some or all movement activities. Lidia's case was extreme, but it is common for many aggrieved individuals to experience fear, shame, and insecurity. Many troubles may also affect an individual's networks and willingness to socialize. Instead of facilitating the mobilization when

political opportunities arise, grievances may also discourage non-conforming behavior, such as participation in protests and social movements. Under these circumstances, people prefer to hide from the public and avoid any confrontation.

Once we explore the variety of grievances and reactions to them, we realize the complexities of political solidarity or lack thereof. If we understand solidarity as the willingness to contribute individual resources—time, money, and energy—to a collective end (cf. Durkheim, 1912; Hechter, 1987), it is easy to understand why people motivated by mobilizing grievances contribute their private resources to a collective end that will advance their position. However, the experiences of Jorge and Lidia are more complex. Why was Jorge willing to make sacrifices for something he would not directly benefit from? Why did Lidia struggle to find the motivation to join efforts with others who sought the same goal and were already doing it successfully?

Reactions to grievances follow different processes. Some grievances foster internal solidarity. This type of reaction has been amply studied by previous literature and is not the focus of this work. Other grievances may foster external solidarity. Even if one is not affected by the issue at hand, the injustice compels individuals to act. This type of reaction requires the capacity to empathize with a collective that one is not part of. Finally, grievances may sometimes create so much disruption in people's lives that they immobilize those facing them. Before being ready to mobilize, some individuals need to pass through a healing phase, where their needs related to emotions, identities, and capacity to participate are addressed.

This work builds on previous studies of how the political process of contention unfolds, highlighting three aspects that have been overlooked so far. First, it provides an explanation of the process through which non-beneficiary early-risers start to mobilize in support of an external group. In recent years, solidarity movements in the context of migration (Ataç et al., 2016; Della Porta, 2018; Monforte, 2019), state atrocities outside its borders (Nepstad, 2008; Russo, 2018), and those motivated by the dismantling of the welfare state due to austerity cuts (Cabot, 2016; Teloni & Adam, 2016) have been at the forefront of political events and scholarly attention in the global north. This book maps the processes through which some privileged allies empathize with an aggrieved collective, experience solidarity towards a group they are not part of, and decide to start organizing in their support.

Second, the book sheds light on instances when grievances hamper solidarity among the affected collective. While most social movement research focuses on instances of successful mobilization and strategies to foster participation and recruitment, this work provides a comprehensive account of the immobilizing effects that some types of oppression have. While previous explanations are centered on how structures of social control (Piven & Cloward, 1977; Snow et al., 1998), as well as state (Davenport, 2007; Earl, 2003; Ortiz, 2013; Soule & Davenport, 2009) and cultural (Ferree, 2004) repression, prevent contentious collective action, this work highlights the devastating effect that some grievances may have for those who face them to an extent that individuals become immobilized.

Finally, the book explores ways in which organizations foster solidarity among those aggrieved, and empower their members to take ownership of their struggle as well as contribute to the collective goals of the movement. This work is an effort to present a comprehensive account of empowerment that includes emotions, identities, and skills. Previous studies on empowerment in social movement organizations have focused mostly on building knowledge and skills (Andrews et al., 2010; Han, 2014). While other works have focused on social movement leaders' efforts to encourage certain emotions (Flam & King, 2005; Goodwin et al., 2001a; Goodwin & Pfaff, 2003; Gould, 2001; Jasper, 2011, 2018) and identities (Klandermans et al., 2008; Melucci, 1995; Polletta & Jasper, 2001; Saunders, 2008; Snow & McAdam, 2000; Taylor, 2000). Moreover, this book develops a framework that highlights the interactions between changes in emotions, identities, and skills and how they foster solidarity and engagement among the aggrieved community.

This work builds on previous studies of contentious politics (Choi-Fitzpatrick, 2017; Fligstein & McAdam, 2015; McAdam, 1999 [1982]; McAdam et al., 2001) and highlights two pathways of mobilization that are central to some movements that, in addition to the logic of justice that inspires most attempts to change society, are based on a logic of care (cf. Gilligan, 1982). When the beneficiary group is immobilized by their grievance, they may need a first impetus from more privileged solidarity early-risers, who may address the problems that prevented the engagement of beneficiary constituents during the first stages of mobilization. This book argues that, when these two groups meet, certain dynamics take particular importance. The beginnings of this type of mobilization require that those immobilized go through a process of healing and empowerment within the organization. This phase is initiated by non-beneficiary constituents,

who also need to make additional efforts to understand the needs of the collective they are mobilizing for. To understand these dynamics, we need to pay attention to how activists care for each other and the care logics that arise.

The Ethics of Care of Contentious Collective Action

Care is 'a species activity that includes everything that we do to maintain, continue, and repair our "world" so that we can live in it as well as possible. That world includes our bodies, our selves, and our environment' (Tronto, 2013, p. 19; see also Fisher & Tronto, 1990, p. 40; Tronto, 1993, p. 103). To have political meaning, care must consist of a relational action that goes beyond the act of thinking. According to Held, care consists of 'attending to and meeting the needs of the particular others for whom we take responsibility' (2006, p. 10), and also includes protecting ourselves and others from 'extraordinary incursions of violence or other forms of disruption into our daily lives' (Tronto, 1993, p. 104).

Studying social movements from an ethics of care perspective places emphasis on the interdependencies that are at the core of social mobilization. Rather than approaching social movements emphasizing individuals and collectives, an ethics of care approach places the focus on the relationships among them. While social mobilizations are often ignited by distinct grievances that affect certain communities and social groups, those who are part of these mobilizations also bring other vulnerabilities. Black feminist scholars have long pointed at the multiplicity of ways in which different forms of oppression and discrimination intersect (e.g., Carastathis, 2014; Crenshaw, 1989; Davis, 1983; Hill Collins, 1990, 2015). Studying social movements through the lens of the ethics of care brings to the fore how these intersecting vulnerabilities complicate mobilization, as well as the relationships that take place in social movements that help to overcome the challenges that these discriminations pose to the socio-political mobilization of these groups, contributing to the empowerment of these communities and their members.

According to Tronto (1993, 2013), caring consists of a four-step process. Any caring relationship starts with a person or collective (1) *caring about* another. This action requires the quality of attentiveness. Second, it is necessary to take responsibility to address the identified need, (2) *caring*

for the other individual or group. Third, one needs to be competent to address the identified needs and (3) *give care*. Finally, the collective or person (4) *receives the care* and responds to it.

I argue that the caring process theorized by Tronto serves to analyze how mobilization social movement may originate from external solidarity. (1) Mobilization begins when a, generally more privileged group, cares about another collective and recognizes that it suffers from some needs that should be met. (2) After the detection of the need, the privileged group evaluates the conditions of the field and the possibility of addressing the needs of the immobilized collective through contentious collective action. If they think that they have the chance to mobilize in support of the aggrieved group, they will assume the responsibility of confronting their oppression. (3) After assuming responsibility, solidarity early-risers start efforts to enter into contact with the aggrieved and immobilized collective and caregiving starts. This is the moment when the group initiates mobilization. (4) Once care activities take place, the person or group that has been cared for reacts to the interaction. For care to be considered political, the recipient person or group shall evolve in the direction of taking ownership of their struggle. This characteristic is what determines the sometimes-thin difference between whether care relationships take place in the realm of contentious politics or through assistance-based solidarity activities. In other words, the privileged and empathic constituents need to have the vocation to politicize the beneficiary group, and, eventually, be ready to give up leadership and referential roles in their favor.

Care serves to understand the reasons why some aggrieved individuals do not join social movements, or at least struggle to do so at first, and how they are empowered once they do. As I argue in the book, somebody immobilized by a grievance faces structural, biographical, and/or personal needs that complicate their participation in contentious collective action. First, being part of networks and being reached by mobilization attempts are two of the strongest predictors of participation in social movements (Gould, 1993; Klandermans, 1997; Klandermans & Oegema, 1987; McAdam & Paulsen, 1993; Verba et al., 1995). Yet, some immobilizing grievances isolate individuals. They may generate conflicts with their circles or lead them to isolation because their shame and fear, or reduced economic capacities, push them to be by themselves. The new situation of lack of 'structural availability' (Snow et al., 1980) produced by their grievance becomes an extra burden for confronting the grievance itself. Second, even if individuals are part of networks and aware of grassroots initiatives

to confront their grievances, the instability created by some types of oppression may reduce their biographical availability, leaving those affected with no time to dedicate to anything beyond dealing with the consequences of the grievance itself. Finally, as I elaborate throughout the book, some grievances may turn people 'personally unavailable'. Personal availability refers to the degree to which emotional, self-identity, and knowledge constraints pose barriers to participation in some or all movement activities. Certain emotions, such as shame and fear (Amabile et al., 2005), 'spoiled identities' (Goffman, 1990 [1963]; Kaplan & Liu, 2000), lack of identification with the collective that the organization represents or not having certain 'civic skills' (Verba et al., 1995) will prevent people from approaching a SMO.

In the case when some people, despite these burdens do approach a collective, they tend to be passively recruited. *Passive recruitment* consists of privately approaching an organization without the will or capacity to participate. In these cases, people tend to approach an organization seeking assistance as passive beneficiaries, looking for individualized solutions. Plainly said, they may show up at assemblies, but they will not speak there, socialize with others in any way, or participate in any activity of the collective. Under these circumstances, immobilized individuals who are passively recruited need to go through a healing phase, where the needs that hampered their participation are addressed. I refer to these efforts as *care work*.

I identify three types of care work. First, *emotional care* is the interactions among activists that confront immobilizing emotions, and generate energizing emotions and high 'emotional energy' (cf. Collins, 2004). Emotional care may take place through rituals, where the congregation of bodies with a shared focus of attention influences the emotions of its participants (cf. Durkheim, 1912). In this case, it is the collective, rather than particular individuals, who provide the care work. Emotional care also takes place through 'intimate social networks' (cf. Goodwin & Pfaff, 2003), where particular persons provide emotional support to those in need. Second, *identity care* consists of the organizational efforts to maintain and repair members' self-concepts and collective identities. Finally, *participatory care* is the activities aimed at facilitating participation in the activities of the movement. These efforts may consist of offering newcomers easily accessible activism opportunities and making participation in each activity as easy as possible; training members to better contribute to the movement; and reducing the risks associated with activism and

members' lives so they are more comfortable contributing to the social movement's activities.

As I elaborate in the book, care relationships empower those taking part in them. Empowerment is 'a social-action process that promotes participation of people, organizations, and communities towards the goals of increased individual and community control, political efficacy, improved quality of community life, and social justice' (Wallerstein, 1992, p. 198). In the context of social movements, empowerment refers to the evolution that individuals go through, which increases their availability to take part in social movement activities. During this process, newcomers start being exposed to interactions of care work that make them more available to engage in activism. Moreover, newcomers may make conscious efforts, trying to manage their emotions and joining organizational training programs, among other things. As they are exposed to care work, members become empowered to take ownership of their struggles and contribute to the collective activities of the movement that aim at confronting their grievances. When immobilized newcomers approach the organization, they will be exposed to organizational rituals that confront the emotions that prevent their participation. Moreover, some more experienced members may encourage them to contribute to the group through easily accessible activism opportunities, such as taking minutes at the assembly.

These reflections, and the whole book, are inspired by the case of PAH. PAH was founded by six people who did not have a mortgage but who decided to seek solutions to address the drama of evictions that was affecting many people who purchased their dwellings through indebtedness. People trapped in their mortgages were both biographically and structurally unavailable prior to joining the organization. Facing financial distress and risking eviction destabilize one's life to the extent that people have no time or energy to do anything else than address this problem. Moreover, the stress and shame of not being able to repay their debts and afford a dwelling isolates individuals from their personal networks (Di Feliciantonio, 2017). Despite these challenging circumstances, PAH has become the biggest housing organization in Spain. Hence, PAH is a 'typical case' (Gerring, 2007; Seawright & Gerring, 2008) of successful mobilization inspired by care that is perfect for exploring the mechanisms of this phenomenon. I consider PAH a typical case because it exemplifies a stable relationship between care practices and mobilization. Cases of this type are the best suited to explore the causal mechanisms in a relationship of interest (Seawright & Gerring, 2008).

The Platform of Those Affected by Mortgages

PAH was created in February 2009 with the objective of organizing those facing evictions. During the years of the housing bubble, prior to the crisis that started in 2008, thousands of families signed mortgage contracts to buy a dwelling. When the crisis came, many became unemployed and found they could no longer afford to pay their mortgages. As the deed in lieu of foreclosure is not a common clause in Spanish mortgage contracts and housing prices had collapsed, many found that not only they would lose their homes but they would still carry six-figure debts. Under these circumstances, a group of six people, none of whom had a mortgage, decided to start looking for ways to organize this immobilized collective.

PAH has become one of the most influential social movement organizations in Spain. It has expanded to all corners of the country and, as of 2019, is present in 254 locations. They have blocked thousands of evictions through civil resistance and prevented many more by pressuring banks. Moreover, it has rehoused more than 2500 people in occupied apartments owned by banks and vulture funds (Plataforma de Afectados por la Hipoteca, 2017). Institutionally, PAH has organized the biggest official petition in the history of Spain to this date, gathering almost 1.5 million signatures, and it has successfully lobbied to change the housing laws of five of the 17 regions in Spain, as well as a national housing law. Moreover, many of its members are or have been elected representatives, the most iconic of whom, Ada Colau, was the spokesperson for PAH and became mayor of Barcelona in 2015, until 2023. Finally, PAH has also reframed the social discourses about housing and the financial crisis, and improved social perceptions of occupation (Martínez, 2019).

Structure of the Book

In the six chapters of this book, I explore the processes of mobilization that originate from empathic and immobilizing grievances, and how these two distinct patterns connect. Chapter "Housing Crisis, Care, and Empowerment" develops the theoretical framework of the book. It presents a categorization of the different reactions to grievances and focuses on the mobilization that originates from those who experience external solidarity and those who became immobilized by their oppression. To do this, it borrows from the debates on the ethics of care and applies them to the study of social movements. It theorizes the two processes of

mobilization outlined and explores how they fit together. Care work is presented as a fundamental factor for social movement organizations to sustain mobilization and a crucial tool for the mobilization of immobilized collectives.

Chapters "Caring Movements and Care in Movements" and "The Origins of PAH: Empathy and Solidarity Mobilization" focus on the two types of mobilization explored in the book. Chapter "Caring Movements and Care in Movements" explores the origins of PAH from the perspective of the Politics of Care. It shows how external solidarity led PAH's founders to create the organization and it follows the steps of the collective until the creation of its two most significant campaigns: *STOP Desahucios*, PAH's campaign to block evictions through civil resistance, and *Obra Social*, the occupation of empty buildings owned by financial institutions to rehouse evicted families. Chapter "The Origins of PAH: Empathy and Solidarity Mobilization" looks at the other side of PAH's mobilization and explores how those trapped in their mortgages become empowered and managed to overcome the burdens that complicated their participation in the organization. This section dissects the different ways in which facing financial distress and the risk of eviction immobilizes individuals and the process through which they manage to overcome these burdens and become empowered with the support of the rest of the organization.

Chapters "From Immobilized to Empowered: Beneficiary Mobilization in PAH", "Emotional Care: From the Sentiments of Eviction to the Feelings of Contention", and "Identity Care and Becoming Activists" elaborate on the different components of care work, as they occur in PAH. Chapter "From Immobilized to Empowered: Beneficiary Mobilization in PAH" focuses on how PAH confronts the immobilizing emotions with which individuals arrive at the organization and how its members foster energizing emotions through rituals and personal interactions. Chapter "Emotional Care: From the Sentiments of Eviction to the Feelings of Contention" addresses how PAH improves its members' self-concepts and feelings of community through Identity Care. Finally, Chapter "Identity Care and Becoming Activists" explores how PAH addresses the challenges of participation, such as the limited time of its members, the risks associated with activism, and the lack of previous knowledge and experiences of most of its members.

I conclude the book by discussing its implications for political sociology and social movement studies. The case of PAH teaches us that some

grievances, such as facing financial distress and the risk of eviction, instead of encouraging collective mobilization, hamper internal solidarity among the affected community. However, as I argue in this book, solidarity can be constructed during the process of mobilization. Furthermore, in addition to internal solidarity, individuals not affected by the grievance of a collective may experience empathy and external solidarity towards them. These emotions may even trigger mobilizations in support of immobilized collectives. The experience of PAH also highlights the importance that coalitions between privileged, empathic non-beneficiary activists and immobilized beneficiary constituents can have for the mobilization of heavily oppressed groups. The creation of internal solidarity among people facing the risk of eviction happened thanks to the initial efforts of a group of people not affected by the problem of mortgages, who began mobilization in solidarity with them. Moreover, care relationships empower the individuals involved in them. Care allows those who were initially immobilized to advance in the process of taking ownership of their struggle and, more generally, the direction of their lives.

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Caring Movements and Care in Movements

People join social movements when they see something is wrong, and they want to change it. In other words, grievances, defined as 'feelings of dissatisfaction with important aspects of life' (Klandermans et al., 2001), are a necessary condition for the appearance of social movements (Kern et al., 2015; Klandermans et al., 2001; van Stekelenburg & Klandermans, 2013). Students of contentious politics have generally agreed on this fact since the beginning of the discipline. Yet, their understanding of how individuals react to grievances and the process through which they motivate social action has evolved considerably. Exploring what previous scholarship has said about the effects of grievances and how people react to them will shed light on the three questions that guide this book: (1) Why do some aggrieved groups not mobilize to confront their oppression?, (2) Why does a group not affected by a grievance mobilize in solidarity with them?, and (3) What is the process through which these two collectives finally join forces?

For the economist Mancur Olson (1965), many aggrieved groups did not mobilize because they faced a 'collective action problem'. Olson, and many other scholars who applied a rational choice model to the study of society, assumed that individuals join collective activities following a cost/benefit logic. According to these early rational choice approaches, humans seek to maximize the limited time, energy, and money they have and will weigh their participation in collective action against the output they expect

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F. G. Santos, *Social Movements that Care*,
https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-031-74296-5_2

to obtain from their contribution. While large numbers are generally key for the success of a collective mobilization—particularly for matters that interest groups with limited access to economic resources and political power—, the participation of just one individual will not make a difference in whether a group is considered sufficiently large. Hence, although it requires some effort from each participant, their individual input does not create a substantial difference in the size of a protest. However, if collective action achieves its objective of social, political, and cultural change, everyone benefits regardless of whether they have contributed to its success. Hence, from the perspective of the collective action problem, people are discouraged from joining collective mobilizations because their individual participation does not make a considerable difference—nobody notices whether there is one person more or less at a big rally—and they will still enjoy the eventual fruits of the endeavor, if successful. For early rational choice theorists, this poses a challenge for protest organizers because people may 'free ride' on the outcome of mass mobilizations, obtaining the same gains as those who mobilized without having contributed to the effort.

Against this backdrop, a puzzle remained: Why, despite their incentives to 'free ride', did, a priori, rational individuals participate in collective activities such as protests? Olson posited that people joined collective action because they received 'selective incentives', rewards, and punishments that are not directly related to the outcome of a person's involvement in a movement but depend on whether they took part in it.

Despite criticism of rational choice models of mass mobilization from later literature (e.g., Ferree, 1992; Hirschman, 1984; Jasper, 1997; Ostrom, 1990; Pizzorno, 1986; Snow & McAdam, 2000), Olson points out a feature that most people would agree with: often people facing a grievance do not mobilize. However, through this book, I will try to convince the reader that, among the group of people affected by a problem who do not join collective endeavors to address their grievance, rational 'free riders' are a negligible minority. Most of those who are aggrieved, yet not mobilized, are not cost/benefit calculators who make a conscious decision to not participate in collective action because they anticipate that the efforts to contribute outweigh the possible wins at the precise moment. Instead, another much more likely explanation of what leads individuals not to engage in collective action seeking to redress their grievances is that they are people whose lives are too precarious to engage in any type of collective action. Those who benefit from the collective good of basic

social advances—such as an increase in the minimum salary, social housing, women and LGBTQ+ rights, more humane migration policies, etc.—without contributing to them are people who work double shifts to make ends meet; who need to care for their children or elders after work; or who are risking their lives trying to cross the Mediterranean sea in an overcrowded rubber dinghy. In the words of Piven and Cloward (1977, p. 3) participation in social movements 'is not freely available to all groups at all times, and much of the time it is not available to the lower-class groups at all. The occasions when protest is possible among 'the poor', the forms that it must take, and the impact it can have, are all delimited by the social structures in ways that usually diminish its extent and diminish its force'.

While socio-political structures may discourage lower-class groups from channeling their demands through contentious means, there are moments when these structures lose legitimacy or 'breakdown', opening windows of opportunity for mobilization (Snow et al., 1998). A prominent example of systemic breakdown, which is relevant to understanding the mobilizations studied in this book and many others, is the collapse of the financial system that started in 2008, which led to a global economic crisis and the questioning of socio-political structures across the world. These mass mobilizations pointed at a double crisis in the economy and political representation and criticized the influence of financial interests on institutional politics (Flesher Fominaya, 2020; Portos, 2021). From New York to Madrid, demonstrators claimed that they were 'the 99%' (as opposed to the 1% to which political decisions were geared) and that they were not 'merchandise of politicians and bankers'. In other words, the economic crisis started in 2008 led to a moment of breakdown when the legitimacy of the economic and political system was put into question, opening the opportunity for political mobilizations that placed at the center of the agenda the demands of groups that had been silenced by the established socio-political structures.

In contrast to early rational choice approaches, the political process theorists interpreted protests as the outcome of political struggles among groups with different interests, who could be more successful in influencing politics and society by mobilizing combined resources around particular opportunities. For Tilly, the development of nation-states and the process of industrialization paved the way for the appearance of mobilizations by organized groups displaying particular claims about the government (Tilly, 1986; Tilly et al., 1975). Inspired by this logic, McAdam highlighted the importance of political opportunity structures—access to

political institutions, divisions among elites, and changing levels of repression—, the capacity of organization of the aggrieved collective, and public support for the claims of the group, for the appearance of contentious collective action (McAdam, 1999 [1982]). In sum, mobilization was the outcome of a collective's capacity to mobilize people, money, and support, combined with their ability to seize openings in generally adverse sociopolitical structures.

While political process approaches have generated many fruitful advances as well as ample debate (see Goodwin & Jasper, 2004), two conclusions are particularly relevant for understanding the complexities of mobilization that I seek to tackle in this book. First, in line with Piven and Cloward's assertion (1977), they also highlight that there are plenty of reasons why individuals may not confront their grievances through political means. It may be the case that the conditions of the field are not conducive to their mobilization. In some cases, challengers may lack the political skills to make use of the opportunities available to them at a given moment. In others, avid incumbents may anticipate the opportunities that may arise for challengers and preemptively react to truncate their advantage (Fligstein & McAdam, 2015; Jasper, 2006).

Second, they point out that allies not affected by a grievance may perceive an opening of opportunities to advance the position of an oppressed group and mobilize in solidarity with them. Without exploring their capacity to initiate mobilization, some authors have referred to activists who contribute to the goals of a collective that, if achieved, will not benefit them directly as 'non-beneficiary constituents' (McCarthy & Zald, 1977). Hence, in addition to challengers and incumbents, non-beneficiary activists can become relevant actors in a field. As I show in the book, non-beneficiary constituents may even initiate. In recent years, we have witnessed a growing number of solidarity movements in support of refugees (e.g., Ataç et al., 2016; Della Porta, 2018), victims of transnational state violence (e.g., Nepstad, 2004, 2008; Russo, 2018), and animal rights (e.g., Einwohner, 2002; Munro, 2005; Pellow, 2014). Most members of these movements are not directly affected by the grievance confronted. Instead of mobilizing because they experience that form of oppression on their own skin, solidarity movements fight for the rights of another collective.

Solidarity, either to one's own group or to another, is a key factor in the appearance of social movements. It is crucial for the development of collective identities, commitment to the group, and mobilization more

generally (Fireman & Gamson, 1979; Hunt & Benford, 2004). For Melucci, solidarity is 'the ability of actors to recognize others, and to be recognized as belonging to the same social unit' (1996, p. 23). However, in this book, I follow a Durkheimian approach (cf. Durkheim, 1912; Hechter, 1987), and define solidarity as the willingness of actors to contribute private resources—time, energy, and money—to the collective ends of a group. Whereas Melucci's definition emphasizes recognition, the Durkheimian approach is centered on the contribution of private resources. While recognition does not necessarily translate into any observable behavior and may lead to confusion between the concepts of solidarity and collective identities, focusing on actual contributions facilitates mapping the mechanisms through which solidarity leads to contentious collective action.

Hunt and Benford (2004) differentiate between internal and external solidarity in terms of direct personal benefit from a cause. Internal solidarity takes place in relation to a group to which one belongs, while external solidarity is directed towards an external collective. In my interpretation of their work, internal solidarity is motivated by self-interest: the achievement of the collective aim is expected to result in a bettering of one's own position. In contrast, external solidarity requires empathy: people need to understand the position of the aggrieved group before contributing their private resources to somebody else's cause.

The Many Faces of Oppression and Solidarity

Given the variety of reactions to grievances, it is analytically relevant to categorize them. In Table 1, I divide reactions to grievances based on the possible responses from aggrieved and non-aggrieved individuals. Grievances may foster internal solidarity, external solidarity, immobility, or indifference.

Table 1 Reactions to grievances

	Affects one's group	*Affects another group*
Fosters solidarity	Internal solidarity	External solidarity
Hinders solidarity	Immobility	Indifference

Internal Solidarity

Some grievances spark a sense of groupness among those affected. Collectives triggered by internal solidarity do not necessarily engage in politics. Individuals may go through several stages of mobilization before joining a social movement. To engage in an activity, potential recruits need to first identify with the aims and tactics of the movement, be reached by mobilization attempts, and overcome barriers to engagement, such as finding the time and energy to participate (Klandermans & Oegema, 1987). Once individuals pass through these stages, it is more likely that they will develop a sense of solidarity with those facing the same circumstances, and participate in an initiative that addresses the grievances that affect them. This type of solidarity is the one that motivates most movements studied by contentious politics scholars: people joining forces to fight for their rights.

Immobility

Grievances may lead to immobility. Individuals' feelings and identities may complicate their identification with any non-conforming tactics with which most movements engage. Some emotions may obfuscate a person's engagement even if they are reached by mobilization attempts (Goodwin & Pfaff, 2003; Gould, 2009). It is also common that institutional and economic structures eliminate individuals' possibility to confront oppression, immobilizing them. For instance, migrants and refugees trying to cross the borders of the Global North to escape from poverty, climate disasters, and wars face barriers to contentious collective action stemming from their lack of political rights and geographic position. Not having the citizenship of the country to which they seek access and being located outside of its national borders makes self-interested political organizing practically impossible. A similar situation affects sweatshop workers. The complex outsourcing mechanisms of the garment industry create a context in which workers in the Global South have no possibilities to address the firm they are ultimately producing for. Beyond geographical reasons, as the headquarters of the firm are too far away to be reached, immobility may result from the fact that most sweatshop workers do not even know which company will finally sell the product of their labor. The offshoring context, lack of media attention, and limited access to political rights hamper the chances of workers in the producing countries to organize

politically. For instance, conflicting information given by state officials, doctors, and lawyers led residents of an Argentinian village surrounded by a petrochemical compound that was contaminating their area to doubt and even deny the impact of pollution in their lives, leading them to remain inactive in their defense of their environmental and health rights (Auyero & Swistun, 2009). Thus, even when grievances alone are not immobilizing, the context in which they occur may make them impossible to confront. For instance, conflicting information given by state officials, doctors, and lawyers led residents of an Argentinian village surrounded by a petrochemical compound that was contaminating their area to doubt and even deny the impact of pollution in their lives, leading them to remain inactive in their defense of their environmental and health rights (Auyero & Swistun, 2009).

External Solidarity

Some instances of oppression may foster the identification with an outgroup to such an extent that a person feels compelled to do something about the grievance of a collective they are not part of. According to Passy (2001), there are three overarching reasons why people may act for the benefit of others. First, from a rationalist perspective, external solidarity may originate from the immaterial benefits (e.g., self-esteem and personal connections) that individuals expect to receive from their involvement. Second, from a structuralist viewpoint, empathic solidarity may originate from the characteristics of the socio-political environment. The availability of resources—including funding, public opinion support, and a critical mass of people already involved in a movement—political opportunities, and personal networks may encourage individuals to act collectively for a cause from which they will not benefit directly but that gives them higher chances of success. Finally, from a culturalist standpoint, solidarity towards an outgroup may originate from values, identities, and processes of socialization. At the individual level, activists develop morals that lead them to place importance on defending the rights of others (Mayton & Furnham, 1994; Vecchione et al., 2015). Beyond ideology, religious motivations may also encourage believers' mobilization to alleviate others' suffering (Nepstad, 2004; Russo, 2018). From a societal perspective, economic security changes the values of a community, which starts giving more importance to immaterial issues (Inglehart, 1977). These changes have affected the topics around which groups who enjoy a certain economic

status mobilize (Kriesi et al., 1995; Melucci, 1989). For similar reasons, people whose material needs are met may act to improve the status of others who do not share their prosperity.

Coalitions among oppressed and more privileged collectives have always been common in social movements. Previous scholarship has referred to people mobilized by external solidarity with several terms, such as 'non-beneficiary constituents' (McCarthy & Zald, 1977), 'allies' (Messner et al., 2015; Myers, 2008), 'privileged outsiders' (Munkres, 2008), and 'solidarity activists' (Russo, 2018; Sundberg, 2007). Some examples of this type of mobilization include migrant solidarity groups (Della Porta, 2018; Russo, 2018), men in the feminist movement (Messner et al., 2015), white people in the civil rights movement (McAdam, 1986, 1988), and people from the global north mobilizing against sweatshops in the global south (Bartley & Child, 2011, 2014; Prasad et al., 2004), among many other instances.

Indifference

The most common social reaction towards an external grievance is indifference. The world is full of examples of groups suffering from oppression and a disregard for the situation they are facing from most of the population. In some cases, indifference may originate in ignorance about the situation of those facing the specific trouble. In others, external actors may be aware of the aggrieving situation but consider it none of their business. Yet, in other cases, people may empathize with the aggrieved collective, but their empathy does not lead them to any action, resulting, de facto, in their indifference.

Two Sides of the Same Coin

From the perspective of mobilization, those who are immobilized by their grievances and those who experience external solidarity are often two sides of the same coin. When individuals are immobilized by their grievances, they will not use the opportunities they may have to advance their position through contentious collective action. Despite having common problems and adversaries, their overwhelming grievances prevent them from collaborating with others to confront incumbents. Under these circumstances, the mobilization of more privileged outsiders in solidarity with them has transformative potential. In these cases, solidarity mobilization

addresses issues that would not be tackled otherwise because the aggrieved collective is immobilized. When the grievances of a group prevent them from building the necessary internal solidarity to act or the location of the groups strips them of their influence, the intervention of external groups may give them the strength they lack initially.

Clearly, solidarity mobilizations generate tensions and contradictions. An evident one is how to delineate the difference between transformative political action, commonly associated with social movements and other more vertical assistance-based logics often associated with charitable activities. As I elaborate below, a key difference lies in the vocation of empowerment of the affected collective, which should ultimately be able to take ownership of the struggle.

These dynamics present some puzzles that are worth exploring. What are the reasons for which commonly aggrieved individuals do not collaborate among themselves to confront their oppression? Why do some groups mobilize for the rights of others, sometimes even going through considerable discomfort? What is the result when these two types of collectives meet each other? In what follows, I build on the debates surrounding the ethics of care to explain how immobilizing grievances destroy internal solidarity, how external solidarity fosters mobilization, and how internal solidarity can be constructed through social movement engagement.

The Politics of Care: Immobility, Empathy, and Mobilization

Care is 'a species activity that includes everything that we do to maintain, continue, and repair our "world" so that we can live in it as well as possible. That world includes our bodies, our selves, and our environment' (Tronto, 2013, p. 19; see also Fisher & Tronto, 1990, p. 40; Tronto, 1993, p. 103). It consists of 'attending to and meeting the needs of the particular others for whom we take responsibility' (Held, 2006, p. 10), including protecting ourselves and others from 'extraordinary incursions of violence or other forms of disruption into our daily lives' (Tronto, 1993, p. 104). In this way, to have political meaning, care must consist of a relational action that goes beyond the act of thinking. From the perspective of care, mobilization originating from empathic and immobilizing grievances follows two distinct processes.

Solidarity Mobilization Through the Politics of Care

In what follows, I provide the basis of a model of solidarity mobilizations. This approach bridges previous efforts to develop a strategic interaction model of the original political process approach (Choi-Fitzpatrick, 2017) and the work developed on the ethics of care (Tronto, 1993, 2013). As a relational logic of action, caring can be conceptualized as a four-step process (Tronto, 1993, 2013). Any caring relationship starts with a person or collective *caring about* another. During this first step, attentiveness is key to noticing the unmet needs of another person or group. Second, it is necessary to take responsibility to address the identified need, *caring for* the other individual or group. Third, one needs to be competent to address the need and *give care*. Finally, the collective or person *receives the care* and responds to it. A summary of the process of solidarity mobilization is presented in Fig. 1.

Attentiveness: Caring About

The process of mobilization starts when a person or a group recognizes the existence of a need that should be met. In other words, mobilization starts with the recognition that care is necessary. I call this group *solidarity early-risers*. I define solidarity early-risers as individuals who create an organization or initiate a cycle of mobilization but will not benefit directly from achieving the movement's goals. Solidarity early-risers are different from beneficiary social movement entrepreneurs because they are not expected to profit directly from the achievement of the organizational goals. They are also different from 'non-beneficiary constituents' and 'conscience adherents' (McCarthy & Zald, 1977) because, unlike these two, solidarity early-risers are not followers who join a contentious cycle that is already ongoing. Rather, solidarity early-risers initiate mobilization motivated by their empathy towards another collective. Tronto argues that this first step calls for 'a suspension of their self-interest and assuming



Fig. 1 The process of solidarity mobilization

the position of another person or group to recognize the need' (Tronto, 2013, p. 34).

Responsibility: Caring For

After the detection of the need, solidarity early-risers assess the situation in the field and the threats and opportunities related to confronting the grievance of the oppressed collective through contentious collective action. If the attribution of the conditions of the field seems favorable, solidarity early-risers will assume responsibility for addressing the identified needs. Caring for, in the context of social movements, requires the recognition that the roots of the unmet needs are political—or at least that there is a political solution to the grievance—, and that collective action is needed to address these issues. This is the moment when solidarity early-risers decide to start organizing. At this stage, solidarity early-risers activate their networks and attempt to mobilize the resources needed to initiate mobilization.

Competence: Caregiving

After assuming responsibility, solidarity early-risers start efforts to enter into contact with the aggrieved and immobilized collective, and caregiving begins. This process is iterative. After initiating collective action, activists constantly reevaluate their strategies and innovate. It may be that the initial tactics do not work to address the identified need and a new period of strategizing starts. This new process requires again attentiveness to the needs of the aggrieved collective, updated expectations based on initial errors, taking responsibility for revising former tactics and implementing the new caregiving strategy. It may also happen that, after the initiation of caring relationships, more caring needs are detected. This situation, again, starts a new process of care and strategizing.

Previous understandings of care assumed that, during a care relation, there is a person or group that provides care, the 'one-caring' and another that receives it, the 'cared-for' (Noddings, 1986). Even if these two roles can sometimes be differentiated—particularly in isolated, one-off interactions—, it is common that a caring relation among activists is reciprocal, and all groups take on both roles. Sometimes reciprocity can be sequential, with the caring roles exchanged at a certain point. On other occasions, both parties care for and are cared for at the same time.

Certain scholars have presented organizations as a locus that provides the conditions for care to happen, but not as agents who give care

(Noddings, 2015). However, from a social movement's perspective, a community of people can be on both sides of the caring relationship. Indeed, there are circumstances when care is successful precisely because a collective is involved in the act of caring, and its influence cannot be equated only with the aggregation of individual care relations. For instance, an eviction blockade is an act of care in which activists engage in civil resistance to address the need of a family for a dignified living. This act of care cannot be divided into individual relationships, as the involvement of each individual alone would have a negligible effect outside the group and care would not be successful. Neither does a single person block a definable part of eviction. Rather, the foreclosure is prevented as a whole by the group. It may even be the case that the eviction is blocked precisely due to the legitimacy that an organization has earned over years of activity, and the same people would have not been able to prevent the eviction had they been part of another collective. In this way, many care-inspired contentious collective actions are successful precisely because the organization cares.

Responsiveness: Care Receiving

Once care activities have taken place, the person or group that has been cared for reacts to the interaction. The response can simply be the acknowledgment that care has—or has not—been successful. Besides, new caring needs may arise as a response to the previous needs being covered. For care to be considered political, the person or group that has received the care should evolve in the direction of taking ownership of their struggle. This characteristic is what determines the sometimes-thin difference between whether care relationships take place in the realm of contentious politics, or through assistance-based activities. On the micro-level, members who have been exposed to care will gradually become more involved in the activities of the organization and participate in more types of actions. Once part of the caring needs of the person or group have been met, they may reproduce some of the caring activities received, and support others that are passing through a similar situation to the one they have overcome.

On the meso-level, the organization evaluates the outcomes of the mobilization, strategizing, and adapting to new scenarios and knowledge. The process of care may open the door to the inclusion of new actions in the repertoire of the group, which were previously out of reach for its constituency. Additionally, once certain caring needs are addressed or are deemed impossible to tackle, new needs may arise, leading to innovations

in the repertoire, or even the appearance of new social movement organizations. As I show in the next chapter, as a reaction to being unable to block many evictions, PAH included house occupations in its repertoire. On the other hand, after PAH had successfully obtained numerous social rents for its members, the Alliance against Energy Poverty (APE by its Spanish acronym) was created to fight for access to affordable utilities for those who could now afford a house, but not the utilities needed for a dignified life.

Finally, at the macro-level, mobilization may influence the behavior of the incumbent, translating care relations into public policies and legislation, as well as the culture and norms of the field. For example, PAH has managed to influence changes to housing laws in five regions in Spain (Martínez, 2019), as well as on the national level.

Immobilizing Grievances and Mobilization

When somebody is immobilized by a grievance, we can say that this person is unavailable to participate in contentious politics because they face structural, biographical, and/or personal needs that hamper their mobilization. Structural availability refers to the degree to which somebody is connected to social networks that facilitate access to information about mobilization opportunities (Barkan et al., 1993; Snow et al., 1980). Several studies have shown that one of the strongest predictors of engagement in protests is having been asked to participate (Klandermans, 1997; Klandermans & Oegema, 1987; McAdam & Paulsen, 1993). Some grievances destroy individuals' family and personal networks. For instance, it is common that mortgage problems break individuals' support circles. Difficulties meeting mortgage installments may be either the consequence or the source of family conflicts. Divorce often consists of lengthy and costly processes, and entails one of the partners leaving the place of residence. In this way, it may complicate paying their debts, and the leaving party may decide to stop paying their share of the mortgage. Conversely, financial problems may be the source of arguments and family separations. In addition to family relationships, financial problems may affect one's circle of friends. Taking part in social activities generally requires money, so when somebody becomes poor, it is common for the person to cut some or all social gatherings. This happens partly due to financial reasons, and partly because of the shame of admitting to others that one is facing economic problems. Finally, the reduction of free time due to job precariousness and the gig

economy forces individuals to reduce any other activities. Hence, acute grievances may destroy any previous support networks that those aggrieved had.

Moreover, even if a person has networks and is aware of social movement initiatives addressing their need, grievances may make the people they affect biographically unavailable. Biographical availability refers to the absence of responsibilities that limit one's capacity to dedicate time to activism (Beyerlein & Hipp, 2006; McAdam, 1986). Certain grievances are so acute that they affect the lives of those suffering them beyond the bounds of the problem they directly create. When a person loses their job, cannot pay for their mortgage and a bank starts foreclosure procedures against them, the problems that they face go well beyond unemployment and the risk of homelessness. The stress and anxiety may make them psychologically and physically ill (Ramis-Pujol, 2013). Unemployment and the need to meet monthly installments may lead people to become part of the 'gig economy' (Friedman, 2014) or the black market, accepting small, low-paid, and unstable jobs. Under this situation, people may become a 'working poor' (Andreß & Lohmann, 2008; Newman, 2009). They may have several jobs to which they have to dedicate their whole day, having no time or energy for anything else, and still not be able to make ends meet. Hence, some individuals who had time, energy, and money to engage in social movements before being aggrieved become biographically unavailable because they are immobilized by their troubles. In sum, grievances may be so destabilizing that create a situation in which those aggrieved have no time or energy to dedicate to anything beyond making it to the end of the day.

Finally, I suggest that besides structural and biographical availability, studies take into account *personal availability*. Personal availability refers to the degree to which emotional, self-identity, and knowledge constraints pose barriers to participation in some or all movement activities. Certain emotions, including shame, guilt, and fear, discourage interaction with others and participation in public actions (Goodwin & Pfaff, 2003; Gould, 2009; Jasper, 2018). Additionally, research has shown that feelings such as anger, suspicion, and hostility are often required before somebody can relocate blame from themselves to external actors (Goodwin et al., 2001). Hence, aggrieved collectives often need to overcome the emotions that immobilize them and develop new ones that encourage dissent (Flam, 2005). For example, as Gould (2009, p. 32) explains, the AIDS Coalition to Unleash Power (ACT UP) needed to change the 'embodied, axiomatic

inclinations toward certain feelings and ways of emoting' of queer communities in the 1980s before they gathered the strength to organize one of the biggest cycles of protests of the LGBTQ+ movement in the United States. Furthermore, as the day-to-day running of organizations involves dealing with internal conflicts and setbacks, activists constantly need to engage in emotion management (Effler, 2010).

Regarding self-perceptions, organizations can encourage members to improve the way they see themselves. Low self-esteem, low impressions of self-efficacy, and perceptions of unauthenticity lead individuals to avoid participating in social movement activities (Gecas, 2000). Against this backdrop, activists engage in identity work (Snow & McAdam, 2000) seeking to foster politicized identities (Simon & Klandermans, 2001; Snow & McAdam, 2000), which encourage participation in social movements. For instance, Viterna (2013) maps how, during El Salvador's civil war (1980–1992), the identities of women who joined the FMLN guerrillas evolved based on their roles and the people they interacted with, and how these dynamics affected the tasks they subsequently performed.

Finally, individuals with higher levels of formal education and more civic skills are better able to participate in politics (Verba et al., 1995). Members with more education and skills participate with greater frequency (Oliver, 1984), have greater commitment to their organization (Baggetta et al., 2013), and are more likely to take leadership positions (Han, 2014). Moreover, in order to mobilize, individuals need to understand the source of their grievances and ways to confront them (McAdam, 1999 [1982], p. 51). For example, Auyero and Swistun (2009) linked the inaction of an Argentine community surrounded by a petrochemical compound that was contaminating their area to the conflicting information they were receiving from lawyers, doctors, and state officials, which led them to deny and doubt about the impact that pollution had on their lives.

Recruitment and Passive Beneficiary Engagement

There are numerous ways in which social movement organizations seek to recruit participants, even those immobilized by their grievances. Activists try to make the most of their movement's mobilization potential through mobilization attempts that go beyond organizational and personal ties (Klandermans & Oegema, 1987). Mass media, poster hanging, direct mail, and social media are some of the most common venues for this. However, despite the influence of these technologies in diffusing

information, personal, trusted networks are still key for participation, particularly in cases of high-risk activism (Onuch, 2015).

Sometimes immobilized individuals may finally contact a social movement out of desperation. As I discuss in the next chapter, many people trapped in their mortgages approached PAH as a last resort. They had tried all other available options to address their grievance, and when there were no more possibilities, reached out to PAH. Some of these people knew about the organization from the news, the Internet, or because somebody else had told them about it. Others discovered PAH's existence because the organization was organizing a bank protest while they were going to their bank office in yet another attempt to explain that they wanted, but were unable, to repay their debt.

People who are immobilized by their grievances often join an organization as *passive beneficiaries*. Passive beneficiaries are people who join a social movement organization through an assistance-based logic, hoping that somebody else will solve their problems for them As skillfully observed by Gaventa (1982) in his study of quiescence and rebellion in the Clear Fork Valley of Central Appalachia, United States, communities and individuals can remain quiescent even in the face of severe exploitation and injustice, with their passivity stemming from their powerlessness. This powerlessness, Gaventa argues, may originate from a number of factors, including internalization of power dynamics and dominant ideologies by marginalized groups; lack of awareness of the systemic and structural nature of their oppression; immobilizing emotions such as fear and resignation; and limited social cohesion and solidarity within the oppressed collective.

Despite approaching a social movement organization seeking to be aided without contributing to the collective goals, passive beneficiaries have already taken the step of joining it—or at least some of its actions—, but they are not yet ready to contribute to the group. Some of them may go to an assembly to gather information about how to approach their grievance individually. Others may arrive at the organization through personal networks but not be convinced about joining it and take some time attending some activities without taking an active stance. There are many examples of PAH activists who would go to its assemblies for several months without saying a word or interacting with anyone. Even if they have managed to overcome certain structural and biographical barriers, and have been (partially) recruited, these people are still personally unavailable to participate in any activity and remain passive. Commonly, passive

beneficiaries do not have previous activism experiences, as first-timers are more likely than veteran protesters to experience fear (Klandermans et al., 2008), not identify as activists (Fantasia, 1988), and not have the skills that facilitate participation in politics (Han, 2014). Yet, through organizational activities and rituals aimed at empowering members, passive beneficiaries may be encouraged to become more engaged and contribute to the collective.

The Dual Process of Empowerment

Through their participation as passive beneficiaries, individuals start to be exposed to dynamics of care that contribute to their empowerment. From the perspective of mobilization in the context of social movements, empowerment can be conceptualized as increasing the structural, biographical, and personal availability of individuals and communities (Santos, 2023). Organizations foster participation by reaching potential recruits beyond their networks, coordinating some of their alternative commitments, and building skills and knowledge that are useful for joining in their activities. They also encourage their members to reflect on their actions and perceive themselves as competent and efficacious, as well as to experience activating emotions. The process of empowerment is not linear (Christens, 2019). Individuals and groups may successfully evolve in gaining control over some of their affairs and not others, advance in the opposite direction of the one intended, reevaluate their experiences, and adapt their strategies.

I argue that the process of empowerment takes place on two levels. First, at the individual level, people may make conscious efforts to gain control over their affairs and help the organization advance its goals. For instance, individuals can learn new skills by themselves or engage in 'emotion work' to suppress immobilizing emotions such as shame and fear (Goodwin & Pfaff, 2003). Given the structural challenges that people immobilized by their grievances face, it is unlikely that the individual level of empowerment will achieve the desired outcome with the second collective level.

Second, at the organizational level, organizations can also contribute to the empowerment of their members. Some rituals and dynamics have an empowering effect on individuals, who develop activating emotions, positive self-concepts, and learn new skills. In the case of PAH, other research has already pointed the importance of these dynamics. For instance, Di

Feliciantonio (2017) shows how dismantling the 'neoliberal model of "personal responsibilization"' (p. 40) contributes to tackling emotions such as self-blame and moving away from identities related to failure and isolation, opening the possibility to other identifications with the community (pp. 48–49). Similarly, García-Lamarca (2017) highlights how the knowledge and skills that PAH members build 'from below' contribute to their development as political subjects.

A common way in which organizations foster the empowerment of their members is through what I term a system of incremental engagement. This system has three key components: participation opportunities that are accessible to members through the different stages of their involvement, the communal celebration of individual and collective successes, and organizational education.

Easily accessible activism opportunities often consist of activities that newcomers have engaged in the past and that represent their first contribution to organizational goals. Because newcomers face additional barriers to participate in social movements (Verhulst & Walgrave, 2009), activism opportunities that consist of activities that people have performed previously may represent a milestone for their involvement at the early stages of their activist careers. These initial activities may consist of introducing themselves to the rest of the group during a meeting or helping to clean the assembly space. Organizations may also increase the accessibility of some tasks. For instance, they may provide templates that ease members' formal interactions with incumbents, such as requesting a debt cancellation from a bank or a legal recourse lawyer from the court. Already during these first involvements, members are exposed to ideological socialization, experience activating emotions, and build ties with other peers, which encourage them to continue their engagement. Furthermore, the new skills learned and the period of socialization while doing these initial tasks allow members to be available to engage in new types of activities that may have not been previously accessible.

Second, as part of the process of incremental engagement, the appreciation of members' contributions as well as the celebration of individual and collective achievements is key to empowerment. People's perceptions of self-efficacy increase when their contributions are recognized by their peers. Moreover, the celebration of success encourages members to perceive themselves as well as the collective as efficacious actors who are able to advance their goals. Perceptions of success are also subject to members' availability. Achieving the same tasks may be perceived as something

mundane for an experienced member and great progress for a more novice one. Hence, seemingly smaller objectives that, nevertheless, may represent milestones for their members should also be celebrated.

Finally, organizations may also expand their members' knowledge, and skills needed to contribute to their activities. Training and informal coaching programs among activists during actions are common ways to build skills. In addition to the increased efficacy brought by the new knowledge, the fact that the organization dedicates resources to increase members' impact encourages them to feel that their contributions are important, increasing their perceptions of self-efficacy and generating activating emotions towards the group and the cause. Furthermore, knowledge and skills allow members to be available for more complex tasks. This personal evolution contributes to the empowerment of the organization and other members for two reasons. First, it allows members to perform more complex tasks and take on leadership roles. Second, it liberates accessible tasks for other newcomers to take over, letting them continue in their process of empowerment. These two processes combined allow the organization to grow.

This being said, it should be noted that the process of empowerment is not one directional. Members may struggle with some facets of the process, experience burnout (Gorski et al., 2019) and disengage partly or totally from the group. Also, other alternative commitments may appear in their lives, leaving them less or no time for politics (Hirschman, 1977). There are also instances when organizational schemes may empower individuals in a different course than the one originally expected, not have an effect, or disempower their members. Hence, empowerment consists of constant interactions where activists with different degrees of experience continually strategize, reflect on their actions, and adapt their tactics while learning in the process.

An empowerment approach to mobilization highlights that this process is relational, strategic, and dynamic. It is relational because empowerment takes place through interactions among members and organizational rituals. It is strategic because it depends on the individual and organizational efforts and tactics to foster engagement, which are periodically evaluated and adapted. Finally, it is dynamic because it underscores that mobilization and empowerment are not steady but, rather, take place at different paces, while there may be periods of advancement, steadiness, and setbacks.

Care Work in Social Movement Organizations

Care work is crucial for the creation of solidarity among immobilized individuals and their sustained mobilization. While care relations take place among members of any group, care is particularly important for collectives that rely on voluntary contributions from their members, such as social movement organizations. The strategic interaction between incumbents and challengers that takes place during any contentious mobilization happens generally during a long period. Moreover, it is difficult to anticipate the outcome of the interaction until the process nears its end. While many of the costs and risks of movement participation, as well as the personal constraints, are real at early stages of people's involvement in a collective, the political rewards are uncertain and far in time. Under these conditions, encouraging participation becomes a challenge, and hypothetical political changes are often insufficient motivation, particularly when oppression is acute. As I argue in this book, care relationships among activists are key to the sustained mobilization of the group.

Care work refers to activists' efforts to address the needs of other members, as well as their own, and to sustain social relationships. These interactions increase solidarity engagement by making individuals more structurally, biographically, and personally available to participate in organizational activities. Most of the care work that takes place in movements happens through 'interaction rituals' (IRs, Collins, 2004). During IRs, a group of people are assembled in the same place, sharing a focus of attention as well as a mutual awareness of each other's concentration. From this perspective, I divide the activities of any collective can be divided into two categories of IRs. First, there are IRs where only organizational members are allowed to participate. Assemblies, meetings, workshops, as well as the informal gatherings fit within this group. It is common that, in addition to strategic discussions and preparations that take place during these IRs, activists also care for each other. For instance, most movement organizations have speaking rules during assemblies, which, in addition to being aimed at maintaining structured discussions, also to facilitate the participation of less outgoing members. Likewise, the framing used by movement leaders during their interventions has both the objective of preparing for the next strategic interactions, and promoting specific emotions and identities, especially during periods when these are under challenge. Moreover, some organizations even have rituals that are specifically directed towards care work. Some groups develop spaces of emotional and even

psychotherapeutic support for those who need it (Gould, 2009; Stuart, 2020; Taylor, 1996), and most movements organize workshops during which members learn skills in order to contribute better to the movement.

The second category consists of IRs in which outsiders participate either as objects of claims, bystanders, or active participants. These rituals are the public activities of any movement. All public IRs also have a caring component, as they are either called to meet some of the needs of the movement constituency or are organized in a way that facilitates participation. For instance, the main objective of an eviction blockade is to defend the right to adequate housing for a family at risk of eviction. However, eviction blockades also facilitate organizational participation as they reduce the life risks that members face, allowing them to dedicate more of their time to the movement. Additionally, eviction blockades generate activating emotions such as hope and confidence, and they increase perceptions of self-efficacy, as members see that participation in the organization can solve their concrete needs. Care work also takes place when public actions are organized in a way that facilitates the participation of movement members: The music and songs performed during a march are aimed at generating a festive dynamic that motivates protestors; members from the same organization gather together before a demonstration so nobody is left alone; etc.

Besides, care can happen as an outcome of IRs, generating more informal caring relations among specific individuals. The continuous repetition of the gathering of bodies with a shared focus of attention fosters feelings of solidarity that go beyond specific rituals. For instance, sharing important victories or suffering repression together creates strong bonds between activists. As a result, individuals develop relationships that lead them to care for each other in more informal ways than the staged rituals created by the organization. As I explore the case of PAH, in organizations where in-group solidarity is particularly cherished, members are socialized to care for members they have not encountered yet. For instance, the feminist movement has developed slogans such as 'Women supporting women' or 'I believe you',[1] whose aim is to foster solidarity among women,

[1] This slogan has appeared in feminist campaigns during public accusations and trials of rape and sexual assault when the credibility of a woman has been called into question by the jury. For instance, this occurred during the hearings of Judge Brett Kavanaugh's nomination to the Supreme Court in the US (Stolberg, 2018), and a trial over the gang rape of a woman in Spain (Belaza, 2018).

even if they do not know each other. I discuss this issue throughout the book, particularly in Chapters "The Origins of PAH: Empathy and Solidarity Mobilization" and "From Immobilized to Empowered: Beneficiary Mobilization in PAH".

Emotional Care

Emotional Care refers to the interactions among activists that confront immobilizing emotions and generate 'high emotional energy'. High emotional energy is 'a feeling of confidence and enthusiasm for social interaction […] It includes feelings of what is right and wrong, moral and immoral' (Collins, 2004, pp. 108–109). High emotional energy makes people feel more confident, enthusiastic, and proactive. Individuals who participate in such interaction feel good about themselves and have a sense of connection and solidarity with the group (Ibid.). These are the kinds of feelings that have been shown to motivate participation in social movements (Goodwin et al., 2001; Jasper, 2011, 2018; Klandermans et al., 2008). Beyond the organizational and strategic discussions that take place during assemblies, the interactions and language in these spaces also aim at reiterating a construction of reality in accordance with the framing of the movement. For instance, it is common that identity-based movements develop processes to convert feelings of shame about one's identity into pride (Britt & Heise, 2000; Gould, 2001, 2009). On other occasions, a focus may be on overcoming depression through self-help groups (Taylor, 1996). More generally, an important part of the framing developed during internal meetings aims to create feelings of injustice, placing guilt on external incumbent actors instead of individuals, and generating hope and confidence among movement members.

Organizational rituals of emotional care translate into relations of emotional care among individuals. High emotional energy fosters solidarity among those who participate in the same IR (Collins, 2004). This feeling of solidarity, in turn, encourages members to care for each other outside these rituals. These actions are not something that is expected from all movement members and depend to a large extent on the character of each individual, as well as personal affinities. Some people are better able to detect whether another person has a particularly low emotional energy at a given moment, and then respond accordingly. Likewise, personal emotional care is more likely to occur within organizational subgroups who spend more time together, or who have closer relations for other reasons.

While the rituals developed within a movement target those who probably have a greater need for that type of care, every member of the collective is emotionally cared for through personal interactions. For instance, exchanges of emotional care contribute to avoiding burnout, which is generally suffered by those in, or close to, leadership positions (Gordon, 2017; Strang & Jung, 2005).

Identity Care

Identity care refers to the organizational efforts to maintain and repair members' self-concepts and collective identities. Identity care targeted at members' self-concepts encourages them to become active agents in their struggle. According to Gecas, there are three motivations for action that originate from the self-concept, he refers to them as self-esteem, self-efficacy, and authenticity (Gecas, 1982, 1991). Self-esteem refers to 'the motivation to view oneself favorably and to act in such a way as to maintain (protect) or increase a favorable view of oneself' (Gecas, 1986, p. 138). Self-efficacy is 'the motivation to perceive oneself as a causal agent in the environment' (Gecas, 1986, p. 139). Finally, authenticity is the assessment of 'whether the various identities constituting the self-concept are meaningful and 'real' to the individual' (Gecas, 1986, p. 141). According to Gecas, 'by virtue of having a self-concept the individual is motivated to maintain a favorable assessment of it, to conceive of self as efficacious and consequential, and to experience it as meaningful and real' (Gecas, 2000, p. 101). Scholars have already observed that the interactions that take place in social movements, as well as the exchanges among activists, trigger psychological processes that may lead to changes in members' self-concepts (Kiecolt, 2000). I borrow Geca's typology to highlight three components of what I term self-identity care. The first component involves improving members' self-esteem and overcoming the social stigma internalized by many marginalized communities. Low self-esteem and internalized social stigmas act as a constraint to movement participation (Gecas, 2000), even after a member has been recruited into an organization. Hence, improving members' self-esteem encourages them to contribute to the group and to innovate (Ibid.). The second component seeks to increase members' perception of self-efficacy. In order to contribute better to the activities of the movement and to take ownership of their personal struggle, individuals need to see themselves as competent and efficacious. Some scholars have referred to this as the acquisition of

'activist identities' (Fantasia, 1988; Kelly & Breinlinger, 1996). This component is of special importance for disempowered groups that have been socialized as passive subjects through social shaming or dependence on social services and charity organizations to cover their most basic needs. Finally, the third component has the goal of encouraging members to experience themselves as authentic and meaningful. Participation is fostered if members experience themselves as unique individuals who are appreciated by their peers for who they are, and whose actions are in line with their acquired identities.

In addition to self-identity care, members, and organizations can perform collective identity care. Collective identity care encourages members to see their peers as part of the same social unit and to relate to the group, its image, and its attributes. A collective identity is 'the shared definition of a group that derives from its members' common interests and solidarity' (Taylor, 1989, p. 771). Aggrieved individuals are often socialized into discourses that justify their oppression, presenting their situation as a personal failure rather than a structural problem (Di Feliciantonio, 2017; Gibson-Graham, 1996, 2006). These discourses complicate identification and solidarity with others facing similar circumstances. Moreover, this type of framing favors the achievement of individualized answers instead of collective solutions, as individuals do not want to associate themselves with other people sharing similar stigmatized identities.

Collective identity care results from activists' efforts to develop collective identities among the movement's base, and consists of providing members with a community of shared values, where participants feel accepted and identify as peers. Encouraging actions of mutual support contributes to the development of collective identities. As Taylor (1996, p. 19) explains, 'a sense of solidarity derives from the strong emotional bonds, empathy, unconditional acceptance, and support networks that form between people by virtue of helping each other understand and cope with problems overlooked by existing social institutions'. When members of a movement enjoy this sense of solidarity and become aware of the commonalities in their struggles and goals, they develop a 'cognitive, moral, and emotional connection' (Ibid.) with the community they have shared this process with. One way in which organizations make this happen is by creating 'free spaces' (Evans, 1979; Evans & Boyte, 1986; Polletta, 1999). Free spaces are 'small-scale settings within a community or movement that are removed from the direct control of dominant groups, are voluntarily participating in, and generate the cultural

challenge that precedes or accompanies political mobilization' (Polletta, 1999, p. 1). In these spaces, members develop counterhegemonic frames that point to structural factors and incumbent actors as the source of oppression, facilitating the appearance of collective identities and internal solidarity.

Participatory Care

Participatory Care refers to efforts to facilitate participation in the activities of the movement. Among all the actions that are part of the repertoire of a movement, not all are equally accessible for certain groups. In some cases, due to socialization, personality, duties towards other persons, lack of previous activist experience or, simply, age and health, some people may consider that certain forms of activism are not suitable for them. In these situations, participatory care consists of developing a repertoire of contention whose threshold of mobilization allows social movement members to participate. For instance, older people or parents may prefer not to engage in high-risk activism because of their health conditions or their concerns about being able to fulfil their responsibilities towards their children, in cases of arrest or physical damage. Participatory care entails making sure that the action organized to achieve an objective is as accessible as possible to the movement's base.

Organizations may ease participation in their activities by lowering the costs of taking part in them. This is what Han (2014) calls 'transactional mobilizing', which entails making participation as easy as possible. SMOs may reduce the amount of time and energy that their members need to dedicate to perform a task by using different tools. For instance, during a letter-writing campaign, some organizations may provide templates to their members, so they do not have to write the letters themselves if they prefer not to do so. Organizations may also internalize the costs that their members need to pay for taking part in an activity. Sometimes, organizational resources are used to pay for travel to an important meeting or to provide buses to join a demonstration that takes place far away. Reducing the expenses of participation is of particular importance for 'poor people's movements' (Piven & Cloward, 1977), as even small expenses may act as a barrier for those from less-privileged backgrounds.

Another way in which organizations may provide participatory care is through building knowledge and skills among its members. Social movements offer plenty of opportunities for their members to learn new

information and skills, to confront their struggle and contribute to the collective. One common way in which learning is organized may be through formalized training programs such as workshops about how to engage in civil disobedience or use Twitter. Education may also take place in a more informal manner, such as exchanges of information among activists and coaching during actions.

Involvement may also be facilitated by mitigating the risks of participation. Before an action takes place, organizations may include plans to lower the risk of repression. Some examples of this include clearly assigning roles so every member knows what to do and who to turn to in case of need. Additionally, many groups organize training programs on civil resistance to teach members how to behave when confronting authorities with as little risk as possible. Moreover, many SMOs plan their risky actions with the legal code in mind and look for ways that would categorize their behavior as wrongdoings of lesser punishment. Risks can also be mitigated while the action takes place. For instance, commitment to non-violence lowers the probability of violent confrontations with police authorities (Chenoweth & Stephan, 2011). Finally, collectives can reduce the risks of taking part in an action by ensuring that their members will be taken care of in case hazards become a reality. When somebody is taken to the police station from a demonstration, it is common that activists organize protests at the police station to demand the release of their peer, while they provide free legal support to those experiencing legal and police repression. It is also common for these groups to collectivize the payment of fines with organizational resources.

In addition to addressing the expenses and dangers associated with participation in organizational activities, SMOs may also foster participation by reducing the costs and risks that members face in their lives. Many organizations help to coordinate some of their members' alternative commitments so they can dedicate more time to activism. For instance, in addition to putting the problems of malnutrition that many African American communities faced, the Black Panther's free breakfast program facilitated the participation of black people in their activities by taking care of black parents' need to feed their families (Cleaver & Katsiaficas, 2001). As I elaborate further in this book, beyond protecting members' right to housing, PAH's eviction blockades and house occupations also give certainty to members by assuring that even if they are facing the hazard of homelessness, the organization will assure that they and their families will always have a roof to sleep under.

Finally, participatory care covers all the actions developed so the rest of the organizational activities can happen. These arrangements range from cleaning the space where meetings and assemblies take place, to buying materials for making banners, as well as providing food during a long protest. This part of care is what some authors have referred to as the invisible labor of community organizing (Daniels, 1987; Stall & Stoecker, 1998), as these activities require extensive work within a movement, but are normally eclipsed by the more public performances of the group. They are also activities in which women tend to have a greater presence than men, who prioritize engagement in more visible types of action (Stall & Stoecker, 1998). For these reasons, the distribution of roles in relation to these activities may reproduce existing patterns of gender and racial inequalities. Against this backdrop, participatory care also entails turning visible and managing these dynamics, seeking to assure a more just distribution of duties.

A Holistic Understanding of Care Work

Although care can be divided into types for analytical purposes, it is a process that takes place in a holistic way. The boundaries between categories are often unclear and different processes of care are in constant interaction, reinforcing each other. Emotional care contributes to the development of collective identities and to changes in the self-concept of activists. Vice versa, collective identities foster solidarity with newcomers and facilitate unconscious interactions of emotional caring. Additionally, when childcare is coordinated within the assembly, or a bus is organized by the movement to attend a demonstration, activists develop collective identities and solidarity with each other. Further, the identification of an experienced member with a newcomer from the same organization may also encourage greater attention to this specific person during training where several groups participate. Sometimes researchers have simplified the complexity of these processes, obscuring these interactions. None of the categories of care identified in this work have prevalence over others. Moreover, there is no specific order in which the different types of care take place. It is the needs of each individual that guide which component of care has greater influence. This also means that the care needs of each person will change throughout their life. In this line, it is probably more accurate to speak about *care work* rather than split it into 'emotion work' (Goodwin & Pfaff, 2003), 'identity work' (Reger et al., 2008; Snow & McAdam,

2000) and other processes that facilitate participation in a movement. Theorizing inevitably requires a degree of abstraction and simplification. Consequently, the terms emotion work and identity work are still useful for the development of explanatory mechanisms. This is the reason why this book divides care into three components (emotions, identities, and participation). c, attention to explanatory mechanisms should be balanced with consciousness about the complexity of any social process.

Methodology

This research and its preparation involved qualitative text analysis of articles from four newspapers for the period 2009–2016, one year of engaged participant observation, and 71 semi-structured interviews. The qualitative text analysis of newspaper articles was particularly useful for the fieldwork preparation. It helped to identify key actors in the leadership of the organization, as well as the defining moments of its history. Moreover, it was used to triangulate the information I collected during interviews about the origins and evolution of the organization. I gathered pieces of news from four newspapers—*El País*, *El Mundo*, *ABC*, and *El Periódico de Catalunya*—through LexisNexis using the keywords 'PAH' and 'Plataforma de Afectados por la Hipoteca', and the period covered was 2009–2016. This search resulted in 2101 articles. *El País* and *El Mundo* are newspapers of reference associated with the Spanish center-left and center-right, respectively. Hence, they were included to obtain high-quality factual information about PAH, as well as the printed opinion read by the core of Spanish public opinion, ranging from the center-left to the center-right. *ABC* is a conservative national outlet that was selected to include a priori critical views in the analysis. Finally, *El Periódico de Catalunya* is a progressive Catalonian newspaper, which covered PAH since its creation in Barcelona and has reported the most detailed information during its first years.

Fieldwork took place in Barcelona between June 2017 and June 2018, eight years after PAH was created. The distance from some of the events discussed presents both opportunities and challenges. On the one hand, eight years is enough time for care practices to influence those who experienced them. Through life-interviews, it was possible to explore the evolution of more experienced members since they joined PAH. Besides, new people arrived at PAH's assemblies practically every week, so it was possible to compare the recollections of veteran members with the observations

of newcomers' behavior and their evolution. On the other hand, founders' memories about the origins of the organization may have been distorted during these years. At this point, triangulation with the data from the qualitative newspaper analysis and with the information from other interviews proved to be useful to obtain a fair picture of the past.

Contact with the organization was made through common acquaintances with part of PAH's leadership. After two weeks of attending the two weekly assemblies of the organization in Barcelona, I publicly introduced myself during a meeting. In order to assure that members were aware of my position as researcher, I was mindful to share that information during all personal introductions. During the period of study, I participated in PAH Barcelona's weekly collective counseling and coordination assemblies, several eviction blockades each week, tens of bank protests, seven meetings with local administrations, six negotiations with bank clerks, and the occupation of a building to rehouse evicted members. Additionally, in March 2018, I went to the European Parliament with members from different locations in Spain on a two-day trip organized to gather international support for a bill they presented at the Spanish Parliament.

Being a participant observer allowed me to see the dynamics of care and empowerment firsthand. It also permitted me to triangulate the information from interviews with my own experience. Most importantly, I could understand how welcome mortgage-affected newcomers feel when they arrive at the organization, because I felt it myself. Since my first day in Barcelona, PAH members made efforts to integrate me into their group and their activities, as well as helping me understand the dynamics of the organization. This facilitated my efforts to build rapport with my future interview respondents.

Interviewees were approached through my interactions with them during fieldwork and snowballing. The final sample (see Table 2 for a summary) included activists from Barcelona (29), Madrid (8), Sabadell (5), Terrassa (4), Valencia (4), Seville (3), Manresa (2), Blanes (2), Murcia (2), Pontevedra (2), Bilbao (2), Pamplona (1), Segovia (1), and members of Obra Social Barcelona (6), which was created after a split from PAH Barcelona due to disagreements about strategy and some internal decision-making mechanisms. Interviews with members from Barcelona, Madrid, Sabadell, and Terrassa took place in person in those locations, and in public spaces, generally cafes. During my trip to Brussels, I interviewed one member from PAH Valencia and another from PAH Pamplona.

Table 2 Summary of interviewees

PAH local group	*Type of involvement*	*Sex*	*Age group*	*Housing situation*	*Type of interview*	*Interview length (minutes)*
Barcelona	Non-beneficiary constituent	F	30–40	Stable—No major housing problems	In person, Barcelona	81
Barcelona	Non-beneficiary constituent	F	30–40	Stable—No major housing problems	In person, Barcelona	76
Barcelona	Non-beneficiary constituent	F	<30	Stable—No major housing problems	In person, Barcelona	103
Barcelona	Non-beneficiary constituent	M	30–40	Stable—No major housing problems	In person, Barcelona	84
Barcelona	Non-beneficiary constituent	M	30–40	Stable—No major housing problems	In person, Barcelona	125
Barcelona	Non-beneficiary constituent	M	30–40	Stable—No major housing problems	In person, Barcelona	183
Barcelona	Non-beneficiary constituent	M	30–40	Stable—No major housing problems	In person, Barcelona	64
Barcelona	Non-beneficiary constituent	M	30–40	Stable—No major housing problems	In person, Barcelona	54
Barcelona	Beneficiary constituent	F	60+	Squatting	In person, Barcelona	84
Barcelona	Beneficiary constituent	F	50–60	Facing foreclosure procedures	In person, Barcelona	71
Barcelona	Beneficiary constituent	F	40–50	Facing foreclosure procedures	In person, Barcelona	43
Barcelona	Beneficiary constituent	F	40–50	Stable—Debt cancellation	In person, Barcelona	82
Barcelona	Beneficiary constituent	F	30–40	Stable—Social rent	In person, Barcelona	93
Barcelona	Beneficiary constituent	F	30–40	Squatting	In person, Barcelona	149
Barcelona	Beneficiary constituent	M	60+	Facing foreclosure procedures	In person, Barcelona	47

Barcelona	Beneficiary constituent	M	50–60	Facing foreclosure procedures	In person, Barcelona	58
Barcelona	Beneficiary constituent	M	40–50	Stable—Social rent	In person, Barcelona	66
Barcelona	Beneficiary constituent	M	40–50	Squatting	In person, Barcelona	86
Barcelona	Beneficiary constituent	M	30–40	Facing foreclosure procedures	In person, Barcelona	69
Barcelona	Newcomer	F	40–50	Facing foreclosure procedures	In person, Barcelona	72
Barcelona	Newcomer	F	40–50	Facing foreclosure procedures	In person, Barcelona	48
Barcelona	Newcomer	F	40–50	Facing foreclosure procedures	In person, Barcelona	41
Barcelona	Newcomer	F	30–40	Facing foreclosure procedures	In person, Barcelona	62
Barcelona	Newcomer	F	30–40	Facing foreclosure procedures	In person, Barcelona	57
Barcelona	Newcomer	F	30–40	Facing foreclosure procedures	In person, Barcelona	57
Barcelona	Newcomer	F	30–40	Facing foreclosure procedures	In person, Barcelona	55
Barcelona	Newcomer	M	40–50	Facing foreclosure procedures	In person, Barcelona	48
Barcelona	Newcomer	M	40–50	Facing foreclosure procedures	In person, Barcelona	26
Barcelona	Newcomer	M	40–50	Facing foreclosure procedures	In person, Barcelona	17
Madrid	Non-beneficiary constituent	M	30–40	Stable—No major housing problems	In person, Madrid	68

(*continued*)

Table 2 (continued)

PAH local group	*Type of involvement*	*Sex*	*Age group*	*Housing situation*	*Type of interview*	*Interview length (minutes)*
Madrid	Non-beneficiary constituent	M	30–40	Stable—No major housing problems	In person, Madrid	62
Madrid	Beneficiary constituent	F	60+	Facing foreclosure procedures	In person, Madrid	39
Madrid	Beneficiary constituent	F	50–60	Stable—Social rent	In person, Madrid	55
Madrid	Beneficiary constituent	F	40–50	Facing foreclosure procedures	In person, Madrid	60
Madrid	Beneficiary constituent	M	50–60	Facing foreclosure procedures	In person, Madrid	83
Madrid	Beneficiary constituent	M	40–50	Facing foreclosure procedures	In person, Madrid	45
Madrid	Beneficiary constituent	M	40–50	Facing foreclosure procedures	In person, Madrid	28
Sabadell	Non-beneficiary constituent	M	30–40	Stable—No major housing problems	In person, Barcelona	109
Sabadell	Non-beneficiary constituent	M	30–40	Stable—No major housing problems	In person, Sabadell	87
Sabadell	Beneficiary constituent	F	40–50	Facing foreclosure procedures	In person, Sabadell	73
Sabadell	Beneficiary constituent	F	40–50	Facing foreclosure procedures	In person, Sabadell	68
Sabadell	Beneficiary constituent	M	40–50	Facing foreclosure procedures	In person, Sabadell	94
Terrassa	Non-beneficiary constituent	M	40–50	Stable—No major housing problems	In person, Terrassa	121
Terrassa	Non-beneficiary constituent	M	30–40	Stable—No major housing problems	In person, Barcelona	138

Terrassa	Beneficiary constituent	F	40–50	Stable—Social rent	In person, Terrassa	55
Terrassa	Newcomer	M	40–50	Facing foreclosure procedures	In person, Terrassa	41
Valencia	Non-beneficiary constituent	M	60+	Stable—No major housing problems	In person, Brussels	137
Valencia	Beneficiary constituent	F	50–60	Stable—Debt cancellation	Telephone	32
Valencia	Beneficiary constituent	F	40–50	Stable—Social rent	Telephone	66
Valencia	Beneficiary constituent	M	60+	Stable—Social rent	Telephone	79
Sevilla	Beneficiary constituent	M	50–60	Facing foreclosure procedures	Telephone	113
Sevilla	Beneficiary constituent	M	50–60	Facing foreclosure procedures	Telephone	42
Sevilla	Beneficiary constituent	M	50–60	Stable—Social rent	Telephone	38
Manresa	Beneficiary constituent	F	40–50	Facing foreclosure procedures	In person, Manresa	53
Manresa	Beneficiary constituent	F	40–50	Stable—Social rent	In person, Manresa	42
Blanes	Beneficiary constituent	F	40–50	Facing foreclosure procedures	In person, Blanes	77
Blanes	Beneficiary constituent	F	40–50	Stable—Social rent	In person, Blanes	50
Murcia	Non-beneficiary constituent	M	60+	Stable—No major housing problems	Telephone	78
Murcia	Non-beneficiary constituent	M	60+	Stable—No major housing problems	Telephone	39
Pontevedra	Beneficiary constituent	F	30–40	Stable—Debt cancellation	Telephone	83
Pontevedra	Beneficiary constituent	M	40–50	Stable—Social rent	Telephone	63
Bilbao	Beneficiary constituent	M	60+	Stable—Social rent	In person, Barcelona	68
Bilbao	Beneficiary constituent	M	60+	Stable—Social rent	In person, Barcelona	65

(*continued*)

Table 2 (continued)

PAH local group	*Type of involvement*	*Sex*	*Age group*	*Housing situation*	*Type of interview*	*Interview length (minutes)*
Pamplona	Beneficiary constituent	M	50–60	Stable—Social rent	In person, Brussels	44
Segovia	Beneficiary constituent	F	40–50	Stable—Social rent	Telephone	57
Obra Social Barcelona	Non-beneficiary constituent	F	30–40	Stable—No major housing problems	In person, Barcelona	74
Obra Social Barcelona	Beneficiary constituent	F	50–60	Squatting	In person, Barcelona	75
Obra Social Barcelona	Beneficiary constituent	F	40–50	Squatting	In person, Barcelona	64
Obra Social Barcelona	Beneficiary constituent	M	40–50	Squatting	In person, Barcelona	176
Obra Social Barcelona	Beneficiary constituent	M	40–50	Squatting	In person, Barcelona	40
Obra Social Barcelona	Newcomer	F	30–40	Squatting	In person, Barcelona	59

Additionally, I interviewed the two members from PAH Bilbao during a visit they made to Barcelona. The remaining 14 interviews were performed over the phone. Interviews lasted an average of 71 minutes, ranging from 17 to 183 minutes in length. Out of the total 71 interviewees, 18 were non-beneficiary constituents—seasoned activists who did not have housing problems, 41 were experienced beneficiary constituents—who joined the organization because they were facing the risk of eviction and had been involved in the group for several years, and 12 were newcomers—beneficiary constituents who joined the organization at different times during my fieldwork and, hence, had been members less than one year prior to talking to them. Out of the 53 beneficiary constituents I interviewed, 16 had solved their housing issues, commonly through deals with their banks to accept the deed in lieu of foreclosure, and debt cancellations or reductions, 8 were living in occupied housing, and 29 were still facing foreclosure procedures. With the exception of one interview in Barcelona where the interviewee requested to bring a newcomer, all interviews were individual, recorded with a Dictaphone, transcribed by myself, and analyzed using the software Atlas.ti.

There were two noticeable differences between beneficiary and non-beneficiary members. First, these two groups diverged regarding their social class. While neither beneficiary nor non-beneficiary constituents came from particularly affluent backgrounds, non-beneficiary members had greater cultural capital. Most privileged allies had a university education and reflected more about politics in a wider sense than the members trapped with their mortgages. Second, while migrants—mostly from Latin America and North Africa—represented an important proportion of affected members, non-beneficiary constituents were mostly born in Spain. There were, also, many members who, after having solved their mortgage and housing problems, continued their involvement becoming de facto non-beneficiary constituents, even if in this research they have been categorized as beneficiary constituents, based on their original motivation.

Each group I interviewed provided me with valuable information about different topics. Discussions with founders, which are just a special category of non-beneficiary members, offered rich information about the origins of PAH, their reasons for creating an organization from which they would not necessarily benefit directly, and their background that led them to that commitment. Interviews with non-beneficiary members helped to deepen my understanding of the motivations of this collective and their

process of mobilization, as well as some of the strategies used to empower those who were immobilized by their grievances. Finally, conversations with beneficiary members provided rich details about the reasons why some people are immobilized by their grievances and do not mobilize to confront it, even if they have opportunities to do so. They also gave me a great account of the empowering impact that care processes have on members and how their perspective and involvement changed thanks to care. All interviews were also instrumental in helping me understand the dynamics and relations I observed during my fieldwork and translate them into more stable mechanisms.

The local group that each respondent was part of was sometimes relevant to understand the perspective from which they approached strategy. As with any other big organization, PAH members do not always share ideology and strategy. An important divide in the organization is between those who seek to combine grassroots organizing with institutional advocacy and those with more libertarian views who prioritize direct action. The dominant perspective in the organization, and that of PAH Barcelona, is the former. This group places value on institutional reform because 'there are many people affected by mortgages that will never reach to PAH and we should also defend their right to housing' (Non-beneficiary member, 16 June 2017, Barcelona). Moreover, activists seek to present their message in a way that appeals to 'the common sense' of people, instead of their ideologies. These intentions often involve refraining from using vocabulary associated with pre-established ideologies as well as reframing and rethinking certain actions, such as squatting and occupying bank offices to provide a less drastic image of them. Given the greater presence of these perspectives in my data, the analysis in the book is likely to be influenced by these views.

Most of my respondents from Barcelona, Terrassa, Valencia, Seville, Blanes, Murcia, Pontevedra, Bilbao, Pamplona, and Segovia could be categorized as part of this group. The more direct action-oriented faction is best represented by the PAHs from Sabadell and Manresa, whose framing tends to place struggles for housing within a wider capitalist framework of exploitation, and the language they use reflects this. During my interviews with members from Obra Social Barcelona, I did not detect a particular emphasis on leftist vocabulary. However, they did show greater libertarian inclinations and a general rejection of institutional practices, being this was one of the main reasons for their split from PAH Barcelona. Finally, in Madrid, PAH has a more decentralized structure that has allowed for a

relatively stable coalition between both factions, which was represented in my interviews. The variety of locations and ideological groups allowed me to detect patterns and strategies that were not only specific to PAH Barcelona, where most of my fieldwork was based but also to the wider organization.

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The Origins of PAH: Empathy and Solidarity Mobilization

Home foreclosures are one of the most dramatic sides of financial capitalism and have had particular prominence during the crisis that originated in 2008, with serious consequences still to date. In Spain alone, 370,000 evictions were executed between 2007 and 2017, according to the Spanish General Council of the Judiciary (Consejo General del Poder Judicial, 2019). Considering that during most evictions there is more than one person who loses their homes, if all those expulsed would move to the same city, they would join the top five of the most populous settlements in the country.

During the years prior to the burst of the housing bubble, thousands of families took on large loans to become homeowners, as rent prices were high and access to mortgages was easy. There was also a general discourse among Spanish media and public opinion encouraging people to buy a house as a sound investment because 'housing prices never decrease' (Televisión Española, 2004). Even if at some point people were unable to meet their mortgage payments, it was expected that selling the property at a higher price would provide enough income to repay the debt and make a profit. Already before the burst of the housing bubble, the construction

This chapter draws extensively on the paper Santos, F. G. (2019). Social movements and the politics of care: empathy, solidarity and eviction blockades. *Social Movement Studies*, 19(2), 125–143, authored by the writer of this book.

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F. G. Santos, *Social Movements that Care*,
https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-031-74296-5_3

sector started to stagnate, generating high rates of unemployment. Many construction workers received most of their salary under the table, and thus their unemployment benefits were insufficient to cover their expenses. Many started failing to pay their mortgages and, when they tried to sell their houses expecting the so-promised profit, they found out that nobody wanted to buy them. Banks began to execute repossessions and evict families from their homes.

The Platform of Those Affected by Mortgages (PAH by its Spanish acronym) was created in February 2009 to confront the drama of evictions, but the political context was not accommodating for its appearance. The Spanish economy relied heavily on its construction sector. According to data from the OECD, from 2005 to 2009, the construction sector represented an average of 11.23% of the total value added in the Spanish economy, double the average for all OECD countries (OECD, 2019). This dependence discouraged political representatives of any color from implementing policies aimed at capping mortgage indebtedness. Indeed, all governments between 1996 and 2012 progressively deregulated the financial and housing markets (Campos Echeverría, 2008). The only measures related to evictions were aimed at easing them. In 2008, Carme Chacón, the Socialist Minister of Housing at the time, promoted the creation of special courts to speed foreclosures (Europa Press, 2007), arguing that greater security for landlords and faster eviction processes would lower rental prices through an increase in the number of apartments available to let.

Second, evictions were not something discussed in the public sphere. Despite the growing number of foreclosures since 2008, media outlets remained silent. As shown in Fig. 1, evictions did not really make it to the news until the 15 M/Indignados movement appeared in May 2011, two years after PAH was created. It was PAH who raised the debate through its actions. The period when the media covered the issue of evictions the most was the submission of PAH's official petition to the Spanish Parliament in October 2012 and its subsequent Escraches campaign (Romanos, 2014). This petition gathered almost 1,5 million signatures and it became the biggest official petition in the history of Spain (Martínez, 2019; Plataforma de Afectados por la Hipoteca, 2013). Even if official petitions are generally expected to be discussed in the Spanish Parliament once they gather 500,000 signatures, the General Committee of the Congress—the governing body of the Spanish Parliament that had a conservative majority at that time—decides on whether they are finally allowed for debate. The Christian Democratic party attempted to block its admission and PAH started a campaign of public pressure to avoid the obstruction. During this campaign,

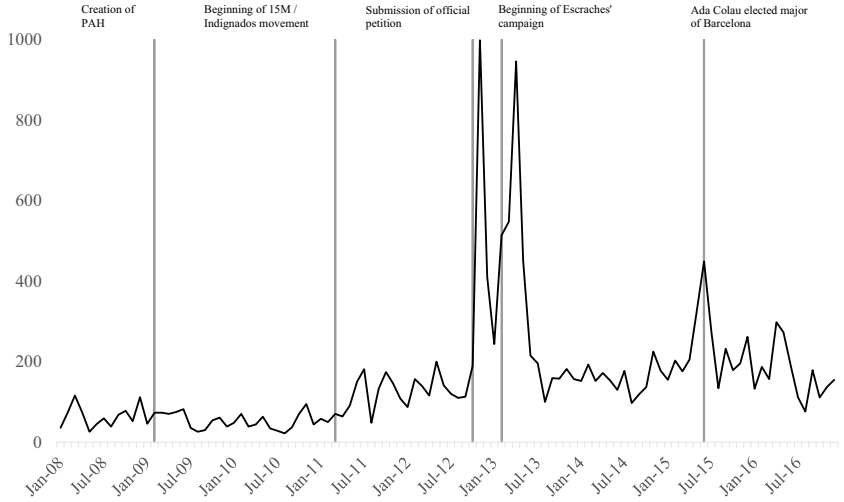


Fig. 1 Number of mentions to the words 'eviction' and 'evicted' in four Spanish newspapers (El País, El Mundo, El Periódico de Catalunya, and ABC). Source: Compilation by the author with data from LexisNexis

PAH organized *Escraches* at the homes and offices of MPs who opposed the debate of the bill. Escraches consist of non-violent actions of public pressure on political representatives to challenge the impunity of their actions (Romanos, 2014). This campaign was very controversial and generated heated discussions in the media because it consisted of gatherings in front of the homes of political representatives. PAH members attempted to meet with MPs to explain to them their demands and, if they were not received, they would chant, put stickers up, and ring the bells of their homes. The last peak in the number of mentions of evictions emerged when a founder, former spokesperson, and most iconic figure of PAH, Ada Colau, was elected as Mayor of Barcelona in June 2015. The fact that the peaks in the mentions of evictions in the press can be so clearly traced from PAH's actions indicates that it was the organization, together with the 15 M/Indignados mobilizations, who put the drama of foreclosures on the political agenda and not the other way round.

Moreover, when evictions were discussed prior to PAH's appearance, they were often framed from the neoliberal logic of the 'self-made man', pictured as a personal failure and blaming defaulters for not being responsible enough (Di Feliciantonio, 2017). Spain is a country of homeowners (Schwartz & Seabrooke, 2008), where the perception of success in life is

linked to the ownership of your house. This observation has been constantly reinforced by policy-makers who have prioritized property ownership over renting since Spain's pre-democratic times. This approach is well summarized by the words of Josè Luís Arrese, one of Franco's Housing Ministers, who, making a rhyme with the words *propietario* (homeowner) and *proletario* (proletarian) said that they wanted to create a country of homeowners and not proletarians, contraposing homeownership with a working-class identity, which was viewed as highly problematic at that time (Aisa Pámpols, 2014). This impression is common among Spaniards still today, and not being able to own a house is often regarded as being poor or unstable. This logic was widely spread during the times of the housing bubble when homeownership became a sign of social status. Hence, the stigma associated with not being able to pay their mortgage was doubled. Besides the personal burden of poverty that is common in most countries, defaulting on their mortgage meant a failure to join the successful group of *propietarios* and being doomed to swell forever the ranks of *proletarios* unable to have a stable life.

Despite its difficult beginnings, PAH has expanded all around Spain and has achieved considerable success (D'Adda et al., 2022; Martínez, 2019). As of 2017, PAH is present in 254 locations throughout the country. They have managed to prevent thousands of evictions and housed at least 2500 people in occupied apartments owned by banks and vulture funds (Plataforma de Afectados por la Hipoteca, 2017). Moreover, they gathered almost 1.5 million signatures in what became the biggest petition in Spanish history (Plataforma de Afectados por la Hipoteca, 2013). They have also contributed to reframing the hegemonic discourses about the financial crisis and improved perceptions of occupation (Martínez, 2019). Finally, many of its members are or have been elected representatives, including Ada Colau, who became the first woman to be elected mayor of Barcelona in 2015 and remained in that position until June 2023, and Irene Montero, Minister of Equal Opportunities between January 2020 and November 2023.

In the rest of the chapter, I start by providing some context about the period during which PAH's mobilizations took place. Then, I explore the origins of PAH and how it started its two most prominent campaigns, *STOP Desahucios* and *Obra Social*. PAH was created by six solidarity early-risers who, despite they did not have a mortgage, founded the organization to mobilize those affected by the drama of evictions. I explore how external solidarity motivates the mobilization of non-beneficiary

constituents while in the next one I place the focus on how grievances can often be immobilizing for those facing them, and the process through which this group can still join a social movement.

Empathy, Care, and Evictions: Mapping PAH's Origins

People participate in contentious collective action for different reasons. Many react to grievances and act collectively because they experience oppression firsthand or cooperate to advance their interests. Others, as was the case with PAH's founders, may experience external solidarity and be guided to action by a genuine understanding of somebody else's situation. As discussed in the previous chapter, solidarity early-risers first go through a moment of *attentiveness*, when they realize the unmet needs of some other person or group. Then, after a period of evaluation of the possible opportunities and threats of acting, they feel the *responsibility* to act to address the identified need. Once this happens, this solidarity early-risers start to mobilize their networks and resources to be *competent* to act. Finally, after the process of mobilization, the aggrieved group that inspired the mobilization of the non-beneficiary constituents experiences the outcome of mobilization and *responds* to it. As I elaborate in this chapter, this is the process that PAH's founders went through. The capacity to be attentive to other people's situations may originate from different sources, such as the previous socialization of activists or a moral shock from some information or episode that one encounters during their life. After realizing the struggle of those trapped in their mortgages, PAH's founders passed through a period of attribution of the threats and opportunities of mobilizing this collective. In other words, based on their experiences and interactions with others, they reflected on what could be done regarding this problem and whether they had any capacity to intervene. Once they answered these questions, they assumed responsibility to address the needs of those struggling to meet their mortgage payments. They started to reach their circles and mobilize the initial resources they could, with different degrees of success. At this point, mobilization began. With collective mobilization and the interactions that are generated, activists start also caring for each other.

The following pages explain in more detail the process since PAH's founders realized the struggles of those trapped in their mortgages until

PAH blocked its first eviction. To do this, I start presenting PAH's 'legacy' (Della Porta et al., 2018), describing the background of its founders and how they became empathic to the struggles of those trapped in their mortgages even if they were not part of the collective. Then, I discuss their efforts to mobilize the affected collective as well as their circles. Later, I map the failure of the first demonstration organized by PAH and explain it as a misinterpretation of social movement entrepreneurs about the caring needs of PAH's constituency. Finally, I describe the period until PAH stopped its first eviction.

Caring About: When Empathy Inspires Housing Rights for Everyone

PAH was created by six solidarity early-risers, people who did not have a mortgage but whose empathy towards the challenges that people affected by mortgages faced led them to explore ways to organize those facing eviction. Their personal stories show how empathy can originate from different sources. Four of them—Ada Colau, Adrià Alemany, Ernest Marco, and Guillem Domingo—had previous activism experiences, so they were socialized into placing themselves in the position of others and taking responsibility for addressing the unmet needs of an external collective. Ada and Adrià were prominent leaders of *V de Vivienda*, a social movement organization focused on youth precariousness and its problems accessing housing, which was one of the first actors denouncing the housing bubble in Spain (Aguilar Fernández & Fernández Gibaja, 2010). Additionally, Ernest and Guillem participated at the *Ateneu Candela*, a social center that aimed at engaging the community beyond the traditional leftist circles in the town of Terrassa. One of the initiatives of the center was the *Office for Social Rights*, a space for horizontal collective counseling and support against precariousness, be it at the workplace, related to access to housing, or the living conditions of migrants. At a certain point, they realized that discussions turned out to be mostly about mortgages and fear of eviction. Seeing this situation, Ernest and Guillem started to explore ways to confront this emerging problem.

Even if *V de Vivienda* is commonly cited as the origin of PAH (Di Feliciantonio, 2017; Flesher Fominaya, 2015; García-Lamarca, 2017a; Romanos, 2014), acknowledging the *Office for Social Rights* is of crucial importance to understand PAH's development. PAH's collective counseling assemblies were inspired by the success of the assemblies of mutual

support at the Office for Social Rights. Below, I discuss the centrality of collective counseling assemblies for PAH's activity but, for now, a quote from a leader of PAH Barcelona summarizes it well 'if the coordination assembly is PAH's brain, where we coordinate all our activities, the assemblies of collective counseling are its heart' (Non-beneficiary member, on 12 July 2018, Barcelona).[1]

Ada and Ernest knew each other from their involvement ith the alter-globalization movement and, given their converging analysis about the upcoming drama of evictions, they united efforts and started to reach out to their activist networks with little success. Most young and progressive activists are renters, so they were not familiar with the topic. Moreover, activists considered that those who became indebted to buy a house did so to speculate with the property and contributed to the housing bubble.

> There was the sensation that homeowners also created the housing bubble, that they were investing in housing, they were speculating with it. Hence, it was a group that was quite stigmatized. You could support people who were renting, but supporting homeowners was not well regarded. (Founder, on 15 August 2017, Barcelona)

Most activists did not empathize with evicted homeowners and were not willing to contribute their private resources to the collective ends of this group. Differently from PAH's founders, in addition to having no self-interest in the struggle, the rest of the activists felt no empathy towards homeowners who were defaulting on their mortgages, so external solidarity did not appear.

The other two founders—Lucía Delgado and Lucía Martín—had not been involved in activism before. In this case, their empathy originated in their discussions with Ernest, who was their coworker at the Department of Chemical, Biological and Environmental Engineering of the Autonomous University of Barcelona. As one of them explains, through the experiences they heard from Ernest, they started to empathize with the struggles of indebted homeowners.

> Ernest was speaking a lot about mortgages—'you are also affected by the mortgage problem, we all are'—'But I don't have a mortgage. How can I be affected?'—. And then we would speak about the subprime crisis, about

[1] All interview excerpts have been translated from Spanish and Catalan by the author.

> how many people were homeowners and how they were being evicted. I didn't have much time because during that period I was playing lots of basketball and I did not move in the social movement circles. I would follow the news and had an opinion, but I did not participate in anything. However, those stories were so horrible that I went to one of the meetings, and to the next one, and the next one… and I got hooked. (Founder, 23 August 2017, Barcelona)

Placing the stories of these six founders in a theoretical context, none of them had a mortgage and the issue around which they mobilized was not well regarded in their circles, making it difficult to explain their involvement through rationalist arguments. From the perspective of their personal resources, some of them were 'biographically unavailable' (McAdam, 1986), as other activities occupied their time, so their participation is difficult to understand from this stand. Moreover, political opportunities were rather closed. Between 1996 and 2012, there was a consensus among the Socialist and Conservative parties about the need for further liberalization of the housing market (Campos Echeverría, 2008). Therefore, the support in parliament for the demands that would later be associated with PAH oscillated between 2% and 7% of the seats.[2]

From a care perspective, these six solidarity early-risers mobilized because, after being aware of the situation of those struggling to pay their mortgages, they empathized with them and took on the responsibility to address their need. Their empathy originated from cultural and structural factors. Ada, Adrià, Ernest, and Guillem had developed ideologies and greater attentiveness to the situation of less-privileged groups through their previous activist involvements.

> They started explaining [during the meetings of the Office for Social Rights] that they stopped paying, that they lost their apartment and that, on top of that, they had a debt that would stay with them the rest of their lives. Some of them were now living back in their parents' house, others with some friends… This was a shock—what do you mean that you have been kicked out [of your house] and you still have a debt?—And then we started thinking what could be done because this situation was unbearable. (Founder, on 15 August 2017, Barcelona)

[2] This calculation includes the seats from the parties Amaiur, Bloque Nacionalista Galego, Chunta Aragonesista, Compromís, Esquerra Republicana de Catalunya, Eusko Alkartasuna, Izquierda Unida, and Nafarroa Bai.

Both Lucía's were exposed to the information about the situation of those trapped in their mortgages through their networks and this knowledge made them more empathic to the struggles of those facing evictions and financial distress.

> You listen to some of those stories [about mortgage-affected people] and you realize that you could have been there too. I did not even consider getting a mortgage because my job was just too precarious, but what if I had been more stable? Then I would have probably gotten indebted too. (Founder, 22 June 2017, Barcelona)

Additionally, empathy was facilitated by the relative economic security of all founders, as they could afford to think about other people's grievances. Nevertheless, this is not a sufficient explanation, as many activists that were contacted by them did not want to mobilize for this cause despite their stable jobs.

Caring For: Reaching Out to the Housing Activist Circles

After PAH's solidarity early-risers became more acquainted with the problem of mortgages and evictions, they decided to reach out to those affected. They printed posters that read 'If you have a mortgage and are facing problems meeting your payments or you are going to be evicted, come this Sunday to the Casa de la Solidaritat[3] of El Raval neighborhood' and stuck them around Barcelona. More than 100 people gathered at the meeting. Nonetheless, according to several interviews, these people did not come for solidarity purposes, willing to contribute their private resources to a collective end. Instead, they were interested in resolving their doubts about how to best approach negotiations with their bank, and what kind of support was given by public administrations and charities.

Given the social importance attributed to homeownership in Spain, people trapped in their mortgages viewed their situation as a personal failure, and identifying oneself with categories such as 'defaulter' or 'evicted' was extremely stigmatizing.

> Owning a house was a social objective, just like getting married, having kids, and all that. […] Suddenly, the crisis comes and you lose your job; you don't

[3] Casa de la Solidaritat is the name of a social center in Barcelona.

> get any more gigs. You lose everything and you find that you are broke, and it is tough to admit it in public. It is tough because you feel ashamed, because it is a personal failure, because you don't want others to know that they are confiscating your stuff that you cannot afford to pay for your home, that you don't have enough to fill the fridge. (Beneficiary member, 3 May 2018, Seville—phone interview)

Saying that those trapped in their mortgage experienced immobilizing emotions seems to fall short of describing their reality. Many faced serious psychological issues (Ramis-Pujol, 2013; Vásquez-Vera et al., 2016, 2019) and others even committed suicide.[4]

These cultural and emotional factors led them to attempts to solve their problem through individual and non-public actions. Many negotiated the refinancing of their debts with the bank, postponing, or lowering some of their payments in exchange for increasing the interest they paid. Others prioritized paying their mortgages over their dietary needs or relied on charity to cover them. The grievance they were facing came together with many other factors that complicated the appearance of internal solidarity.

From the reflections that many organizational leaders shared during my interviews with them, they now understand that care work was crucial for internal solidarity to arise. The emotional, identity, and participatory needs of their activists' base had to be addressed before those facing evictions would be willing to contribute to the collective. However, this conclusion came after long discussions about strategy, together with a process of trial and error. One of the most iconic episodes, recalled by many, is the failure of PAH's first demonstration.

Caregiving: Addressing Members' Needs Before Contentious Mobilization

Seeing the success of the first assembly, gatherings were organized every week. As people started to come regularly, the founders became motivated to organize a demonstration. When the day of the march came, only around 40 people gathered, most of them non-beneficiary constituents who were not directly affected by the problem of mortgages. As a founder

[4] Activists for the right to housing have identified that the media has recorded at least 43 suicides related to evictions since 2010. The full list can be found at: https://15mpedia.org/wiki/Lista_de_suicidios_relacionados_con_desahucios (accessed on 9 July 2019)

recalls, this experience made them realize that people trapped in their mortgages faced several barriers that prevented their internal solidarity and that they needed to address them before those trapped in their mortgages would engage in contentious collective activities.

> We organized a demo, and nobody came. We gathered around 40 people and we decided to walk on the sidewalk because we were ashamed to block the street with such a small crowd. […] And we were all buddies, you know? Maybe there were 2 affected persons only. We were hoping mad—How is it possible that nobody came?—But, of course, how are they going to come if they are devastated? What kind of demo would it be with everybody depressed all around? And then we realized that we needed to generate other dynamics to empower people. (Founder, 22 June 2017, Barcelona)

Internal solidarity was hampered by three unmet needs. Firstly, those facing eviction were not emotionally prepared because they were ashamed of their situation. Secondly, they did not see a collective purpose to struggle for and they were socialized as passive subjects, receivers of help from administrations and charities. Thirdly, they were not comfortable participating in a demonstration, as many had never been involved in contentious politics before. Those trapped in their mortgages did not participate in the demonstration because they were facing emotional, identity, and participatory barriers that they needed to overcome before they would be ready to join a public and collective action.

The aftermath of the demonstration illustrates well how internal solidarity can be constructed within SMOs. PAH founders focused on two activities: collective counseling assemblies and accompaniments. Collective counseling consists of self-help assemblies where whoever has a question exposes their situation and doubts, and the rest of the people give advice based on their own experience. An important feature of these assemblies is that counseling is expected to come from other members of the movement and not experts or lawyers (Di Feliciantonio, 2017; García-Lamarca, 2017a, 2017b). As I discuss in detail in Chapter "Identity Care and Becoming Activists", PAH's collective counseling assemblies have an important component of participatory care. They facilitate the contribution of private resources to the group since it consists of sharing their experiences. However, these seemingly small contributions have a great impact on the advancement of the organizational aims as members learn best practices and are better able to confront financial institutions. The

beginnings of these meetings were difficult, as nobody knew much about the process. However, through studying the mortgage laws and translating them from legal jargon to everyday language, sharing experiences and 'best practices', and trial and error, the movement managed to develop substantial collective knowledge and specific dynamics through which members could support each other. In other words, collective counseling facilitated the beginnings of internal solidarity.

The horizontal dynamics of collective counseling assemblies also contribute to the development of collective identities, through identity care. First, support comes directly from their peers, something that creates strong bonds among members. There are also constant references to the acceptance of the person in the group and the better chances to achieve a solution through it. When newcomers share their stories at the assembly, one of the most common first reactions is somebody saying, 'don't worry, now you are with PAH and you are no longer alone'. Moreover, members constantly speak about PAH as their family. For instance, the main Telegram[5] chat of PAH Barcelona, the main channel of communication where all members participate, is called *PAHmilia*, a combination of the words PAH and family. This feeling of acceptance by the group and the hope that comes with it contributes substantially to the involvement of the person in the movement's activities and the development of internal solidarity.

Accompaniments consist of gathering a group of activists to go together with a person to a meeting with the bank or the administration. These actions exemplify well the different care components of most PAH's actions. From the perspective of emotional care, even if the affected member is the one expected to lead the negotiation, some other member may speak on her behalf if she finds difficulties during the meeting. Affected members can better confront their fear and anxiety because they know that there are other activists ready to intervene if they need it. Moreover, bank clerks know that PAH may organize a protest in their bank office if the negotiations do not progress, so they are willing to make more compromises. As reflected in the following statement of a PAH activist, this situation contributes to the dynamics of identity care, increasing members' perceived and actual self-efficacy. While prior to joining PAH,

[5] Telegram is an encrypted, online messaging software commonly used in Spanish activist circles.

members engaged with bank clerks alone and without success, now they can raise their demands and still achieve what they wish.

> When you go by yourself, they don't care much about you, but when you go with PAH, they do. Before they always say 'no', but when you go with other people, there are things that become possible. In fact, this afternoon I am going to an accompaniment with a person that doesn't want to go with her kids to a public hostel, because that is not a dignified housing for children. We are going to tell the administration that, if they don't give her access to public housing, they will have to face the whole PAH. (Beneficiary member, 26 July 2017, Barcelona)

Accompaniments contribute to collective identity care, creating strong bonds among members. Many activists remember exactly those who were present during their first accompaniment, even after several years. Furthermore, PAH's constant use of the idiom *hoy por ti y mañana por mí* (similar to the English *I'll scratch your back and you scratch mine*) encourages participants to understand their fight as a collective struggle where they are expected to do the same for other members. The idiom is commonly used when some member thanks others for their help, but it is also reminded when asking for participation in some activity. This double use of the expression emphasizes that PAH's strength resides in members' reciprocity. Individual triumphs are collective victories achieved through the solidary engagement of others. These dynamics and framing of collective identity care during accompaniments contribute to the development of internal solidarity.

In addition to improving members' capacity to pressure their banks to obtain the deed in lieu of foreclosure and social rents, collective counseling assemblies and accompaniments provide spaces for care work. Through these activities, PAH addresses the emotional, identity, and participatory needs of its members and constructs internal solidarity. As I explain in the next section, these interactions of care work were crucial to preparing activists for their participation in PAH's first eviction blockade.

Care Receiving: Contentious Collective Action as a Response to Care

Despite the efforts of PAH and its members when negotiating with banks to avoid being evicted, frequently no compromise is achieved. During most of my interviews with the founders of PAH, it was clear that they

wanted to block evictions on the street from the beginning. However, it took them one and a half years of care work to build enough empowerment and solidarity to organize their first eviction blockade in November 2010. As one of the founders explains,

> People did not want to confront evictions [on the street]. They would rather give their flat up and go somewhere else, wherever… So, we did not want to push it, but we were constantly looking for somebody who wanted to confront, somebody who wanted to block the eviction. (Non-beneficiary member, 4 September 2017, Terrassa)

Emotional and identity needs were two of the reasons that prevented people facing foreclosure procedures from participating in eviction blockades. A number of interviewees who were facing eviction from their homes in Barcelona during PAH's early years reported feelings of shame or embarrassment at how their neighbors might see their situation. Other members were not comfortable making their housing depend on strangers. Their lack of identification with other members and the collective hindered their trust in the willingness of their peers to contribute their individual resources to protect their homes through civil resistance.

> When I arrived at PAH, I was still paying my mortgage, even if I knew that I would not be able to pay it for much longer. Everyone told me that if I knew that I would have to default soon, it was best to stop paying already […] I kept paying for another couple of months, mostly because I did not want to receive the calls from the bank during Christmas, but also because I did not know those people. So, I was not going to do whatever they told me, just like that. (Beneficiary member, 31 July 2017, Barcelona)

These factors may help explain an unwillingness to join an action of civil resistance on the streets and a preference for leaving their homes quietly prior to the date of the eviction.

The solidarity constructed during collective counseling assemblies and accompaniments was key to overcoming these problems. The relationships that appear through involvement in these spaces foster interactions of collective identity care that contribute to the appearance of internal solidarity. When members care for each other and see instances of commitment to the collective, they feel more comfortable trusting that their peers will contribute their private resources to defend their right to housing. The reverse is also true: when members have shared spaces of care within

the organization, they develop bonds that encourage them to engage in risky activities to protect each other from harm.

> It is not the same going to the eviction blockade for whoever because you are asked to go than going to the one of *Pepita*,[6] with whom you have been in PAH for a year. You have developed affective bonds. You have realized that you are in the same boat. You have even shared time with her outside of PAH. So, when they are going to kick her out, you go there, not because of activism but because she is important to you. (Non-beneficiary member, 4 September 2017, Terrassa)

For the first eviction blockade, emotional care was instrumental in providing the person affected with the necessary courage to engage in civil disobedience. Prior to the eviction blockade, leaders had several exchanges with this member until he felt ready for the confrontation.

> The first *STOP Evictions* was the one for Luís from La Bisbal del Penadès,[7] who said—yes, I am ready to go public, let's call for the *STOP Evictions*—but previously we made a process in which we talked to him so he would have the determination of saying—yes, I am going to face the music in front of my family, in front of my acquaintances, in front of the whole world… I will be on TV, I don't care; I am going to denounce this situation. (Founder, 12 August 2017, Barcelona)

Participatory care was also crucial for PAH members, particularly those with no previous activism involvements, to be comfortable in their first experience of civil resistance. Everything was organized so everyone would know what to do and expect, reducing the actual and perceived risks of the action. There were those in charge of speaking to the police and the judicial entourage, those recording videos both to publicize the action and to discourage police violence, and there were training programs on how to react to different scenarios. Also, to make the action seem less confrontational, banners were shaped like comic bubbles.[8] All these preparations were aimed at removing the barriers that would prevent people from

[6] Pepita/o are names generally used in Spanish to refer to a hypothetical person.

[7] La Bisbal del Penadès is a village to the west of Barcelona.

[8] The video of this eviction blockade can be found through this link: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=FwrPYc1Uzwg (accessed on 9 July 2019)

contributing their private resources to the collective end of the eviction blockade.

Finally, some 50 people gathered in front of Luís' house. This came as a surprise both for the judicial entourage and for the police, who, partially because they did not know what to do, declared that the eviction could not take place and postponed the date to one month. This episode was the beginning of the normalization of eviction blockades through civil disobedience. Of the 54 beneficiary constituents I interviewed, 43 (79.6%) indicated little prior experience of activism. However, through their participation in the *STOP Evictions* campaign, they began to see civil resistance as 'a normal practice and as a moral obligation, as a collective tool to transform reality, and a legitimate action applicable to other struggles' (Mir García et al., 2013, translation from the author).

From this point on, the *STOP Desahucios* (STOP Evictions) campaign, which consists of postponing the date of eviction by gathering a group of people in front of the entrance of a building to block with their bodies and through strategies of civil resistance the entrance of judicial entourage in the property, became PAH's flagship action. Until 2019, PAH had blocked more than 4000 evictions all around Spain (Plataforma de Afectados por la Hipoteca, 2019). This campaign has become so referential that many local organizations associated with PAH call themselves simply *STOP Desahucios*. Moreover, the logo of the campaign, which is a STOP traffic sign with the word Desahucios and PAH's logo below, has become so iconic that it has been used by social movements all around the world, including Italy (*STOP Sfratti*, n.d.), the United States (*Stop Evictions*, n.d.) and Turkey (*Stop Tahliye*, n.d.). The STOP Desahucios campaign has become PAH's most successful public initiative, and it has made the organization a global reference in the struggle for the right to housing.

Rights Are Conquered, Not Requested: Strategic (Re-)Evaluations of Care and the Appearance of PAH's Obra Social Campaign

Needs are what guide care-based mobilization. They indicate in which direction some of the activities of the movement should go. As I discussed in this chapter, PAH prioritized its self-help activities during its beginnings because its leaders realized that people trapped in their mortgages had some needs that had to be addressed before they were ready to engage in

contentious collective action. In other cases, the failure or success to address some members' needs may initiate new campaigns or cycles of mobilization. PAH's Obra Social campaign appeared after several failed attempts from the organization to block an eviction. In other words, it appeared after they failed to address the need for housing of some of their members.

The Obra Social campaign consists of the occupation of empty buildings owned by financial institutions to rehouse evicted families. Its name derives from corporate social responsibility initiatives by some banks, which had the same name. During the financial crisis, financial institutions became some of the biggest real estate agents in Spain. They accumulated their housing stock from house repossessions and failed real estate development initiatives (Muñoz, 2009). After the bailout of the Spanish financial sector in 2012, most of these properties were purchased by the SAREB, a public 'bad bank' created to clean up the books of Spanish financial institutions that were at risk of collapse. Given the ownership of most properties occupied by PAH, the organization does not call its actions 'occupation' but prefers to refer to them as 'recuperation'. They argue that they are recovering the social use of properties that were already purchased by the State through the bank bailout.

Obra Social was the outcome of a failed process of care-based mobilization. PAH had managed to block four times the eviction of a family from Montcada i Reixac, a location close to Barcelona, but its fifth attempt failed. As the family had no other housing alternative and the local government only offered to pay for a hostel for a couple of days, they decided to occupy their own flat (Mir García et al., 2013). This initiative inspired a period of reflection, after which PAH launched the Obra Social campaign with the occupation of an entire empty block of flats in the town of Terrassa in December 2011 (García-Lamarca, 2017b). Hence, the inability to care for some of its members and guarantee their need for housing started a new process of care that resulted in the creation of the Obra Social campaign and the inclusion of occupations in PAH's repertoire. This statement to the press from Ada Colau, spokesperson of PAH Barcelona, when the Obra Social campaign was launched, exemplifies how this innovation in PAH's repertoire was inspired by the unmet needs of its constituency.

> We will continue proposing legislative changes and demanding town halls to be the ones that facilitate that empty flats will be used as social housing for

> families. However, as long as there are no answers from the administrations, the life of these families is under risk and we will support those families that, instead of ending up in the streets, prefer to recuperate their homes. (TV3, 2011)

The creation of Obra Social follows the four steps of care-based mobilization outlined in Chapter "Caring Movements and Care in Movements". The first moment of *attentiveness* originates when PAH realizes that blocking one eviction after another is not sustainable in some cases and that other families were facing the same problem as the one from Montcada i Reixac.

> [Obra Social appeared when] we realized that we could not be stopping the eviction of the same family seven times because we achieved nothing, and we were only prolonging the process. Imagine blocking evictions every month and knowing that the next month you will have another eviction for the same family, and the next one the same, and all this without ever reaching a solution. […] When this family from Montcada i Reixac returned to their own home, we thought that it could be a more stable solution for many other families that were in the same situation. (Founder, 22 June 2017, Barcelona)

After realizing that blocking the eviction from the same family every month was unsustainable and too unstable for most families, PAH started to evaluate the opportunities and threats of the campaign. Following a period of strategizing, the organization concluded that they could take *responsibility* for addressing the needs of their members that could not avoid their eviction. Squatting was a higher-risk activity than any other action that PAH had organized before, as entering a property through force can be punished with a prison sentence. Hence, even if there was an initial period of attribution of threats and opportunities, the organization has constantly been updating its strategy. They initially paid attention to the legal issues and, when the campaign was already ongoing, they framed it in a way that could be acceptable for public opinion. Originally, PAH only occupied entire blocks of flats with the objective of building communities that could support each other. Later on, when they found it difficult to entire blocks of flats that were empty and owned by financial institutions, they started occupying empty flats in buildings where other people lived.

> Everyone participated in planning how to do it [the Obra Social campaign]. We organized workshops to develop the campaign, and we consulted the legal issues with people who knew. Later on, when the campaign was already ongoing, we created our own framing; we changed the word occupation for recuperation. Then, the campaign evolves, right? First, we only did entire empty buildings owned by banks, then we started with individual flats and [real estate owned by] vulture funds.[9] (Non-beneficiary member, 4 August 2017, Barcelona)

This last innovation required the organization to develop a plan about how to interact with neighbors before, during, and after occupation. For instance, during my fieldwork, PAH Barcelona occupied several flats in the building located at 477 Aragò Street, which had been recently purchased by an Israeli vulture fund called Norvento. Norvento's aim was to empty the building and reform it to a high spec, so they could ask for more money from the new tenants. Norvento informed those living in the building that it would not renew their contracts and asked them to move out. There were some tenants that had unlimited rental contracts, so Norvento tried to expulse them through what is commonly known as *real estate mobbing*. They started work in the building without respecting the legal restrictions about the time of the day when they must start and finish, creating constant noises and disturbances early in the morning or late at night. Even if they would eventually need to pay a fine and compensation to the tenants of the building, it was a price they were willing to pay for their strategy. Seeing these circumstances, PAH contacted the tenants before occupation and suggested organizing with them their resistance against Norvento. Hence, not only PAH managed to obtain tenants' support, but it also expanded its membership base. This strategy is part of the wider logic of caring, in which PAH cares for the fear and perceptions of risk of those outside its constituency.

How Obra Social appeared and unfolded shows that the process of mobilization is not always linear and that activists constantly evaluate the threats and opportunities in the field. Activists constantly strategize with the information they have available and they update their tactics during their mobilization (Jasper, 1997, 2006). Indeed, this is also the case for social movements' targets (Choi-Fitzpatrick, 2017). Hence, the process of mobilization consists of multiple interactions between challengers and

[9] Vulture funds are investment funds whose main object of investment is purchasing.

incumbents where both actors update their strategies based on the new information they learn during their exchanges.

After the initial period of planning, PAH felt *competent* to initiate the campaign and launched it in December 2011. The care logic of Obra Social can be appreciated in the fact that the campaign does not approach squatting as an exclusively militant act. This action is rather aimed at addressing the need of its members for stable housing.

An important difference between PAH's Obra Social campaign and traditional ways of squatting is that, after the occupation of the property, PAH starts negotiations with the bank to regularize the families' situation demanding a social rent that never exceeds 30% of the total income of the household (García-Lamarca, 2017b). Often, the total sum of the rent requested is zero, as many PAH members have no income. Hence, PAH's Obra Social differs from traditional squats because occupations are used as a means to achieve a stable and legalized solution through a social rent. In a way, PAH reinterprets what squatting is, as it recognizes the ownership of the dwelling and tries to regularize the squat, either through negotiations with the property landlords or by pressuring public institutions to purchase it for its social housing stock. When this happens, it can be considered that the need of the family for stable housing has been addressed and *care has been received* successfully. Up until 2018, PAH had rehoused more than 2500 people through this campaign (Martínez, 2019).

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From Immobilized to Empowered: Beneficiary Mobilization in PAH

I am sitting on a terrace in front of the farmers' market of Sants neighborhood, close to PAH Barcelona's office, sipping my coffee while I wait for Carmen to arrive for our interview. Carmen is an Ecuadorian migrant who lost everything during the 1999 economic crisis in her home country and moved to Barcelona in 2000. She got hit by another crisis in 2009 and, unlike the Ecuadorian and Spanish banks, she was not bailed out on either of the occasions. Even if she struggled, she managed to recover after both episodes. Her story of empowerment is famous within PAH Barcelona, as she passed from being a regular in the weekly psychotherapeutic sessions that took place at PAH's office, to being one of the coordinators of the Obra Social committee, PAH's campaign to occupy empty bank-owned apartments to rehouse evicted families.

Carmen knows well how immobilizing it can be to face financial distress and the risk of eviction, having felt it firsthand. She also understands the importance that empowerment has both for the life of PAH members and the organization, and she happily presents herself as an example of people's evolution in PAH. Indeed, Carmen arrived late for our meeting because she was convincing a newcomer to come with her, so that she could listen

This chapter draws extensively on the open-access paper Santos, F. G. (2024). How activists build power: passive beneficiary involvement and empowerment in the platform of those affected by mortgages. *European Societies*, 26(1), 34–62 written by the author of this book.

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F. G. Santos, *Social Movements that Care*,
https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-031-74296-5_4

to her story as she told it to me. This act was a beautiful example of how those who once were cared for later became the ones who cared for others. Carmen greeted me saying, 'if you don't mind, I am bringing her with me because she is not empowered at all. I want to show her that she needs to wake up and be empowered; and that this is possible, because I was where she is [now]. She doesn't believe that, so I have brought her to listen to the interview'. Carmen knew I was a researcher doing fieldwork, but we had not discussed the topic of my research in detail. However, for Carmen, her story in PAH made no sense without speaking about empowerment, and that was what she was planning on telling me, regardless of whether this was what I was looking for. Luckily, we were on the same page.

During that conversation, Carmen told me about how overwhelmed she was when she started having financial problems, about the plans she had to leave everything and return to Ecuador to escape from her mortgage debt, and about how PAH changed everything for her. Carmen had known about PAH from a friend who knew somebody in the organization, but she did not want to approach it. She was never interested in politics and she thought that PAH was not for her. After several months of exhausting every possible option, she finally decided to go to an assembly. However, when she arrived at PAH Barcelona's office, her feeling of shame immobilized her and even prevented her from entering the building. It took her several weeks of going every Monday to PAH's office until she felt the courage to step into the space. However, the fact that she entered the assembly did not mean that she participated in it. She took more time to introduce herself to the rest of the group.

> I would arrive at PAH's office, which was not here. It was still in Enamorats street, and stay outside. I would just walk from one end of the street to another, on the other side of the street, so nobody would realize that I was looking for PAH. I spent five or six weeks walking up and down the street. I was really ashamed… you cannot imagine.
>
> Question: Why were you ashamed?
>
> I don't know. It is like trying to cover the sun with one finger. I didn't want anyone I knew to see me… then everyone inside was wearing green t-shirts…[1] I don't know; it was many things. I think that everyone who comes to PAH for the first time comes like *uffffff*.

[1] PAH's green t-shirts have become a distinctive symbol of the organization. Members wear them at all of its public actions, and it is common for many to wear them during assemblies and other meetings as well. Chapter "From Immobilized to Empowered: Beneficiary Mobilization in PAH" talks in more detail about the importance that these t-shirts have for members.

Question: What do you mean by *uffffff*?

I don't know. It is so many things. I was ashamed. I was even scared that my bank clerk would see me. Can you imagine? As if he gave a damn about me. I didn't know what to do if I entered. It is so many things that I cannot tell you everything.

Question: How did you finally manage to enter?

I don't know. One day I just entered, crestfallen, I sat in a corner and I looked around. I probably went to three or four assemblies a bit like in incognito, isolated. Then I started talking to some people around me and, in the sixth or seventh assembly, I introduced myself. (Beneficiary member, 21 July 2017, Barcelona)

Carmen's story is a pertinent example of what *passive recruitment* means. Not only did she attempt to join PAH's assembly several times before she gathered enough strength to enter the office but, once she entered, she made conscious efforts not to participate actively. From the perspective of previous accounts of recruitment and participation, she would have been labeled as a participant since the first time she joined an assembly. However, it would be inaccurate to consider that she participated. The episode described above reflects only the process until she introduced herself at the assembly for the first time. Carmen took even longer to take a more active role in the organization.

I arrived at PAH because of a problem with my mortgage, that I had been dealing with for a long time already. However, when I arrived at PAH, I was in emotional chaos. Imagine, the first thing I did after I had started speaking with the other people was join *mutual support*…[2] the first activity I joined was *mutual support*. It was on Wednesdays and we had [the nickname of the psychotherapist] helping us. [He would say] 'Hey, tell me, what's up', like in a psychological way, and you would tell the rest of the group about your problems. I mean, all your problems except the mortgage. Of course, we spoke about our mortgages, but not like in the welcome or coordination assemblies. They were never the main problem we discussed there. (Beneficiary member, 21 July 2017, Barcelona)

Carmen joined PAH during its beginnings, and the organization is now more conscious of the dynamics of passive recruitment. During the first

[2] Mutual support is how PAH Barcelona's group therapeutic sessions were called. These sessions took place every week and were led by a professional therapist.

years, there were many newcomers coming to PAH's welcome assemblies every week, and leaders were less aware of how passive recruitment hampers participation. Currently, PAH members pay attention to new faces, and either the moderator of the welcome assembly or somebody sitting close to newcomers encourages them to speak. Despite the organizational efforts to reduce the phase of passive recruitment as much as possible, many newcomers still struggle to engage beyond their introduction, particularly when they have not been notified about their eviction date, or the foreclosure is not imminent.

Carmen's story shows that there are some types of grievances that are so overwhelming that they hamper mobilization. They destabilize the lives of those suffering them so much that they create problems beyond the origin of the grievance itself, complicating not only participation in contentious collective action but, often, any action at all. Indeed, many members are conscious that they have passed through a phase during which they would never have been able to join PAH. The following quote is from a member who joined PAH six months after she was evicted, with the objective of at least having her remaining debt cancelled.

> I am perfectly conscious that if PAH had appeared in the moment of my foreclosure, I would not have been able to receive their help. I was not prepared to do anything at all. I mean, it was a miracle that I managed to survive. I did not have strength for anything other than survival. [A leader from PAH Pontevedra] had been telling me for one year to join PAH, and for one year, I said no. Until I said—okay, let's do this. (Beneficiary member, 8 April 2018, Pontevedra—phone interview)

People may finally react to their *immobilizing grievances* and even do so by joining contentious collective initiatives, but the path they follow is not as straightforward as for other groups affected by mobilizing grievances. In the rest of the chapter, I explore the reasons why those trapped in their mortgages were immobilized by their original situation and later explain how they were mobilized at last.

Lives Broken by Evictions

PAH members are *debtors of good faith*. When they stopped meeting their mortgage payments, they did so because they could not afford to pay them any longer, but they would have continued if they had been able to

do so. The reasons for defaulting are manifold. Most commonly, people have lost their job, either because of the economic downturn during the crisis, or because they became ill or pregnant and they were not re-hired or able to find another occupation afterwards. In many cases, people worked illegally or received most of their salary out of their contract and, once they lost their job, they had no right to unemployment benefits.

> I stopped paying because I was working without a contract in a supermarket, getting paid per hour under the table. I fell from the ladder in the stockroom and got injured, so I could not work anymore, and did not have the right to any social benefits. So, I lost all my income. (Beneficiary member, 26 July 2017, Barcelona)

Banks were rather lenient in following the legal requirements for signing a mortgage and used to offer mortgage contracts to people who were not supposed to be eligible for one. Moreover, it was not part of the priorities of public administrations to enforce these rules, so financial institutions could get by offering mortgages to people with no stable income, job, or assets (Naredo, 2010). The behavior of Spanish banks and public bodies with regard to mortgage contracts was common in other regions of the world (Dell'ariccia et al., 2012), and was an iconic example of the whirl of speculation that generated the collapse of the world's financial system in 2008.

The foreclosure process in Spain has consequences that go beyond losing their homes. They are so drastic that some voices have equated evictions with a 'civil death' (Gonick, 2021, p. 100). Once you stop paying your mortgage, a judge will set the date for a public auction for your house. In the common case that there are no offers, the bank acquires the property for 60% of its current tax value. Given the great disparity between the pre-crisis and post-crisis prices, this sum rarely covered their remaining debt and, as the deed in lieu of foreclosure is not a common figure in Spain (García-Lamarca & Kaika, 2016), you would still be indebted for the difference between your debt and the price at which your house was sold. Moreover, your name would be registered on a public debtors list, discouraging anybody from offering you a rental contract or an employment offer. In brief, a civil death means becoming an indebted homeless person during one of the worst economic crises of modern history, facing additional burdens to finding a job and a dwelling than many people sleeping in the streets.

Suffering financial distress and the risk of eviction creates so many problems that it is likely that individuals have no time or energy for anything else. The fear of having their salary confiscated pushes many defaulters into the informal economy, making their income dependent on low-paid, small, and unstable jobs. Despite long working hours every day, they would struggle to make ends meet, as many of these jobs are not paid even the minimum wage.

> I was unemployed and I would get jobs every so often, by the day. I would do any gig, going from one side of the city to another, and agreeing with people to pay me whatever they could, because, after all, we were all on the same boat—we were all hit by the crisis. (Beneficiary member, 30 March 2018, Valencia—phone interview)

Just like others who lost their jobs during the crisis, many people trapped in their mortgages joined the ranks of the 'working poor' (Andreß & Lohmann, 2008; Newman, 2009). They could work the whole day, having no time or energy for other engagements, and they would still not be able to afford to cover their daily expenses, let alone pay their mortgage installments. Furthermore, beyond economic issues, people trapped in their mortgages face additional problems.

Evictions are associated with physical health, psychological, and social problems. Individuals facing foreclosure procedures are more likely to report poorer health conditions (Vásquez-Vera et al., 2016), pay more visits to the hospital (Pollack et al., 2011), and feel depression and anxiety (Cagney et al., 2014; Gathergood, 2012) than the general population. Sometimes, psychological problems may push those trapped in their mortgage to their limit. Studies in the United States have linked increases in home foreclosures to greater suicide rates in a neighborhood (Houle & Light, 2014) and activists for the right to housing have recorded at least 43 suicides linked to evictions in Spain (15Mpedia, 2018). Socially, in addition to arguments that are likely to appear within families due to the stress suffered, previous studies have linked facing eviction with children's underperformance at school (Ramis-Pujol, 2013), and higher odds of child abuse (Frioux et al., 2014). Moreover, gender-based violence is more common in households suffering from economic hardship (Schneider et al., 2016). Economic precariousness, health, and household troubles destabilize their life to a degree that it is difficult to find any time and energy to engage in collective activities to confront their grievance.

Collaboration with others is complicated even further by the isolation that many mortgage defaulters fall into. As others have explained using the case of PAH (García-Lamarca, 2022; Gonick, 2021), mortgage indebtedness and default construct and destroy social ties. For instance, facing eviction is correlated with higher chances of divorce (Cohen, 2014), even if the causality in the relation is not clear. Divorce—an often lengthy and costly process—may make it difficult to pay their debts. One of the partners, particularly the one who moves out, may also decide to stop paying their share of the mortgage. Conversely, financial problems may be the source of arguments leading to separations. Moreover, conflicts may arise with parents and extended family who have signed as guarantors for their mortgage, as the financial burden is passed on to them. In addition to family, when somebody becomes impoverished, it is likely that they will cut social activities, distancing themselves from their circle of friends. This happens partly for financial reasons, and partly because of the shame of admitting to others that they are facing economic problems.

> You may imagine that you have the support from your social circles, but that is often not the case. It is difficult to admit in public that you are poor. It is difficult because you are ashamed that you cannot pay for your home, that you are giving powder soup to your kids … You also realize that most of your friends are not such good friends. When you stop having cash, there are many things that you cannot do. It's not only about going out for drinks and stuff, I am speaking about having a phone line. It is not that your friends stop calling you because you are never up for a beer; it is that they can't even call you. (Beneficiary member, 15 September 2017, Madrid)

While other scholars have mapped the practices of community support among the urban poor (Desmond, 2016), they have also highlighted the low levels of perceived political collective efficacy among these groups (Desmond & Travis, 2018).

It is not difficult to imagine that these experiences affect people's emotions and identities in a way that prevents many from confronting their grievances, let alone doing so by collaborating with others in activities that they have never engaged in before. Suffering from financial distress and facing eviction makes many people *personally unavailable* to engage in contentious collective action to confront their problems. From the perspective of emotions, the feeling of guilt and shame over not being able to pay their debt, or afford to pay for their homes, leads people trapped in

their mortgage to avoid interactions with others. Most of my interviews with PAH's beneficiary constituents covered in one way or another how shame and guilt made them postpone the moment they approached the organization and their subsequent involvement. Shame, in particular, influences the degree of involvement after recruitment. Shame is easier to overcome when contributing to private activities, such as assemblies and groups of collective counseling, but places additional burdens on public actions. Ultimately, PAH's office becomes a safe space where newcomers feel comfortable and accepted, and where they can anticipate with whom they will share a presence. However, this is more difficult to predict for public events. Many members are still ashamed to let their close circles know about their mortgage problems, even after being in PAH for some time, and they are more cautious about their participation in activities on the street.

> I was in PAH for some months already. I participated in the assemblies and went to the STOP Evictions, but I remember there was one in [her neighborhood], where I used to live, and I panicked because I thought that, if I went, my neighbors may see me. I felt terrible, but I made up that I had a meeting with my bank and I didn't go to the eviction. (Beneficiary member, 21 July 2017, Barcelona)

This quote indicates the possibility that not all immobilizing emotions influence participation in all activities in the same way. In this case, shame may complicate participation in public activities even more than in private ones. In a similar way, fear is likely to be overcome more easily in the case of low-risk actions. Indeed, previous studies point to the importance of emotional micromobilization in PAH's private spaces to understand sustained participation in public events (Ancelovici & Emperador Badimon, 2021).

The self-concepts developed by people trapped in their mortgages, once they start facing financial distress, become a barrier to their engagement in contentious collective action. Their repeated unsuccessful interaction with bank clerks, and their difficulties in meeting basic needs such as food and clothing, lead them to internalize the idea that they are on the losing side. They develop what is called 'learned helplessness' (Abramson et al., 1978), the sensation that they have no control over their lives. This perception of inefficacy discourages them from engaging in any activity to change their position.

> The eviction is not the day they expulse you. It starts much earlier, it's all the things that push you down day by day. The eviction is that you can't buy new shoes when yours are broken; the eviction is when you have no money to buy food; the eviction is when the bank clerk insults you and you just shut up because you think that he is right and everything is your fault; it is thinking about what will happen when they expel you—where you will go? I don't get help from the administration because they say they have no social housing left. What can I do? (Beneficiary member, 23 May 2018, Blanes—phone interview)

Knowledge, the last component of personal availability, also gives a good perspective on why those aggrieved by their mortgage problems do not act to confront them. The lack of awareness about the relevant legislation and how others have succeeded in confronting the same issue complicates innovative action. More importantly, this unfamiliarity prevents any capacity to plan ahead, as those trapped in their mortgages do not know what to expect from the future. Under this context of uncertainty, they are unable to initiate any strategic interaction and their only option is to react to the banks' actions.

> Before PAH, I did not talk [to bank clerks] like 'If I give you my apartment, you will cancel my debt'. I didn't even know what the deed in lieu of foreclosure was. I would simply try to make sure that I left the bank [from a meeting] without the clerk having decided to evict me. So, I would talk like 'I cannot pay. I don't know what to do. All I can pay you this month is this much. I am sure that next month I will make up for this one. I am sorry'. (Beneficiary member, 4 July 2017, Barcelona)

Personal unavailability is the most relevant factor to explain passive recruitment in the case of PAH. Those who have joined some of the activities of the organization, but remain inactive, have overcome their problems of biographical and structural availability. Despite the little time and energy that their alternative commitments left them, they managed to find a moment to approach PAH. Indeed, many people I interviewed mentioned how they joined the assemblies of the organization numerous times and for long periods before they actively participated. This factor indicates that newcomers had allocated time every week to dedicate to the movement and that they managed to gather the necessary strength to attend the meetings. Additionally, once newcomers join PAH, they become part of its organizational networks. They receive information about the

mobilization opportunities during assemblies, and they are exposed to the new framing being created by the movement. Yet, newcomers do not actively participate. Indeed, many make conscious efforts to avoid interactions with others. Reflecting on their first months in the organization, many members made references to immobilizing emotions, negative self-concepts, and lack of knowledge and information, as reasons for not playing a more active role, or not joining PAH despite knowing about its existence. Personal availability is the reason why most people who are passively recruited into the organization do not participate until they go through an initial process of empowerment and care. In the rest of the chapter, I explore the process of mobilization of those immobilized by their mortgage problems, and PAH's efforts to empower its members.

Empowering Those Trapped in Their Mortgages

Potential recruits who are not structurally available, because they are not part of any networks through which PAH usually reaches its members, find out about PAH in two ways. A common story is that they discover it during one of its public actions. PAH's public actions take place in venues to which those trapped in their mortgages go frequently. Eviction blockades take place in the streets, and PAH's members are very visible, as most people in the group wear PAH's green t-shirts and chant different slogans to be noticed by the neighborhood. Thus, many newcomers discover PAH's existence from their windows, or while they walk across their own street. Bank protests also act as a recruitment activity, as those facing financial problems visit their bank offices often to attempt to find a solution or, simply, to justify themselves. It is common that potential recruits risking eviction approach PAH when they encounter the organization during these occasions. Even if they may not identify with the tactics—most people without an interest in politics cannot imagine themselves practicing civil resistance—, they finally make the decision to approach PAH because they see its effectiveness firsthand when it succeeds in blocking an eviction or pressuring a bank office.

> I got to know PAH during a *STOP Evictions*. I was at home and I heard lots of people shouting in the street, so I watched through my window to see what was happening. And there was this group of people with green t-shirts chanting that they were evicting somebody and that they were going to stop it. So, I stayed and watched them. Then, the police arrived, they spoke with

> them for a while, and they started celebrating and signing *¡Sí, se puede!*[3] So, I thought that I must go down and see how they did it. […] I always thought that protests were a thing for hippies, but if I could keep my home, I would become a hippy or whatever I had to become. (Beneficiary member, 17 July 2017, Barcelona)

Another common way through which newcomers reach PAH is desperation: they know about the organization, and they finally approach PAH as a last resort. During its more than ten years of existence, PAH has become very popular. It appears in the news and its leaders speak often on television. This was particularly the case during the years of the financial crisis when evictions were at their peak. So, many of those trapped in their mortgages knew about its existence, but they decided not to join. The reasons for this behavior are generally related to personal availability: people cannot imagine themselves joining a protest, they do not perceive those tactics as efficacious, or they are ashamed or fearful and do not want to share their problems with strangers. On other occasions, bank clerks discourage defaulters from approaching PAH, threatening that joining the organization will only make things worse. However, many people trapped in their mortgages end up visiting PAH after trying all other options they could. Even when they attend their first assemblies, many are not convinced of their decision, but they stay because all other solutions have failed.

> I knew about PAH from a friend who also had mortgage problems, but I waited for maybe a year to go. […] I saw their campaigns on TV, their green t-shirts and, I don't know—what would my family think if they saw me there? I didn't want my parents to think that instead of looking for a job; I was at a protest with some strangers. […] It took me several weeks to enter an assembly. I would go to the address of the office, arrive at the door, stay outside for a while, and leave. I was really embarrassed. (Beneficiary member, 16 August 2017, Barcelona)

If approaching PAH is already a difficult decision for many, participating is even harder. Entering PAH's office does not mean participating in its activities, and more experienced members may have to help newcomers start their process of empowerment by gently forcing them to make their first contribution. Most newcomers may attend PAH's welcome assemblies, but stay silent. Shame, fear, and not knowing how to behave make

[3] '¡Sí, se puede!' is one of PAH's main mottos, meaning 'Yes, it's possible!'.

them personally unavailable. In these cases, more experienced activists will encourage them to take the first step, as explained by this member who used to chair PAH Barcelona's assemblies:

> You arrive at the assembly for the first time, and you are scared, ashamed. You feel awful. I get it; I was there too. Not everyone dares to speak in front of more than one hundred people. It is not easy. When I see that somebody has come to the assembly several times and never speaks, I try to approach them privately and encourage them to talk. Other times, I may also gently put them on the spot during the assembly, so they feel a bit forced to speak. (Beneficiary member, 30 August 2017, Barcelona)

As I elaborate further on Chapter "Identity Care and Becoming Activists", PAH facilitates the participation of newcomers and experienced members by coordinating some of their alternative commitments within the organization, so they are more biographically available. For instance, PAH Barcelona's office has a room called *ChikiPAH*, where children can play during assemblies. At the beginning of any meeting, some people will be allocated the role of caring for the children in the ChikiPAH, so parents can participate without worrying about them. There have also been cases when the office has been opened during a demonstration, so that children can stay and play while their parents protest. These initiatives allow members who were once biographically unavailable to participate in the events of the movement.

Rituals of Empowerment

Easily accessible contributions such as newcomers' first intervention during an assembly are crucial in their process of empowerment. Beyond being a space where newcomers realize that many others are going through the same situation (Di Feliciantonio, 2017; Santos, 2020) and an important locus of political subjectivation (García-Lamarca, 2017), PAH assemblies are the space where newcomers actively contribute to the dynamics of the organization for the first time. Once this happens, they start being exposed to different rituals of empowerment that contribute to their engagement. In the case of PAH, three dynamics are of particular importance. First, the organization has developed a process of incremental engagement that sets clear steps through which newcomers should go, encouraging involvement in individual and collective activities. Second,

the culture of celebration and appreciation present in the organization generates activating emotions and positive self-concepts that increase the impact of those actions on the empowerment of PAH members. Third, PAH places great importance on building skills among its members, both through formal workshops and informal mentoring.

Incremental Engagement: From Passive Beneficiaries to Empowered Activists

Clear instructions and tasks accessible to the level of availability of each member facilitate individuals' increasing engagement. Once newcomers present their case to the assembly, they receive advice about how to redirect negotiations with their bank, postpone their eviction, and request social housing from public administrations. The first tasks consist of going to social services to request a legal recourse lawyer and signing up for the so-called emergency table, which is a register of people under precarious housing conditions and a prerequisite to opt for social housing. These two tasks only involve dealing with bureaucratic requirements, and PAH provides templates and support in filling them to ensure that everyone achieves their goal. Nevertheless, these actions have a great impact on newcomers' perceptions of self-efficacy. Managing to complete these tasks shows new members that they have more control over their lives than they thought and that they have the capacity to accomplish some of their objectives.

Achieving objectives eases members' engagement in more complex and confrontational activities. Once newcomers have accomplished their first administrative tasks, their next step is to request their bank to turn their mortgage into a non-recursive debt and ask for a stamped copy of the request that acknowledges the reception of the communication. Similarly to the previous activity, templates, and support are available to assure that requests cannot be denied based on formal reasons. However, differently from the prior bureaucratic processes, this action increases the level of confrontation. Members must now interact with the director of their bank office, with whom they already had negative encounters after their default. Even if bank clerks are legally obliged to sign and stamp a copy of any communication with their clients upon request, it is common for them to refrain from doing so. In these cases, members are advised to ask for an official complaint form. This action changes the roles in the relationship. While bank clerks used to be those initiating the claims and the affected

person the recipient subject, this time it is the person trapped in her mortgage who demands something and the bank clerk who follows the instructions. This change of roles and the celebration of the milestone by other organizational members increase newcomers' feeling of agency.

> I was in the upper part of the local, where we had an office and I heard [a member] talking very excitedly and the whole assembly starts screaming *UUEEHH!* I went down and [the member] tells told me "Look! I still have goosebumps! I have gone to the bank office to request the deed in lieu of foreclosure. The director did not want to sign. I threatened to call the police, and he finally signed!" It was only the signature on the document, not that she got the deed in lieu of foreclosure, and she was euphoric. (Conscience constituent from PAH Barcelona, 16 June 2017)

Moreover, newcomers are advised to go to their meetings at the bank with PAH's green t-shirt. This piece of clothing is well known by bank clerks and is expected to increase members' chances of success by showing that they are part of the organization. As I elaborate in Chapter "Identity Care and Becoming Activists", this action and the increased sense of efficacy that comes with it encourage the development of collective identities among newcomers.

Starting with these official tasks increases newcomers' personal availability for the use of more drastic tactics in the future. By attempting to reach answers through regularized mechanisms but achieving no acceptable solutions, members can rationalize the use of more contentious actions, such as bank protests and eviction blockades, on the premise that they have exhausted all other possible alternatives. This additional rightfulness encourages members to see these actions as legitimate, facilitating the integration of these new behaviors with their identities, and increasing their sense of authenticity.

Moreover, newcomers have confidence that they will have the support of PAH in case they fail to achieve the tasks they initially had. If the bank is not willing to sign a document or engage in negotiations, or a public worker poses problems to the official requests to join the emergency table or obtain a legal recourse lawyer, the organization is ready to provide an *accompaniment*. Accompaniments consist of a group of members that go together with the affected person at her next meeting. This group is often formed by more experienced activists, who can take the lead if needed, and by other people who want to learn how to negotiate. The affected person

is the one expected to speak during the meeting but, depending on the situation, other people may step in. This dynamic facilitates these initial tasks both putting pressure on incumbents and lifting the members' morale. Bank clerks and public workers are aware that they will have to face the group if they do not collaborate from the beginning. This expectation encourages incumbents to be more receptive to the first demands of the newcomer, facilitating success. Accompaniments also provide additional safety to newcomers, who are encouraged to engage in these tasks by themselves because they know that they will have the help of others if they are not successful.

Besides the initial individual engagement, PAH offers newcomers easily accessible activism opportunities to contribute to the collective. These contributions are generally activities that everyone has done before and that help the day-to-day progress of the organization. During the weekly coordination assembly, newcomers are encouraged to volunteer to clean the office space, as well as to take care of children in the ChikiPAH. Other activities that newcomers may not have done in the past, but that are easily accessible, are keeping track of the speaking turns during assemblies and helping to design banners for the next public action.

> [The first contribution I made to PAH] was being present at the assemblies often. At the beginning, what is asked of you is very basic. It is basically being present. At the beginning, you are not asked to join an eviction blockade because that is risky. At the beginning, I would help with the assemblies, taking minutes and speaking turns. I used to help to take care of the assembly space, because everything is self-managed. So, once or twice a month I would help to clean the space. Once I started to get involved, I joined accompaniments to social services. There are other *comPAHs* that learn more technical stuff and then go to talk to lawyers and banks, but that's not for me. Now, I also join eviction blockades whenever I can. I have even spoken to the police a couple of times to calm things down. Things often get quite tense and, as I am quite a calm guy, sometimes I step in to cool things down. (Beneficiary member, 11 September 2017, Madrid)

Moreover, some of these tasks contribute to high-risk activities. For instance, during flat occupations to rehouse evicted families, members cook for them until they have access to utilities. Even if cooking at home is a low-risk individual activity, it contributes to the success of a high-risk collective action. In distinction from the previous activities that were of a

more individual nature, these involvements represent the first contributions of newcomers to collective goals.

Tiny But Great Victories: Empowerment and Collective Celebration

The external appreciation of contributions and the collective celebration of achievements act as a confirmation of newcomers' perceptions of self-efficacy, increasing their personal availability and encouraging them to take on more complex and contentious tasks. PAH uses the expression *tiny-great victories* to refer to a dynamic where no achievement is small if it represents an important step for somebody. This culture of celebration is encouraged during assemblies. All meetings start with a moment called '*How Are We?*' which is a time for anybody to share how they are and the personal victories they have achieved during the week. Furthermore, in some local groups, such as PAHC-Sabadell, there is a rule that anyone can interrupt the assembly at any time to share a victory. These interventions generate a collective reaction of celebration where members start screaming, singing, and hugging each other.

Rituals of celebration can turn mundane actions, such as submitting a form, into important milestones in members' lives. The mutual focus of attention, the celebration of accomplishments, and the collective effervescence that is generated in the organization generate what Collins (2004) calls high emotional energy, a feeling of confidence and initiative that encourages members to keep interacting with each other and engage in more actions that replicate this emotion. PAH's members vividly remember the first time they spoke in the assembly or when they requested the deed in lieu of foreclosure at their bank office because of all the feelings and experiences associated with those moments.

Empowerment Through Education

Organizational education facilitates members' empowerment. Learning can take place in venues specifically designed for this type of exchange, such as workshops. Moreover, activists can learn skills through their participation in organizational activities.

PAH organizes training programs aimed at building skills that help activists access certain engagements where knowledge may act as a barrier. Some workshops are about abilities related to low-risk activities, such as using social media and knowing the organizational email rules. Others are more advanced, such as how to organize public action and mediate with the police. Some PAH groups even organize workshops about squatting,

in which they provide the necessary practical and legal knowledge to engage in this type of activity.

As PAH proposes legislative changes in relation to housing policy and organizes actions in the street to gather support, it holds workshops to train members on the details of the bills and how to advocate for them. To amplify the reach of these initiatives, PAH has a system of training trainers. During PAH's 2017–2018 campaign to push for a new housing law, a workshop about the bill was organized during its 2017 national assembly. In addition to learning about the details of the proposed legislation, those who attended the training received materials that enabled them to organize similar initiatives for their local groups. Those who wanted to hold a local training program obtained support from local and national leaders to ensure the workshop was successful. The original training and subsequent ones encouraged members' commitment in two ways. First, the information that participants received during the training facilitated their contribution to the public awareness campaign. Second, those who attended the main event and organized others in their local groups increased their commitment by engaging in leadership roles. On both occasions, members became personally available to contribute to the organization in ways that were previously out of their reach.

Additionally, PAH builds skills among its members during its public actions through a system called *one does and another looks*. During the planning of any action, members are assigned roles. In an eviction blockade, there is a group in charge of blocking the entrance of the building with their bodies; another waits inside the flat with the family under risk of eviction; there is also somebody who negotiates with the judicial entourage. On top of these tasks, some members have the role of *looking*. The person in charge of negotiating the postponement of the eviction with the judicial entourage is accompanied by one or two people who will stand in silence and contemplate the arguments, expressions, and reactions of the negotiator.

Education during organizational activities is often followed by a period of discussion to reflect on the takeaways of the action. If the eviction blockade is successful, and there are no more actions planned for the day, it is common for people to gather for a coffee. Even if this is a casual gathering, the *doer* coaches the *lookers* amid the cheerful environment after the victory. Often, this happens as part of the celebration in a conversational way ('Did you see the reaction from the bank representative when I said this?', 'you really cracked it when you did that thing'). Other times, the

conversation is more explanatory and formal. The *doer* goes through the negotiation, explaining what happened, how she reacted, and other possible scenarios that are common. Yet on other occasions, it is the *lookers* who informally lead the coaching with their questions. Through this process, rank-and-file activists learn and are encouraged to take on leadership roles during public activities.

With the help of more experienced activists, who encourage less seasoned peers to become more involved, training during organizational activities encourages members to take on new roles in an almost unconscious way.

> Soon after I joined, [a leader] told me—"come to negotiate with me", and I said—"no, I don't know how to do this, and I am scared of doing it".—"Just come with me and listen, you don't need to speak". And I started going with [the leader] and other people in charge of negotiations until I learned and started doing it myself. (Beneficiary member, 30 July 2017, Barcelona)

As *lookers* become used to being present in this type of setting, they start assuming a more active role in the actions. Furthermore, beyond learning the necessary skills to engage in more activities, being trained increases members' perceptions of self-efficacy. The fact that leaders invest their time and energy to train less experienced people shows newcomers that their contributions are valued. This perception gives *lookers* greater confidence that they can replicate the behavior they have observed and encourages them to take on new tasks.

Building knowledge and skills makes members more personally available by increasing their objective and subjective self-efficacy. Objectively, they become able to engage in the activities of the movement in a more effective way, as they learn the necessary tools to do so. Subjectively, the act of being trained shows members that their contribution is appreciated. The fact that leaders invest their time and energy to help less experienced people increase their impact shows newcomers that their contributions are valued, encouraging them to take on new tasks. Moreover, encouragement and knowledge help members to navigate the limitations that their biographical availability may impose on them. If a referential leader invites somebody to do something, this person will make more effort to juggle the rest of her commitments so she can accommodate the new task. Gaining skills facilitates this action, as members learn to perform

organizational tasks dedicating less energy and time. Though their alternative commitments may not have changed, they will better contribute to the movement while dedicating the same time they used to.

Empowerment as a Way and as a Goal

In PAH, empowerment is perceived both as part of the process to achieve other goals as well as an objective in itself. On the one hand, PAH's emphasis on empowerment has increased the capacity of its members, PAH as an organization, as well as the wider community of people facing eviction to gain control over their affairs. From the individual perspective, PAH has managed to turn thousands of passively involved individuals into organizational leaders. As an organization, PAH has now become one of the most respected voices in the debates around housing in Spain (Martínez, 2019). Finally, it has provided those trapped in their mortgages with a loudspeaker to defend their rights. While the organization was created by six people who were not affected by the problem of mortgages (Santos, 2020), beneficiary constituents are now part of its leadership and public faces. Furthermore, through being able to achieve policy changes such as greater commitment from institutions to prevent evictions of people with no housing alternatives, PAH has also placed the wider community or people facing eviction, even those who are not part of the organization, in a better position to be able to defend their right to housing.

On the other hand, PAH's organizational culture celebrates empowerment as a goal in itself and uses the term on numerous occasions. It is common for activists to refer to a peer as 'somebody who is very empowered' as a way of showing respect or for them to mention that they want to become empowered to solve their cases. Many even make references to empowerment as a process.

> When I arrived at PAH, I was not empowered. I was depressed. I was scared to talk to my bank and had no idea what my rights were. Then, I became empowered as an individual, I was able to defend my case. If I go to the bank now, I don't let them trick me. I became empowered by the movement. When I arrived at PAH, I didn't know anyone and now I have my family here, and I am part of the leadership … yes, you could say that I am part of the leadership in a way. But this happened little by little. First, I learned a lot from [a leader] … he helped me a lot. He pushed me to do

> things I didn't think I could do. And then, you start doing things by yourself—and you are scared—but then you realize that you can actually do them. And then you enjoy being at PAH so much that you try to find time anywhere, so that you can do more stuff here, hang out more with everyone here. (Beneficiary member, 25 August 2017, Barcelona)

For many members, being more empowered, and more available to participate in more activities, is an objective. They find ways to liberate time to dedicate to PAH. They want to learn new skills, explore the emotions they feel and try to work on them and to meet more people from other organizations. In doing so, they are empowering themselves, but their efforts are also being facilitated by the organizational context, the reactions from their peers, and the organizational culture that cherishes empowerment.

These dynamics function as organizational rituals of empowerment because they are part of a routine that most newcomers go through and, once they have started, organizational dynamics guide them almost unconsciously in their progress. While newcomers' actions are not new to them and have not had a particularly relevant impact in the past, the organizational context turns them into important milestones in their lives. Members remember vividly the first time they spoke in the assembly or when they requested the deed in lieu of foreclosure at their bank office. When I asked respondents about what their first contribution to PAH was, many of them mentioned cleaning the office, caring for children in the ChikiPAH, and cooking. While these non-public contributions often pass unnoticed, their appreciation in PAH turns them into important moments for their activism. Moreover, the integration into organizational networks happens without newcomers noticing it. Most of their initial interactions are guided by self-interested logic: they inquire with others about how they have progressed with their cases, so they learn how to do it themselves, and they ask about how to perform the tasks they were advised to do. However, these exchanges generate what Nepstad (2008) calls 'affective commitment'. Pleasurable interactions with other members create strong bonds and cultural rewards that foster participation. These easily accessible contributions facilitate engagement in activities that were once out of newcomers' reach. They reassure newcomers' perceptions of self-efficacy, encouraging them to engage in more complex activities.

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Emotional Care: From the Sentiments of Eviction to the Feelings of Contention

When I arrived at PAH Barcelona's welcome assembly for the first time, I entered the room and took a chair in the last row to better observe the dynamics among the members. I stayed quiet during the three hours of the assembly, occasionally writing in my notebook. I did not want to interact much with anyone, as I was concerned about how welcome a person with no mortgage problems would be among members who were experiencing extremely serious troubles and sharing personal stories. I did not want to appear too curious or disrespectful, so I took some time to observe and understand the interactions of the group before conversing with anybody.

Without knowing it, I was replicating the behavior of many newcomers to PAH's assemblies, but for very different reasons. The feelings of shame, guilt, and panic that most people who are unable to meet their mortgage payments experience create a shield of introversion that complicates their interactions with others. As is the case with many newcomers, my relative inaction did not mean that I did not participate in some of the rituals that took place in the assembly. As I explain below, many of PAH's activities involve rituals where participants are involved, even if they do not actively take part in them. During these rituals the coming together of bodies and the common focus of attention generate 'high emotional energy' (Collins, 2004) and energizing emotions, which contrast with the constant feelings of shame, guilt, and fear that people trapped in their mortgages experience

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F. G. Santos, *Social Movements that Care*,
https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-031-74296-5_5

routinely in their daily lives. It was impossible not to empathize with the strong personal stories that people shared about how they got trapped in their mortgages, how families collapsed over tensions due to financial distress, the constant calls from their bank offices, issues of depression, and attempts of suicide. I was moved by the support shown by the rest of the people in the assembly to somebody who was a complete stranger. Members hugged the person when they collapsed, repeatedly said that they were there for them, and showed solidarity, committing to help each other overcome their financial troubles.

After the assembly ended, a woman came to talk to me 'are you new? I haven't seen you here before. Are you here for problems paying your rent or your mortgage?' When I explained to her that I was new but that I was a researcher, she answered, 'Ah, okay! It's just that sometimes it is difficult to speak for the first time and I was just checking in with you'. Months later, I realized the importance of this type of interaction. When a call for an eviction blockade was cancelled and somebody asked about the reason in *PAHmilia*, they received the following answer:

> [The eviction blockade] has been cancelled. We had not managed to convince the family that it was worth fighting and that with PAH *it is possible*.[1] This is a reminder that it is everybody's responsibility to pay attention in the assembly to those people that struggle more to talk or that we notice that stop attending the assemblies because they are anxious and scared. We all need to pay attention.

The woman who came to speak with me did not do it only because she wanted to get to know me. She wanted to care for me and act as an emotional support in case I did not participate in the assembly because I was emotionally overwhelmed. More experienced PAH members are aware of the difficulties of coming out in public and admitting that they are unable to pay for their dwelling. This is because they have either passed through that experience themselves or they have seen the consequences of not receiving emotional care during their beginnings in the organization. Many people are so ashamed that they have not spoken about their financial problems with anybody, sometimes not even in their closest circles. Talking publicly in front of an assembly of more than 100 strangers is not

[1] The expression *¡Sí, se puede!* (Yes, it is possible!) has become PAH's motto and it is commonly repeated during the interactions among members and the organization's activities.

an easy task. This is one of the most relevant reasons why passive recruitment takes place. As in the example of the Telegram conversation above, the weight that emotions represent may be too heavy to carry by oneself, resulting in some people giving up if they do not receive emotional care when they need it most.

These situations exemplify the two ways in which emotional care occurs in PAH. The first is rituals performed in the different activities of the organization, where care is embedded in the dynamics of the movement. Rather than specific people, it is the organization that cares for its members through actions that are repeated with assiduity. The second way in which emotional care happens is through personal interactions. These exchanges are not structured but depend on the capacity of different members to empathize and connect with each other. In this chapter, I elaborate on these two types of emotional care and explore how they are performed during the activities organized by PAH as well as the impact that they have on its members.

The Emotions of Eviction

Facing eviction and financial distress are experiences that are emotionally overwhelming. Buying a house is a defining moment for most people's lives, as it is a long-term project that is generally associated with starting a family and the beginning of a stable future. Some authors have even argued that owning their homes is a defining feature of the Spanish transition to adulthood (Schwartz, 2022). The most common emotions when debtors start facing financial troubles are despair, frustration, and anxiety (Ramis-Pujol, 2013). Once they default on their mortgage payments and a foreclosure procedure starts, sadness, melancholy, guilt, and shame are the feelings that take over individuals (Ibid.). The common denominator of these two processes is that all the feelings reported can be categorized as immobilizing emotions.

Immobilizing emotions are feelings that prevent individuals from taking action or interacting with others. Throughout the different stages of being trapped in a mortgage, the feelings reported are those associated with inaction. Furthermore, if certain emotional experiences are repeated enough, they generate what some authors have called an 'emotional habitus' (Gould, 2009; Kane, 2001). An emotional habitus is either the conscious or unconscious embodiment of certain ways of feeling and norms about emotions and their expression that we carry with us outside of the

moments when we experience them. The immobilizing emotions of those trapped in their mortgages are present in their everyday lives, as they are reminded them of by the constant calls from bank clerks and debt collection agencies. They return every month with each new installment one is unable to pay and every purchase one has to think twice about.

> I would receive calls every day, including Sundays. They started at 7am and finished at 2 or 3pm. Some days, they could have easily called me ten or fifteen times. When I decided not to answer their calls, they began calling my neighbors. I used to live in a very small village, and everyone knew each other, so it was easy to find my neighbors' landline in the phone book. There is a moment that you are so ashamed that you don't want to leave your home. Imagine, so many years have passed [since she had these problems] and, even now, if my phone rings and it is a number I don't know, I get anxiety attacks. (Beneficiary member, 8 April 2018, Pontevedra—phone interview).

As defaulters routinely experience feelings related to mortgage problems, immobilizing emotions go beyond the specific interactions in relation to their debt and they turn into a habitus that expands to all aspects of their lives. Something as common and easy as answering a phone call becomes an insurmountable challenge due to the immobilizing emotions experienced in the past. These become such a strong emotional habitus that it persists even after several years of solving their mortgage problem. During my conversations with PAH's beneficiary activists, three immobilizing emotions had a particular weight: shame, guilt, and panic. These three emotions and their perpetuation in emotional habitus are crucial to understanding the roots of the personal unavailability of people trapped in their mortgages to engage in social movements or other types of contentious collective action.

Shame

Once somebody starts having problems paying their mortgage installments, shame becomes part of their daily life. In addition to the shame that banks try to impose on defaulters with their calls, the origin of shame lies in cultural factors, in particular the neoliberal housing ideology where conceptions of citizenship (Gonick, 2014; Palomera, 2014) and adulthood (Schwartz, 2022) are associated with being able to participate in the

housing market and honor their debts. Under this cultural context, migrants and urban poor populations were encouraged to become indebted to access housing and show that they were 'responsible enough' to be considered 'good citizens' (Di Feliciantonio, 2017). Beyond the stigmatization of poverty that is common in most capitalist societies (Gilens, 1999; Purdy, 2003; Wacquant, 2008), failure to live by societal expectations made people trapped in their mortgages feel ashamed of their situation.

> They told us, or at least they told us at that time, that the best you could do was to buy a house. Owning a house was a social objective. We had a life project that involved having a family, having kids, owning a house, being able to pay for their house, having a car… and then, the crisis comes, and you lose your job, you don't get any more gigs; you lose everything, and you find that you are broke, and it is tough to admit it in public. It is tough because you feel ashamed, because it is a personal failure, because you don't want others to know that they are confiscating your stuff, that you cannot afford to pay for your home, that you don't have enough to fill the fridge. (Beneficiary member, 22 August 2017, Barcelona)

Even if evicting a family from their home is a shameful act, the victims of these reprehensible actions are those who experience embarrassment for being unable to overcome the expulsion. This is what has been referred to as the 'shame of passivity' (Vetlesen, 2005, p. 204). Shame is further reinforced by the lack of understanding of their close circles, or the expectation thereof. Even after many years of having solved their troubles, there are members who are still embarrassed to share their stories.

> Both of my parents are relatively high-ranked civil servants, so my family has always been well-off. So, they would not understand. Imagine, to this date [nine years after having been evicted], my father does not know that I have been evicted, because he would not understand it. Now that everything has passed, my mother knows about it, but my father still doesn't know anything. (Beneficiary member, 13 September 2017, Madrid).

Even well-intended initiatives and institutions might contribute to the increasing feelings of shame to those facing financial difficulties. The stigmatization of poverty means that people who depend on help from charities and administrations are often embarrassed of needing their assistance.

Some people trapped in their mortgages felt humiliated by the processes that they had to pass through to obtain such help.

> I remember the first time I went to the Red Cross [to receive charity food] and there was a queue to enter their office. I was really embarrassed. Imagine, Masnou is a village. Everybody was going to know about this. (Beneficiary member, 19 July 2017, Barcelona)

Shame is a heavy burden for many people who are considering approaching PAH. Embarrassment discourages publicity and complicates engaging in collective activities to confront their struggle. Shame has an obsessive quality and damages the self to the extent that 'we cannot undertake coordinated actions with others, cannot be part of a parade or rally; instead we try to avoid others' (Jasper, 2018, p. 136). Those trapped in their mortgages could barely discuss their problems with their closest circles, so sharing their situation at an assembly was not even imaginable for most of them, let alone engaging in collective and public claim-making activities. Shame acts as a barrier for those who are considering approaching PAH and then need to introduce themselves in an assembly. However, overcoming shame is even more difficult when one has to join a public action.

> When it comes to participating in your first protest, shame is a real struggle. If you are in a very big PAH, like Barcelona, you may be fine because you have at least 30 people joining each action, so you can hide. But here in Pontevedra we may be five people in a bank protest, so it is difficult to hide. If you are with another four people, you will be seen if the press comes, if we upload a picture to Twitter… and then, anyone can see you, anyone can know that you are going through a foreclosure procedure. (Beneficiary member, 8 April 2018, Pontevedra—phone interview)

Guilt

During the housing boom, the neoliberal logic of the self-made man spread widely in Spain. Success in life was perceived to be solely dependent on their capacity and hard work. When the financial crisis came, this model of 'personal responsibilization' persisted (Di Feliciantonio, 2017). Those who were hit by the economic downturn considered the worsening of their life conditions to be their own individual failure. Social discourses placed blame on individual debtors and rarely questioned the lending habits of financial institutions and whether they incurred too much risk. Banks

themselves contributed to this framing from the position of power that mortgage contracts provided them. Despite the knowledge asymmetries when mortgages were signed and the fact that many banks included illegal clauses in the contracts (for the court case judging the illegality of these clauses, see Consumidores: Condiciones Generales Abusivas; Claúsula Suelo en los Prèstamos Hipotecarios, 2013), it was debtors who broke the agreement when they stopped paying. Hence, they used this power to reinforce the feeling of guilt of those trapped in their mortgages.

> When I stopped paying, I started receiving calls from my bank office. 'Why aren't you paying? Do whatever you want. We don't care how you do it, but you need to pay us'. Then, you start being called by a debt collection company, and harassment is much worse. They call you like 'you spent all your money shopping clothes, you go shopping every day, and then you have no money left to pay your debts'. Other times is not even what they tell you, but how they do it. You are guilty for everything. There is no other point of view. And they talk to you with such a disdain. They talk to you as if they were so much superior to you. (Beneficiary member, 27 July 2017, Barcelona)

The feeling of guilt leads to the acceptance of their eviction. Guilt generates feelings of discontent with oneself, a sense of worthlessness, and anxiety (Phillips, 2014 [1986]). Culturally, feeling guilty of something comes together with the will of expiation (Jasper, 2018) and the bank's reaction to their default may be perceived as an appropriate way of atonement.

Panic

There are few things that produce more panic than the risk of losing one's home. According to Jasper, panic can sometimes be a 'deep mood', meaning an emotion that mediates how we experience the world (Jasper, 2018, p. 125). As Ratcliffe explains, 'in order to be afraid, one must already find oneself in the world in such a way that being in danger or under threat are possibilities' (Ratcliffe, 2009, p. 355). Panic generates a constant feeling of danger that immobilizes individuals. Moreover, panic does not need to be substantiated by reality. In the common case that defaulters do not know the details of the relevant legislation, they may believe in any threat that they receive. Despite eviction notices should include the date and time of the event, this legal unawareness leads those trapped in their

mortgages to believe that these hazards may come anytime. Those trapped in their mortgages live in a constant state of panic, as they believe that they are continually at risk.

> At the beginning, because of the lack of information, I thought that they could come and kick me out any day and, of course, that was such an anguish. I would think 'what if they come now?', 'what if they come at 4 in the morning?' It was horrible. I don't wish it to anyone. Once—now it's an anecdote that I laugh at but before it was not funny at all—I was calmly at home with my partner and we hear that somebody is introducing a key into our door. I automatically jumped from the sofa and went running to push on the door. I was pushing the door so they would not enter to kick us out. Then, it ended up being the neighbor from downstairs who pushed the wrong bottom of the elevator. Now I think about how ignorant and gullible I was, but at that moment, it was hell. (Beneficiary member, 20 April 2018, Blanes—phone interview)

Additionally, panic is reinforced by the threats that defaulters experience. It is common for bank clerks to threaten debtors if they do not bring their accounts up to date after the default. These threats range from real possibilities, such as eviction, to decisions that are outside of the banks' control, like prison sentences and other legal punishments that do not necessarily apply to their case. As a mother of two children, recalled: 'I was afraid because [the bank clerks] threatened me to remove the custody of my daughters. My daughters, if they take my daughters, they take my life!' (Beneficiary member, 30 July 2017, Barcelona). Although the bank clerks do not have the capacity to decide the custody of children, the constant feeling of danger produced by panic leads people trapped in their mortgages to believe these intimidations.

To some degree, the feeling of threat may instigate mobilization (van Dyke & Soule, 2002), but the constant state of being in danger produces an immobilizing panic. One does not act outside of established routines and norms in order to avoid the possible hazards that the new moves may bring. Panic leads those trapped in their mortgages to avoid approaching PAH because they are scared of whether they will be accepted by the group. This panic makes them refrain from considering confronting their banks because they are scared of the consequences of such action. Some bank clerks use the state of panic of those trapped in their mortgages to tell them explicitly that joining PAH will only bring more miseries. More

generally, panic complicates participation in any activity outside of an individual's comfort zone or that carries any degree of confrontation.

Emotional Care: From the Sentiments of Eviction to the Feelings of Contention

One of the biggest challenges that PAH faced was the development of dynamics that confronted immobilizing emotions and generated positive emotional energy. Emotions may last differently. As Jasper (2018) explains, reflex emotions are feelings that arise as a reaction to a specific situation; urges are emotional reactions to physical experiences; moods last longer and affect the peace of our actions outside the context where they were generated; and affective and moral commitments are long-term combinations of feelings that we have in relation to other humans and ideas. All these types of emotions influence people's eagerness to participate in contentious collective activities, and activists need to address them.

Emotional care consists of interactions that generate high emotional energy—'a feeling of confidence and enthusiasm for social interaction' (Collins, 2004, p. 108)—, and energizing emotions while they confront activists' immobilizing feelings. These relations bring positive reflex emotions and create moods that foster energizing motivations and link organizational members and ideas to positive affective and moral commitments. At the same time, care provides members with the emotional tools to manage the avoidance reflexes that may appear while participating in the movement's activities. Even in organizations that pay attention to care, fear may appear when confronting incumbents and the police.

> The first time I joined a bank protest, the police came and cleared us out. They were lifting us one by one and moving us out of the bank office. When they asked me to move, my legs became paralyzed. I could not move them at all. So, I had to tell them that I would be happy to collaborate and move, but that I was so scared that my legs were not responding. (Beneficiary member, 16 August 2017, Barcelona)

Furthermore, members may experience anger and conflicts among them, and activists may feel humiliated when their strategic or ideology position is the minority view. In these situations, healthy organizational dynamics, the previously generated high emotional energy, approach moods, and positive affective and moral commitments help members deal with their

avoidance reflexes—sometimes even longer-term emotions—in a constructive manner.

In PAH, emotional care is performed through two dynamics. On the one hand, organizational activities are often composed of rituals of emotional care. During these dynamics, it is the group who cares for activists through rituals where individuals perform certain tasks and the coming together of members with a shared focus of attention produces emotional reactions. On the other hand, emotional care is performed through intimate networks. These individual relations, to a large extent, depend on personal affinities and consist of the individualized emotional support that members often give to each other.

Rituals of Emotional Care

Although everyone feels emotions, we often do not have control over them. Some scholars have gone as far as arguing that they do not really belong to people, but are rather situated in social contexts (Albrow, 1997; Taylor, 2000). Organizations can create 'distinctive emotion cultures that include expectations about how members should feel about themselves and about dominant groups, as well as how they should manage and express the feelings evoked by their day-to-day encounters with dominant groups' (Taylor, 2000, p. 274). They perform them through rituals during which activists share an emotional focus and attention that produces a shared reality and emotional state. Rituals in relation to SMOs can range from the structure of assemblies and the roles expected from individuals to public events, such as demonstrations and collective acts of civil resistance, like an eviction blockade. For the case of PAH, its welcome assemblies and public events are of particular relevance for understanding how rituals can contribute to emotional care.

Emotional Empowerment During the Welcome Assembly

Most PAH local groups have two weekly—or, for some smaller collectives, bi-weekly—assemblies. Depending on the strategic approach of each local PAH, these assemblies may take place on the same day, one after the other, or on separate days. The Coordination Assembly is the space where the strategic discussions of the organization take place. This meeting is open to the public, and it is where organizations debate about their campaigns, plan their upcoming actions, discuss internal issues that may arise, and the different committees update the whole group on their progress. I pay

more attention to this assembly and how it increases the perceptions of self-efficacy of PAH members in Chapter "Emotional Care: From the Sentiments of Eviction to the Feelings of Contention". The Welcome Assembly is often the first point of contact for newcomers. This is the space where newcomers introduce themselves, learn about PAH's philosophy and dynamics, and receive basic information about the process of foreclosure. It is also where members update the rest of the organization about the progress of their cases, present their doubts and challenges, and ask for support from the rest of their peers.

In addition to the self-help dynamics of the Welcome Assembly and how they support members in progressing with their struggle against banks, the interactions in this space have become a ritual that contributes to the emotional care and empowerment of members. During this ritual, hegemonic beliefs and emotional habitus are deconstructed and an alternative horizon and ways of feeling are presented. Then, the alternative emotional framing is confirmed through the stories of more experienced members.

The process of deconstruction of previous emotions and the production of new ways of feeling starts after a short introduction to PAH and its objectives. An experienced member of PAH presents the steps of the foreclosure process, challenging the most prevalent myths about it. At the center of the assembly, there are always copies of *PAH's Little Green Book*, which contains all the information discussed so newcomers can easily follow it and take it home to reflect in a calmer setting. The foreclosure process is divided into three steps: '(1) You have stopped paying or you know that soon you will', '(2) Beginning of the foreclosure procedure', and '(3) Repossession/eviction and debt reclaim' (Plataforma de Afectados por la Hipoteca, 2014).

During the first step, there is a discussion about the Spanish housing bubble and the problem of mortgages from a structural perspective. Instead of reproducing the dominant 'neoliberal discourses of personal responsibilization' (Di Feliciantonio, 2017, p. 38), the facilitators emphasize how the high rental prices and low interest rates of mortgages led people to choose the latter as their model to access housing. Moreover, banks are presented as careless institutions whose greed led them to give credit without paying attention to the financial sustainability of the debtor; thus making them responsible for each defaulted mortgage. There are also references to the bailout that Spanish banks received. Between 2008 and 2011, the Spanish government bailed out a number of financial

institutions with 64 billion euros, out of which 60 billion euros have been deemed impossible to recover (Banco de España, 2017). The facilitator explains that, instead of bailing out the thousands of families that were struggling economically, the government used their tax money to give it to the same financial institutions that were evicting them. Meanwhile, as constantly reminded during the assembly, many of these people found themselves in the dilemma of deciding between 'paying their mortgage or feeding their family' and decided to secure the dietary needs of their beloved ones. In this way, defaulting on their mortgage is presented as commonsensical. Survival is more important than meeting their financial commitments with an irresponsible institution that has been, anyway, bailed out with public funds. This decision is also framed as legally legitimate, as there was no obligation to bail banks out, but the right to housing is protected by the Spanish constitution.

The weekly exposure to this discourse helps people trapped in their mortgages to reinterpret their experiences. Similarly to how people use written texts to rationalize their personal stories (Wuthnow, 1994), the weekly repetition of PAH's discourse constitutes a sort of unwritten text that serves to help newcomers understand their past differently. The constant references to the juxtaposition of feeding their family or paying their mortgage during my interviews are a solid example of how these discourses stay beyond the space of the assembly.

> (1) We had a variable rate and, eventually, the installments start to rise and rise. Our priority was paying our home, so we started spending our savings in paying the mortgage […] eventually, we could not afford to pay anymore, so I went to tell the bank that I had to choose between paying and eating and that I could not live without food. (Beneficiary member, 30 July 2017, Barcelona)
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> (2) I got a gig cleaning a public swimming pool during the summer. They were paying me 1000 euros. So, from those 1000 euros, 900 would go to the mortgage and I would keep 100. Imagine, with 100 euros left for the whole month, you cannot even afford to eat properly. (Beneficiary member, 13 April 2018, Terrassa—phone interview)
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> (3) I would get gigs once in a while and I would give all the money I earned to the bank because they told me 'pay whatever you can, the important thing is that you show good faith'. I would even take 50 euros from the money for feeding my kids, which was a misery because what difference does 50 euros make if you have to pay 600 for the mortgage? But I finally had to tell the bank that I could not take food from my children, that I was feeling

> terrible. I could stop eating myself, but I could not take money from my children's food to pay the mortgage. (Beneficiary member, 8 April 2018, Seville—phone interview)

The first step in the explanation of the foreclosure process aims to question the overarching feelings of shame and guilt with which people trapped in their mortgages arrive at PAH's assembly. By questioning the hegemonic discourses about housing, the origins of the crisis, and the roots of individuals' default, PAH also challenges the reasons why its members feel ashamed and guilty. PAH questions the neoliberal commonsense of placing their financial obligations before their wellbeing and presents a new rationale where the shameful act would have been not caring for your loved ones. In other words, there is no shame in prioritizing that your family is well-fed over pleasing the greed of financial institutions. PAH points to the structural conditions of the Spanish housing model and the irresponsible behavior of incumbents to confront the social discourses that blame individuals for their default. Those to blame are not the ones who wanted to have a home, but the perpetrators of the scam, who pushed people into debt, and their accomplices, who legislated loosely to allow this and who transferred the money from those affected to the ones who committed the fault.

The second and third parts of the explanation discuss the process since people default until the day of the eviction and contribute to mitigating their panic. During this explanation, emphasis is placed on explaining how the foreclosure procedure is an ordered process regulated by courts, addressing some of the misconceptions about it. Some of the main takeaways from this part are that one cannot go to jail for not being able to repay their mortgage, that a foreclosure procedure needs to be started by a judge and notified in due time, and that social services cannot take one's children from their homes only because they defaulted on their mortgage.

The moderator explains the long process until a judge finally signs an eviction notice. First, the bank needs to inform debtors through a notarized letter about their outstanding debt and the deadline for its clearance. If the reclaimed debt is not paid by the given date, debtors will receive a foreclosure lawsuit that needs to be answered within ten days. After this period, the court sets the date for the public auction of the property that cannot be earlier than twenty days after this decision has been taken. In the common case that no buyers are found, the bank will acquire the property for up to 70% of its value and request an eviction date to be set by the

courts. At this moment, defaulters are advised to present an appeal to delay the process and have more time to negotiate and pressure the bank. This means that people trapped in their mortgages should expect that their eviction date will not come until at least three months after they receive the notarized letter from their bank.

Even if this information does not completely eliminate newcomers' panic, it does provide them with a temporal horizon that helps them not to feel constantly under threat. Eliminating uncertainty is crucial because if individuals cannot anticipate what will happen the day after, it is impossible to start any strategic engagement. Instead, they will only improvise based on the behavior of other actors. Once a person is able to have a temporal horizon in mind, it is also possible to plan for how to approach the problem, reduce the feelings of panic, and, eventually, initiate strategic interactions to confront their grievances.

After this overview, there is a period when newcomers introduce themselves and members update the assembly on their progress with their cases. This stage contributes to reinforcing the new framing presented by the moderator showing those trapped in their mortgages that their situation is more generalized than they thought. Seeing that other people are going through the same problems contributes to moving the blame from the individuals to financial actors and structural factors. Before joining PAH, people trapped in their mortgages saw their problems as idiosyncratic. It is their behavior that led them to their default because, as many media outlets and political figures argued to justify the crisis and austerity cuts, they 'lived above their possibilities' (e.g., El Economista, 2011). Once newcomers are exposed to the new framing from PAH and see that there are many others going through the same circumstances, they question their feelings of guilt and consider their problems within a wider frame of injustice. The new framing encourages newcomers to speak up and turns their shame and guilt into anger.

> I took five weeks to speak [at the assembly], I stayed in the corner because… well… you arrived at PAH with a huge sense of guilt. You think that you did something wrong when, in fact, you did nothing wrong. We all were scammed. And you see so many people there with you, and they all have passed through the same. Then, you realize that you should not feel guilty, because it was not your fault. You should feel pissed because they fooled you. (Beneficiary member, 27 July 2017, Barcelona)

Moreover, the temporal horizon presented during the explanation about the foreclosure process is confirmed by members' stories when they update the assembly on their progress. Newcomers can see that other people facing their circumstances are still in their homes and have started negotiations to prevent their eviction. These stories present a new dynamic where, instead of improvising based on the bank's actions, it is people trapped in their mortgages who are initiating strategic interactions. This gives newcomers the hope of having a sense of control over their lives and shows them that they do not need to feel under constant threat. Of course, the fear of eviction does not disappear, but these dynamics concentrate the episodes of fear in concrete moments that can be anticipated. Moreover, they show newcomers that they can take action to mitigate the risks they face. In this way, they are encouraged to start strategic interactions to confront banks.

> When we met [PAH], we got to know that it is not true that your salary can be confiscated from one day to another. I receive my paycheck on the first day of each month. Each of those nights, I would set the alarm on my telephone for 2.05am or so and I would go running to withdraw the money, because I thought that otherwise they would confiscate it. […] When I met [PAH], they told me that they could not confiscate all my salary. […] I also got to know that I could not be sent off my house from one day to another, that there is a process for this. It is already 2 years [since the foreclosure procedure started] and I know that there will be still another year, at least until they will kick me out of my home, and I am still living in my apartment. […] If they ever kick me out of this flat and I finally have to leave it, I will come back again. I will come back to this apartment or I will enter into another one. Many people do that, and I intend to do it. One would not do these things if they treated us well. (Statement from PAH member collected by Herranz, 2012)

Listening to other people's stories about how they have successfully gone through an eviction blockade, or have managed to advance in their negotiations after calling for a protest at their bank office, addresses newcomers' fear of the consequences they may face if they confront their banks. Bank clerks often threaten people trapped in their mortgages with worse consequences if they join PAH. This is probably a good measure of the popularity and success that the organization has achieved. However, when one is overwhelmed by panic, it may work as a discouragement to approach the group. Furthermore, even when people have already joined several

PAH events, they are reticent to ask for action to support their specific case because they are still fearful that the bank clerk's threats become reality.

Something similar happens with public administrations. Despite the fact that social housing should be allocated based on objective reasons regarding the need and urgency of each specific case, the shortage of social housing stock creates a situation where there are often many urgent cases unattended. Under this context, local representatives and public workers may threaten to prioritize other applicants if PAH organizes a protest supporting a case. I listened to those threats myself during one of the accompaniments I was part of in the town of L'Hospitalet de Llobregat. After having blocked the eviction of a family of four twice, the court decided to send an *open eviction* notice, which is an eviction notice that, instead of having an exact date, declares a date from which the expulsion can take place any time. Seeing the difficulty of organizing an eviction blockade under these circumstances, PAH Barcelona organized an action in front of L'Hospitalet de Llobregat's town hall to force the local government to sit on an urgent negotiating table to provide that family with social housing. After some time of protest, a group of people were allowed to enter the building and speak with a representative. When a representative of PAH informed the town representative that it had been decided to organize an encampment in front of the town hall should no solution be found during that meeting, the elected official threatened to place other families ahead in the list, should PAH take that line of action. While that threat would scare anyone facing an open eviction, the spokesperson from PAH reminded the representative that, should that happen, the town hall would be engaging in a crime of malfeasance.

Being exposed to success stories and celebrating them with the rest of members helps newcomers overcome the fears of confronting incumbents for their own cases because they see that those intimidations rarely become true.

> The Welcome Assembly is a fundamental part of PAH, listening to people that has passed through the same as you and that they tell you 'I have gone to a STOP Evictions and it is fine' or 'I have done this, and it has worked for me'. You are convinced by their experiences that what you heard before is possible. (Beneficiary member, 28 May 2018, Sabadell—phone interview)

Additionally, as I elaborate below, the stories heard during assemblies are confirmed by their participation in public actions.

The Emotional Care of Eviction Blockades

In PAH, public actions contribute to emotional care. They often seek to confront feelings of avoidance, as well as to generate high emotional energy and energizing emotions. The internal message of PAH's flagship campaign, *STOP Desahucios*, is aimed at mitigating the panic with which people who are at risk of losing their homes live. During assemblies, it is common for newcomers to be encouraged to have hope because 'once they are part of PAH, they will never be without a place to live'. However, the statements during an assembly may sound like idealistic promises that are part of the dramatization of any social movement (Polletta, 2006; Tilly, 2008). When members participate in eviction blockades, they see PAH's capacity to stop evictions and, more importantly, *their own* evictions.

Joining an eviction blockade addresses members' panics in two ways. On the one hand, it shows them that through their involvement in the organization, their fears can be confronted. Through eviction blockades, newcomers see the usefulness of civil resistance and collective struggles because they become part of other people's victories that may be their own in the future. On the other hand, participating in eviction blockades normalizes engaging in confrontations with frightening incumbents such as bank representatives, police agents, and the judicial entourage. Those actors were at the center of the nightmares of people trapped in their mortgages because they were those who would expulse them from their homes. Through participation in other people's eviction blockades, PAH members become used to confronting those actors that they did not dare to oppose in the past.

Furthermore, eviction blockades constitute an 'emotional battery' (Jasper, 2012). The negative pole of the battery is the fear experienced while the group is waiting for the judicial entourage and the often-heated arguments when they arrive. The positive pole is the high emotional energy when the parties sign the document confirming the postponement of the eviction. Victory is cheerfully celebrated shouting *¡Sí, se puede!* The signed document becomes the symbol of the triumph, and pictures of the whole group with the affected person in the middle holding the certificate are taken. The juxtaposition of these two feelings and the victory of the latter reinforce the energizing emotions of the victory over the fear

experienced at the beginning; thus contributing to eliminating the panic that many members suffer from.

The ritual of an eviction blockade contributes to emotional care also by questioning the feelings of shame and guilt of people trapped in their mortgages. While shame discourages publicity, an eviction blockade represents the visualization of what used to be an action hidden from the public view. Evictions that are not contested often proceed in silence. It is either the family who vacates the apartment before they are expulsed or they leave peacefully once the judicial entourage and the police forces arrive. During these episodes, shame and guilt reinforce and are reinforced by invisibility. Immobilizing emotions encourages people to leave quietly. The lack of social reactions while a family loses their home acts as a confirmation that what they are facing is right because nobody questions it. The ritual of an eviction blockade breaks this dynamic.

When PAH members assemble in front of the building before an eviction, they try to gather as much attention as possible. They all arrive wearing PAH's famous green t-shirts and they chant while they wait for the judicial entourage to arrive. This ritual breaks the will of avoidance encouraged by shame and, instead, highlights the pride of opposing an eviction and the will to make it public. One of the common slogans chanted during eviction blockades is *¡Este desahucio lo vamos a parar!* (We will stop this eviction!). This slogan frames the person at risk of eviction and the rest of the group as active agents publicly opposing the foreclosure. Instead of hiding that somebody is being expulsed, they make the situation public and show that they are proudly confronting it. Moreover, other chants challenge the hegemonic distribution of guilt that blames those suffering evictions. When PAH members sing *¡Vecino, Despierta! ¡Desahucian en tu puerta!* (Neighbor, wake up! They are evicting someone in front of your door!), they are pointing at who is responsible for the eviction. Emphasis is not placed on the action through a passive voice—an eviction is happening—. Instead, the active voice points at the subject of the sentence—*they* are evicting—, highlighting those who are to blame. Bank representatives, police forces, and the judicial entourage are framed as the perpetrators of the eviction. Moreover, the call to neighbors to wake up and be present for what is happening, or even take action, frames the eviction as something illegitimate that should not pass unnoticed. In this way, the perpetrators of an illegitimate action are the ones who should be blamed.

Through its chants before an eviction blockade, PAH is sending the message to those at risk of losing their homes that they should not be

ashamed or feel guilty. It is their opponents who should experience those sentiments. Furthermore, the fact that this counter-framing takes place in the street sends the message that the ways of feeling presented by PAH are socially acceptable and can be shown in public. Hence, it is not only PAH that tells its members that they should not feel guilty and ashamed, their neighbors and society at large also accept this claim.

Naming and Shaming as Emotional Care

PAH's campaign *Que se Sepa: Este Banco Engaña, Estafa y Echa a la Gente de su Casa* (Let it Be Known: This Bank Cheats, Swindles, and Kicks People out of Their Homes) aims at pressuring bank offices that did not want to progress in the negotiations towards postponing evictions and accepting the deed in lieu of foreclosure. It consists of sticking posters and stickers reading the slogan of the campaign at bank offices during the night. Sticking usually takes place on Friday evening, with the purpose of leaving the signs at the bank office's doors and windows during the weekend. Beyond placing pressure on non-collaborative offices, this campaign also contributes to switching the shame and guilt from those trapped in their mortgages to the banks.

> [The *Que se sepa: Este banco engaña, estafa y echa a la gente de su casa* campaign] aims at signaling at the one that should be blamed for our situation. Basically, banks cheated because they signed abusive mortgages. They swindled because they included clauses that were against the law. And, in addition to cheating and swindling, they also kick you out of your home. This generated a collective understanding among our people that went beyond the rhetoric to which they were used to. When people were exposed to it, they would say 'shit, of course! This is so true!' (Non-beneficiary member, 22 June 2017, Barcelona)

According to this campaign, foreclosures are not the result of their default. Instead, they are the consequence of the banks' decisions and actions. Additionally, it is not only that banks have decided to evict families, but they have also cheated and deceived them before doing that. Following the rhetoric presented during PAH's Welcome Assemblies, those trapped in their mortgages are framed as the victims of an orchestrated scam, and this rip-off should be known by the wider population. Through this public action of naming and shaming, blame is placed on financial institutions. Banks are accused of engaging in socially condemned, and even illegal,

behavior such as cheating and swindling. Hence, they are not only guilty of evictions, but they should also be ashamed for engaging in other illegitimate practices.

One of the biggest achievements of PAH is the transformation of the collective imaginary, to turn things around. For many people, now it may seem obvious that their debt must be cancelled, that they must stay in their home paying a social rent, that banks are crooks, and so on. But it has taken a long journey moving from 'but nobody put a gun on your head to sign the mortgage', 'you were very happy when you could ask for enough money for your home, your car and your holidays in the mortgage'. This campaign turns this over, and the slogan is easy to internalize for everyone. And this is amazing because it means that before you thought that it was your fault that you could not continue paying, that you screwed it up when you signed [the mortgage], that it was your fault. And then you start to understand that this is nothing new, that there was a long journey to arrive at this point; that there was a great degree of collusion from public administrations for this to happen; that this is not your fault, that this is not your personal failure. What happened here is a generalized scam. This was really a fraud. So, this serves you to remove a lot of your feeling of guilt and then, you also identify an enemy against whom to fight. (Founder, 15 August 2017, Barcelona).

This respondent is right in saying that this type of campaign went beyond changing the emotional habitus of PAH's members, contributing to changes in the social allocation of guilt. A 2013 nationally representative survey from *El País* showed that 9 out of 10 Spaniards agreed with the claims of PAH (El País, 2013).

Emotional Care One-on-One

Beyond the rituals developed within PAH, during which the dynamics that take place are more important than the actions performed by a specific person, another component of emotional care is the relations among individuals. These personal interactions help members to overcome the shame and panic they experience when making an active contribution. For instance, speaking at PAH's Welcome Assembly for the first time is a milestone for most members who were immobilized by their grievance and, at this stage, newcomers have not yet been exposed to the rituals of the organization. During these moments, one-to-one interactions provide comfort and give the necessary impetus to overcome the shame of making their first contribution.

> I did not intervene in my first assembly, but I was talking to [a member]. He sat next to me and, well; he gave me some individual advice; you know? He asked me about my situation and made me feel a bit calmer. I did not speak in the assembly, but [a member] made me feel more at ease. […] During my second assembly, [a member] also sat next to me. He recognized me from the Monday before and came next to me. I wanted to intervene, but there were many people talking, many speaking turns. So, I kept wondering 'do I ask for the speaking turn or not? Do I do it or not?' I was too nervous, or I don't know. So, [a member] requested the turn to speak and gave me the floor so I could talk. (Beneficiary member, 27 July 2017, Barcelona)

This support is not something that is expected from all movement members and, to a large extent, depends on the character of each individual, as well as on personal affinities. Yet, once newcomers receive the support of speaking at the assembly for the first time, they are more at ease contributing to the organization.

> Sometimes the assembly just feels too big, but if somebody comes to you and asks 'hey, how are you doing?', then it may be easier to share your miseries with that person. Then, once your miseries are out, it is also easier to share them with everyone. (Beneficiary member, 26 July 2017, Barcelona)

There are some members that are particularly well regarded, be it by the organization as a whole or by specific people, and whose emotional support may be more effective, or at least is more sought after. When members request an accompaniment during an assembly, most of those who will join them offer their company spontaneously. In principle, anybody's participation should have the same effect, as most accompanying members do not have an active role in the action. However, it is common that, after the assembly, the person who requested the accompaniment approaches specific people to encourage them to join as well. These people are generally either more experienced members or individuals with whom the person requesting the accompaniment feels that she has a closer relationship with. More experienced members provide the confidence that, should the affected person not be able to carry the negotiations as expected, they will redirect the discussion back on track. Hence, the affected person will have less fear of the possible negative consequences or not achieving their objective because they know that a veteran person can intervene. Moreover, activists with closer ties give confidence to the affected person because she

can develop greater trust in their commitment and their readiness to offer their support in case it is needed.

Moreover, while it is true that caring rituals are aimed at dealing with the emotions of newcomers, every person in the organization is cared for, even those in leadership positions. PAH's organizational leadership is, at many times, the recipient of person-to-person care. This emotional support helps leaders to confront the pressure from media and adversary political figures.

> We had a WhatsApp group that was called *PAHwer* and with *PAHwer* [a spokesperson] was never alone on TV. She was by herself at the TV set, but we were all there with her. We were writing to her all the time 'you look so pretty today', 'your hair looks amazing!' And after the debate or during the commercials, when she would say 'I did not do well today', we were all saying 'No! Are you crazy? You did fantastic!' I can imagine that, as a leader, one must feel very lonely, and we had to take a lot of care of [a spokesperson]. When you are such a visible person and you are attacking the banks, you are criticized on all sides and in many dirty ways. (Beneficiary member, 4 July 2017, Barcelona)

Hence, while the rituals developed within the movement have the objective of caring for those who probably need it most, every member of PAH receives emotional care to different degrees. Both leaders and the rest of the organizational members pass through worse and better moments during their involvement in PAH. Moreover, the intensity and amount of time that many leaders dedicate to activism may lead them to experience burnout (Strang & Jung, 2005). This is more the case when some of them receive media attention, and the consequent attacks from adversaries in institutional politics and the media, as was the case of many PAH leaders. In these cases, the emotional support from the rest of the members becomes many times crucial in the continuation of the involvement of leaders and their wellbeing.

Personal interactions of emotional care are of great importance because, despite the flashy actions and media appearances, it is the organizational community that sustains the activities of the collective. This is the dichotomy that Stall and Stoecker (1998) refer to when they highlight the difference between 'community organizing', which places more importance in the public sphere activities of a movement, and 'organizing community', which are works developed in the private sphere and which are aimed

at building and repairing relationships. It is common that these interactions pass unnoticed to an external observer because it is people who are not involved in the most visible roles of the organization who generally perform them.

> When you are in charge of coordinating on the Catalan level, or on the State level, or when you are participating in TV programs, you are focused on that, but there is an assembly that is alive, with people with problems, and we need to take care of each other. This is why all contributions are important and necessary. Even those that seem very small can make a big difference. (Non-beneficiary member, 20 June 2017, Barcelona)

Despite the more invisible impact, one-to-one emotional care is crucial to sustaining commitment to the group, and it is one of the reasons why many beneficiary constituents continue their involvement in PAH after they have solved their cases (Ancelovici & Emperador Badimon, 2021).

A Matter of Time

Shame, guilt, and panic do not magically disappear in one assembly. Likewise, nobody feels hopeful that they will solve their mortgage trouble after participating in the first STOP Evictions. In the beginning, the emotions generated by the rituals in PAH are reactions to the immediate environment which newcomers are exposed to. They are what Jasper calls 'reflex emotions' (Jasper, 2018). These feelings generally disappear when the person leaves the space of the ritual. This is the reason why during PAH's beginnings there were people who would call for an eviction blockade during an assembly but then vacate their apartment the day before the eviction, handing their keys to the bank. The social environment of the assembly temporally eliminated their fear and shame. It also gave them hope and confidence that they would be able to overcome their panic and confront the bank. Once they left that space and they joined their previous rituals and emotional habitus, shame, guilt, and panic returned and the eviction seemed again impossible to prevent.

Through repetition, these short-term reflex emotions become longer-term affects that are not exclusively dependent on the social environment individuals are immersed in. They become what Jasper calls 'moods' (Jasper, 2018). The reflex emotions generated in PAH's rituals are dependent on the congregation of bodies in the same physical space and the

shared focus of attention of participants. Nevertheless, the weekly reiteration of discourses and rituals in the assembly, as well as the experiences during accompaniments, protests, and eviction blockades facilitate the translation of the energizing emotions and high emotional energy generated in these activities to the rest of spheres of life. Slowly, newcomers are immersed in the new reality generated within PAH, internalize the new feelings, and experience them outside the organizational rituals.

More experienced members are aware of the temporality of the emotions felt during the assemblies and events, and emphasize the importance of participating regularly. Obviously, any organizational leader has an interest in numbers, as the strength of any movement depends, to a large extent, on the number of committed people it has. However, PAH leaders are also mindful of the temporal component of the emotions that are generated within the rituals of the organization.

> Many people come because their eviction is in a week and then, after we block it, we don't see them again until they receive their next eviction notice. Of course, we go and block their eviction again because nobody should end up in the street, but you know that they are never going to solve their problem. If you don't come to the assemblies, learn, participate in other accompaniments and STOP Evictions and see that *it is possible*, then you are never going to be empowered. (Founder, 22 June 2017, Barcelona)

For this leader, the difference between being aided through assistance-based logic or being able to take ownership of their struggle is internalizing the new emotional dynamics of the movement. Seeing that *it is possible* means internalizing the hope that is generated in the assembly, believing that things can be otherwise, and gaining confidence that they can achieve their objectives through their involvement in the organization.

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Identity Care and Becoming Activists

I was on my way to one of the many early morning eviction blockades organized by PAH Barcelona. As every member who goes to any public action, I was wearing PAH's green t-shirt. When I exited the metro, I stopped by a coffee shop next to the station to buy a coffee and a croissant to eat on my way to meeting the rest of the group. When I was going to pay, the barman did not let me. 'This one is on me. You guys do an amazing job'. Even if it was not a lot of money, the gratuity made me feel great. A well-intended stranger treating you for something and expressing their appreciation for you is a boost of self-esteem. It means that they acknowledge and respect you for what you do. It makes you feel authentic because that is not something that happens often. It was not difficult to understand that the free breakfast was due to PAH's t-shirt I was wearing. It connected me to a community to which I could feel proud belonging to. This moment made me wonder how this type of interactions make PAH members feel. After all, I was a relatively worry-free graduate student, whose problems could not compare to those of people facing eviction. While I was walking on the street, still sipping my free coffee, I concluded that PAH members would probably enjoy interactions such as these even more than I did.

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F. G. Santos, *Social Movements that Care*,
https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-031-74296-5_6

Defaulting One's Identity

The self-concept of a debtor in good faith is likely to be seriously challenged when they find that they cannot continue paying their mortgage. The risk of losing their home and putting the rest of their family at risk of becoming homeless will considerably deteriorate their appreciation for oneself. Moreover, they become dependent on personal networks, the bank, social services, and charity to cover their most basic needs, having the impression that they have no control over their life or capacity to influence it. Finally, admitting to being a defaulter and being poor challenges their previous self-perceptions as a homeowner. It should not come as a surprise that people with low self-esteem, who perceive themselves and their actions as meaningless and uninfluential, are discouraged from initiating strategic action (Jasper, 2006). In other words, those facing these circumstances will find it particularly challenging to act and collaborate in defying the status quo and those who are more powerful than they are.

The collective identities of those trapped in their mortgages are also affected. Many reject identifying as being somebody at risk of because admitting that they may lose their home challenges a fundamental pillar in their life. Consequently, not admitting it allows for sidelining problems, which ultimately leads to difficulties in rationalizing problematic situations. The stigma attached to being poor, a defaulter, or risking homelessness discourages individuals from relating to others who are in the same position. Furthermore, the dominant 'self-made man' discourse discourages forming and cultivating collective identities. This lack of collective identification complicated engaging in contentious collective activities, as failing to identify with other commonly aggrieved individuals hampers trust and commitment to the group, as well as the creation of boundaries between challengers and dominant groups.

Evictions and Self-Esteem

Defaulting on their mortgage and the adjacent experiences that often come with it, such as unemployment, has a tremendous impact on their self-esteem. When people buy a house, they often share a set of characteristics that contribute to having a high self-esteem. They generally have stable jobs with acceptable incomes. They may be starting a family and they probably have reasonable ideas about how their life will unfold. When housing is at risk, their life and their expectations of it change dramatically.

Defaulting on their mortgage is probably the outcome of either becoming unemployed or the result of a breakup. They may have the impression that their family and plans are put at risk because of their inability to behave in the way that produced the original favorable view of oneself.

> You know, you have a life-plan, and the plan is going great and, suddenly, you are out of that plan. All of a sudden, you say 'holy shit, I have just become homeless'. Even if you have a home, you are already homeless because you owe 200.000€ to the bank, your house is not yours, and, if you don't pay your mortgage you are out, you become homeless. Then, you wonder, 'how did I end up like this? How did I screwed life that I ended up like this?' Then, you feel like shit. You feel like shit because you think you are just a turd, because you are not even able to have a home. I am not speaking about being successful, being rich and all that. This is about having access to the most basic stuff anyone can imagine. (Beneficiary member, 4 June 2018, Murcia—phone interview)

Additionally, this changes the interactions with bank clerks, reinforcing such impressions. When people have a payroll direct deposit and a mortgage in a bank, the relation with the bank clerks in their bank office is cordial and amicable. You are a good client, somebody who brings profit to the office and who is expected to be on a profitable relationship with the bank for a long time, as some mortgages were signed for 30 years and more. This relationship even goes beyond formal terms. You may know the bank clerk personally and have shared stories about each other's lives. You are more than a client to them and perceive the relationship as a partnership of sorts. The calls from the marketing department of the bank would praise your financial responsibility and then try to sell you credit cards, televisions, and financing for your holidays. Moreover, everything is incredibly easy to contract. There is almost no paperwork and employees are available and can be easily contacted.

Once you start facing financial problems, everything changes. The partnership that was established in the past disappears. Your troubles are now your sole responsibility and you should solve them by yourself. You are asked to keep paying your monthly installments, regardless of how you do it. After defaulting, people turn into a liability and their homes become a *toxic asset* for the bank. The director of the bank office becomes suddenly unavailable. In place of the marketing department, the credit defaults division starts to call. They don't speak about easy credit or holidays. Instead,

they threaten to evict you and wonder whether the social services would allow you to keep your children, when you cannot guarantee a stable home for them. As Ada Colau, one of PAH's founders, explains in the documentary *La Plataforma*:

> Affected people arrive to PAH totally perplexed. 'Before, the director approached me as if I was family, when I signed the mortgage everything could be done with ease—if you cannot pay, don't worry, we will find a solution, etc.—Suddenly, that kind of treatment changes radically. When the crisis starts, and you cannot pay any more, you go to your bank, where they used to treat you so well and, suddenly, there are even cases of abuse and threats. (Herranz, 2012)

This change in behavior has a significant impact on people's self-esteem. In addition to the stigma generally associated with poverty, people trapped in their mortgages were perceived as prodigal, which is a disgraceful quality to be associated with in a context in which neoliberal jargon and austerity were commonsensical. As one of PAH's leaders summarized during an interview, 'poverty is stigmatized, and evictions are the moment of maximum visualization' (Non-beneficiary member, 16 June 2017, Barcelona).

Low self-esteem complicates their participation in social movements (Gecas, 2000). Those with little self-worth tend to prefer to avoid attention and social interaction (Davitz, 1969; Scheff, 1990). This is particularly problematic for engaging in public displays of non-conforming behavior, as not following the established rules and routines gathers more attention than following social habits.

> I think that many people don't come to PAH because they don't love themselves enough. To do well, you have to feel good about yourself. There was a period when I didn't love myself. It is sad, but I didn't. This is why I would prefer to pay to the bank rather than eating well. So, if I was not even able to care about eating well, how would I be able to make a fuzz at my bank just because they did not want to negotiate with me? (Beneficiary member, 25 August 2017, Barcelona)

Taught to Be Helpless

Reflecting about the common situation of people trapped in their mortgages provides a picture of why many did not consider themselves efficacious. Individuals live in a condition of alienation when they experience

that they cannot control their own lives (Rotter, 1966). Hence, when people have the impression that they cannot influence their present or future, they are discouraged from acting to change it, let alone participate in collective endeavors that affect other people than themselves. Once people start experiencing financial distress and problems to meet their mortgage payments, their most basic needs start depending on external agents. Many people reach out to personal networks, social services and charities for food or clothing, losing control over some of the most basic aspects of life. Moreover, the interactions they have with those providing these services are oftentimes patronizing, reinforcing their socialization as passive subjects whose agency is reduced to asking for help from others and following instructions.

> When I went to social services, I told them that I had to choose between paying to the bank and eating, that there was no other option. And they told you 'No, you have to pay. Pay and we will help you with the food'. (Beneficiary member, 21 July 2017, Barcelona)

This feeling of incapacity is reinforced through their constant interactions with bank clerks trying to find a way to solve the problem with their mortgage. After defaulting, people trapped in their mortgages have the impression that the bank takes over their life. Bank clerks can decide whether they start the foreclosure procedure or wait a bit longer to see whether debtors can start paying again. Moreover, the messages that many people trapped in their mortgage receive from the bank make them feel insignificant and as if there is nothing they can do to confront their problem.

> [The bank director] used to tell me 'we don't care if you set yourself alight in the middle of Catalunya square [one of the main squares in Barcelona], you are never going to obtain the deed in lieu of foreclosure'. (Beneficiary member, 27 July 2017, Barcelona)

Under these circumstances, it should not come as a surprise that this impotence takes people trapped in their mortgages to the extreme, sometimes pushing them to commit suicide. Activists for the right to housing have identified in that the news have reported at least 41 people who killed themselves either right before or during their eviction, between 2010 and 2018 (15Mpedia, 2018).

Experiences of failure, as well as the threats and harassment that people trapped in their mortgages suffer, impose on them the feeling that they cannot do anything to avoid their eviction. Even if social movement scholars have traditionally associated the feeling of threat with engagement in collective action (Almeida, 2003; Chang & Vitale, 2013; Owens et al., 2015; van Dyke & Soule, 2002), participation is often hampered by learned helplessness. According to learned helplessness theory, after someone endures aversive circumstances repeatedly and has the perception of being unable to control or escape them, this person will have more difficulties confronting similar situations in the future (Abramson et al., 1978; Seligman, 1975). Learned helplessness and perceptions of inefficacy act as mediators between emotions and participation in social movements. If, based on previous experiences, a person does not expect to be able to change their circumstances; it is more likely that they will refrain from engaging in any strategic confrontation to address their grievances.

Not Being Oneself

When someone is considered a defaulter, they are likely to struggle to match that label with other components that make for their identity. This situation creates the impression of inauthenticity. Once people trapped in their mortgages start facing financial distress and being at risk of eviction, the thought of being a defaulter starts occupying more and more space in their minds, as a large amount of interactions and experiences are suddenly connected to their default.

Identifying as a defaulter hampers people's capacity to confront their grievances. The identity refers to a situation from the past that is characterized by the lack of action—the inability to pay their debts. Despite not being at ease with that identification, debtors in good faith have little room to move away from it, as the only way to stop becoming a defaulter is paying their debts, something nearly impossible when lacking an income.

> There were times that it seemed that the bank clerk would not get it. 'Don't think that what I want is not to pay and get away with it. I want to pay my mortgages and that you and your people leave me in peace, but I can't. I can't pay you and I don't know what to do. This is why I come to speak with you'. (Beneficiary member, 19 April 2018, Manresa—phone interview)

Moreover, the identity of being a defaulter carries a considerable stigma with it, discouraging individuals from regarding themselves as authentic. This perception of inauthenticity alienates those trapped in their mortgages. Individuals need a certain coherence among the different ways that they perceive themselves, how they would like to perceive themselves and whether they act according to those ideals (Gecas, 1986). When a person perceives themselves or acts in a way that is not congruent to their different identifications, they are in a condition of alienation. Hence, the perception of themselves as defaulters complicates their capacity to confront their grievances. On the one hand, the only available solution that is congruent with that identity is clearing their debts, something that many people trapped in their mortgages try without success. On the other hand, the feeling of self-alienation makes for a motivational barrier to take action.

The Isolation of Eviction

The lack of identification with people in a similar situation is one of the reasons why those affected by mortgages internalized incumbents' framing of 'personal responsibilization' (Di Feliciantonio, 2017; Palomera, 2014), leading those facing mortgage problems to see themselves as the only ones who could help themselves.

> When I arrived to PAH, they would tell me to look at the one next to me and I would think 'listen, don't make me look at the one next to me because I really don't care. What I care about is myself and getting out of all of this' […]. I was very selfish. Why do you talk about the one next to me if I have enough problems myself and the one next to me does too? So, the one next to me is not going to come to my home and solve my troubles or give me food. (Beneficiary member, 23 August 2017, Barcelona)

Identification with a group fosters relationships of trust (Della Porta & Diani, 2006), and commitment to the collective goals (Gamson, 1995; Hunt & Benford, 2004). Furthermore, collective identities facilitate the creation of boundaries between challengers and incumbents (Della Porta & Diani, 2006; Flesher Fominaya, 2007; Gamson, 1995; Taylor & Whittier, 1992).

In other cases, the lack of networks and time prevented people facing financial distress from identifying with each other and think collectively. Many people trapped in their mortgages do not want to admit that they

will have to face an eviction, so they try to find hope for what differentiates them from others losing their homes.

> I would see the news [about evictions] on TV and, it is curious because even though the bank had already started a foreclosure procedure against me; I saw it as something foreign. It was as if my mind was rejecting that I was there, too. I don't know; I was seriously depressed and everyone saw it except of me. I would never admit that I was depressed. Just like I would never admit that I would be evicted, everyone who knows you knows it, but it is as if your mind does not want to take that step. (Beneficiary member, 20 June 2018, Bilbao—phone interview)

Some authors have argued that shared interests are sometimes not enough for the development of collective identities and that it is collective conflicts what provides the basis for group identification (Melucci, 1995, 1996). Hence, it may also be the case that sharing similar conditions and adversaries was simply not enough for people trapped in their mortgages to identify with each other.

Identity Care in PAH

To confront the aforementioned issues, PAH and its members care for the self-concepts and collective identities of members. The frames developed by the organization, its dynamics during assemblies and public events, and the interactions among members contribute to increasing the sense of self-esteem, efficaciousness, and authenticity, as well as cohesive collective identities. These efforts foster solidarity among people trapped in their mortgages, who increase their commitment and contributions to the group.

PAH's organizational culture encourages its members to interact with each other in a way that contributes to improving each other's self-image. Moreover, public actions are also organized, taking into account how they will affect members' self-esteem. Research has also shown that people are more eager to engage in group activities and collectives that contribute to improving the perception that they have about themselves. For instance, stigmatized individuals and those who have experienced rejection by others are more likely to participate in social movements that rehabilitate their image, especially when it challenges societal structures (Kaplan & Liu, 2000; Klandermans & Oegema, 1987). Hence, events and dynamics that

improve members' self-esteem contribute to increasing participation in the activities of the organization more widely.

Identity Care During Public Actions

Many public actions organized by PAH contribute to increasing its members' self-concepts and, more importantly, this factor is considered when planning and evaluating them. Public actions are important for increasing members' self-regard precisely because they confront their initial reaction to seclude themselves in private environments because of their shame and fear. As discussed in the previous chapter, public actions generate high emotional energy among participants. This experience represents a contrast to the emotional expectations that newcomers have about their feelings while doing something in public related to their mortgage problem. Despite the initial embarrassment and distress newcomers may experience during their first public contributions, events are organized in a way that allows members to experience pride, joy, and hope often.

Public actions are organized with the objective that those joining them will have a good time. During bank protests and demonstrations, there is always music and members are encouraged to dance and sing. In the case of more delicate actions, such as eviction blockades, the celebration comes after the expulsion is prevented. Once the judicial entourage signs the postponement of the foreclosure, the group often performs what is called an *ImPAHrables.* The whole group gathers in a circle and sits in a squat. From there, they start singing *imparables* (unstoppable) in a low voice and, as they slowly stand up, they gradually sing louder and louder until a moment when everyone is jumping, screaming, and hugging each other. This type of celebrations contradict the expectations that arise from low self-esteem. In the long run, the positive emotions experienced in a public activity lead those with low self-esteem to question their negative self-images.

> There are people that tell me [regarding their participation in public actions] 'I'm not sure, I feel embarrassed'. Well, that's okay, if you feel embarrassed just say it. We all passed through that. I was also embarrassed but, in the end, these actions are so much fun. So, you will end up joining us. Once people realize that, in PAH, you have fun while you protest, everyone wants to join. (Beneficiary member, 21 July 2017, Barcelona)

Besides the internal dynamics of a public action, interactions with passers contribute to improving members' self-esteem. Given the festive mood that PAH's protests have, many people approach protesters asking about what they are doing. It is common that, after hearing about the reasons for the protest, strangers show support for the action and PAH's objectives. This was especially the case during the peak of the economic crisis and after the bank bailout, when the image of banks was particularly negative among the population.

> It is difficult to imagine that somebody would approach you to defend banks or to tell you 'hey, don't be too harsh on the banks'. Here in Terrassa, occupying a bank office that did not want to negotiate or plastering their window with stickers became fairly common. As you can imagine, occupying a bank office is a very shocking action for most people. But, with the music and the good mood, people were not scared and did not move to the other side of the street. Instead, they were curious about what was going on and they came to check. People have always been very nice to us. (Non-beneficiary member, 4 September 2017, Terrassa)

When PAH organizes a protest or an occupation in a bank office, activists try to engage bystanders. Beyond the objective of pressuring bank clerks by telling customers about the condemnable behavior of the branch, these actions generate positive reactions from strangers, enhancing members' self-esteem and authenticity.

> People generally support you, they pick your leaflets up, and they curse the bank: 'to hell with this bank? They are robbers! I am their client. I will talk to them'. We are always calling on cars to honk, to make a fuss. We even have a banner that says 'honk against bankers'. […] When you see that most people support you, you don't feel bad anymore. Indeed, you realize that it should be the bankers who should feel like shit for what they have done to all of us. (Beneficiary member, 26 May 2018, Pontevedra—phone interview)

PAH's official petition campaign of 2010 is a great example of the importance that the organization places on identity care when organizing its public activities. Despite the great success of the campaign, whose 1.5 million signatures made it the biggest official petition in the history of Spain to this date, conversations with PAH's leadership at the time show that they were not optimistic about their chances of changing the mortgage law. The Christian Democratic People's Party (PP) absolute majority

in the Spanish Parliament allowed them to veto the mere discussion of the proposal. Nevertheless, what PAH's leadership saw in the petition was the possibility of placing the issue of evictions on the political agenda and give members the opportunity to improve their self-concept.

> When you mobilize so many people, give all the information that we were generating, you create a story, you break with the established imaginary and you become hegemonic. That is what we achieved with the petition. […] We already knew that we would not achieve it [changing the law]. At least it would be really difficult, because the PP had an absolute majority, and we would not be able to defeat them just like that. Even if we did not manage that the petition was approved by the Parliament, we won because people went out there and told their stories, they saw that people supported them and that 90% of society supported PAH's demands.[1] (Founder, 22 June 2017, Barcelona)

Gathering signatures in the street was a great opportunity for members to engage with strangers, speak about their situation, and present their framing of the financial crisis. Moreover, this happened in a relatively safe space, as several members were together at the same signature collection event. Even if the act of gathering signatures from strangers initially placed activists in an uncomfortable situation, as it increased the likelihood of encounters with people that disagreed with them, they were together with other movement members whom they knew and with whom they shared care relationships in the past. Moreover, the negative public image of the financial sector during the crisis made it likely that those approached would empathize with people trapped in their mortgages and show their support. The context facilitated that people trapped in their mortgages confronted their initial reactions to remain in the private sphere of the organization.

Repeated positive interactions with strangers often improved members' self-confidence. In turn, these practices boosted participation in gathering signatures, as the improvement in members' self-esteem thanks to such positive experiences made them more confident about their cause and their involvement in it.

[1] This comment makes reference to a survey from the newspaper El País (2013) showing that the demands contained in the petition were supported by 87% of the Spanish population.

> At the beginning, you are ashamed to be on the street [gathering signatures]. I was ashamed. But it goes away very fast because you go with your *comPAHs*, you don't go alone. I went a lot with [a member], who is one of the oldest veterans, because we live in the same neighborhood. And I could see that she talked to anyone, and that people smiled and signed. So, I thought 'it is going to be the same with me'. And then, you see that everyone that you approach supports you and that the only thing you have to worry about is to get as many signatures as possible. (Beneficiary member, 27 July 2017, Barcelona)

Public actions contribute to increasing members' self-esteem because they contradict their expectations about what other people think about themselves. While people with low self-esteem are unsure about the respect they will receive from strangers and anticipate that they will be uncomfortable during those exchanges, the support and joy that PAH members experience contradict these expectations. Instead of being condemned and feeling ashamed, members experience support and enjoy their public behavior. Moreover, the repetition of these experiences results in the internalization of this novel positive self-image.

Complimenting Each Other

Many day-to-day interactions among members also contribute to enhancing their self-esteem. PAH's rituals of mutual support and organizational framing contribute to the development of a caring culture among members where their self-esteem is an important factor. This culture is full of small details that make members feel good and appreciated. For instance, when a member arrives at a space where there are other people, they are generally expected to greet individually every person they know either shaking hands, with a hug, or two kisses on the cheeks. This action may seem insignificant but, when there are several people, it becomes a rather ceremonious ritual. Another example is that it is very common that interactions start by calling each other *guapo/guapa* (beautiful). This address is not done in a flirty manner, and is used regardless of gender, sexual orientation and personal tastes of beauty. Whenever somebody is greeted either in person or online, the conversation is very likely to start with 'Hi beautiful!' or just 'Beautiful!'

It is easier to understand the importance of these interactions if one compares them to the ones that members were used to before joining the

organization. When they would go to their bank office, they were greeted with serious and judging faces. The adjectives used to refer to them were related to their irresponsibility and the little efforts they were making to repay their debt. The little details of kindness present in the interactions that members have with other activists represent a drastic qualitative change. Moreover, this proactive and positive attitude facilitates the integration of newcomers who, after possibly feeling some unease regarding the overly affectionate welcome, become used to it and start using it quickly.

Tiny-Great Victories

As I have previously elaborated on in Chapter "The Origins of PAH: Empathy and Solidarity Mobilization ", PAH increases members' perceptions of self-efficacy, and confronts the learned helplessness developed during the experiences before joining the organization, offering its members opportunities to achieve objectives at different levels of complexity. As Jasper puts it, 'although deep-rooted factors like personality and culture affect a player's confidence, the strongest influence is experience. Winning builds confidence, and losing reduces it' (Jasper, 2006, p. 108). Hence, being encouraged to work on easily achievable tasks, newcomers to PAH start breaking the previous dynamics of learned helplessness and begin to build confidence through achieving objectives. In addition to increasing their perceptions of self-efficacy through achieving tasks that increase in complexity and importance, members internalize their more efficacious identities reporting to the rest of the collective and PAH's discourse of *tiny-great victories.*

Once PAH members make progress regarding their cases, they are asked to report to the assembly. Reporting serves to keep the rest of the organization up to date about the advancements of their members and allows the affected person to request further advice and even an accompaniment if things are stuck. Besides, when PAH's members report about their advancements and struggles, they also increase their perceptions of self-efficacy.

Newcomers go through many new experiences, and rapid changes and internalizing them takes some time. Narrating their stories contributes to accelerating this endeavor. As Wuthnow (1994, p. 312) explains, 'raw experience is often difficult to remember; it needs to be organized in our own minds for us to know what it means. Having to tell a story in a group

forces people to organize their experience'. Moreover, reporting is performative. Even if members may have not progressed much, the act of speaking about goals and planning to achieve them contributes to increasing their self-efficacy. The format of reporting emphasizes members' agency and efficacy, as it is focused on the achievements of the person and their doubts about how to progress further. The attention placed on members' agency generates changes in their self-evaluations, facilitating the internalization of efficacious self-concepts.

When activists report to the rest of the assembly, they also influence their peers. Those who listen to efficacious stories anticipate that they will be efficacious as well. Individual expectations of self-efficacy depend on the perceptions of the efficacy of the group (Bandura, 1986). Furthermore, the fact that someone has achieved something means that there is always the possibility of achieving a similar solution in the future. If a member has managed to postpone the date of their eviction or sign a deed in lieu of foreclosure over their property, it means that this possibility exists for everybody. This discourse also contributes to the understanding of every individual struggle as a collective struggle, as every achievement means a step in the same direction for all others.

> [Assemblies made me feel great because of] the spirit of people, saying 'Yes, it is possible!' The spirit that if you say that it is possible, it means that it is actually possible. So, I was telling myself 'yes, yes… [It is possible]' because I wanted to be able to do it. And people would come and say 'I have signed! [the deed in lieu of foreclosure], I have signed today, and I have agreed on this and that'. And I would tell myself 'If they have managed to sign [the deed in lieu of foreclosure], why shouldn't I manage to do it as well?' (Beneficiary member, 4 July 2017, Barcelona)

By being constantly exposed to efficacious stories, the expectations regarding their own and the organization's efficacy rise.

The performative impact of reporting is enhanced by PAH's discourse of *tiny-great victories*. No achievement is small if it represents an important step for somebody. The celebration of each step of members' progress turns individual achievements into collective victories. Every time that anyone shares any progress during the Welcome Assembly, the whole group starts screaming *¡Sí, se puede!* (Yes, it's possible!). This reaction functions as a social confirmation about the efficacy of members' progress, which is now recognized and celebrated in public.

This culture of celebration is encouraged by organizational dynamics. All assemblies start with a moment called *¿Cómo estamos?* (How are we feeling?), where members are especially encouraged to share any progress with their cases or anything that makes them feel good. Again, after each intervention sharing a success, shouts of *¡Sí, se puede!* fill the room. Moreover, despite everybody having to request their turn in speaking and wait until the facilitator gives them the floor, many local PAHs allow this rule to be broken if somebody has something good to share. If somebody arrives late to the assembly, this person is allowed to interrupt it to share the story of their victory.

> In PAH-Sabadell, we have the rule that if somebody has achieved something and wants to share it with the rest of the assembly, they can do it at any moment. It doesn't matter if you were late for the assembly or whatever, if you have a victory to share, you wait until the person who is speaking finishes and then you can talk without requesting your turn. (Non-beneficiary member, 12 August 2017, Barcelona)

At this moment, the assembly is stopped for a short celebration clapping and shouting *¡Sí, se puede!*

Another component of the tiny-great victories logic is the appreciation of members' contributions to organizational activities. Even if the initial contributions of PAH members may seem insignificant and non-political to some newcomers, their input is appreciated by the collective as much as any other. Collective appreciation encourages activists to see the impact of their actions and feel more efficacious.

The appreciation of contributions is particularly emphasized during assemblies. During any discussion, members are encouraged to acknowledge if their argument builds on a previous contribution. Furthermore, if anyone wanted to make an argument that somebody just defended, this person should rather state her support, instead of reiterating the same message again. This logic contributes to discussions in two ways. First, it gives conversations a better structure, following coherent lines of argumentation instead of personal interventions. Second, less outgoing people and newcomers are encouraged to speak because they see that their contributions are welcome. In a similar way, disagreements can take place, but the organizational culture places high importance on keeping discussions civil and constructive. Avoiding disrespectful disagreements, particularly when more experienced members do not agree with a newcomer, avoids

hurting the self-esteem of members or a feeling of having said something wrong or silly. Hence, identity care is not only about promoting certain self-images, but also about preventing the build-up of detrimental ones.

The logic of tiny-great victories is also present during public actions. When members join a public protest, their contribution is generally tiny—being present at the event—but their victory is great in two ways. First, they contribute to a grand accomplishment, such as protecting a family's home or forcing bank clerks to return to the negotiating table. Second, in line with PAH's discourse, the fact that incumbents have been defeated at that specific action means that other PAH members may have the possibility of winning their strategic confrontations in the future, too.

> Beyond preventing an eviction, a STOP Evictions is personal empowerment. Whenever one experiences a victory, it always represents personal empowerment. I remember the first time I went to an eviction blockade, which was even in my neighborhood. We were around 100 people. So, when I arrived, I was told that the judicial entourage had called the police and that they would go all out. When the riot police van arrived, it just passed without even stopping because we were a lot of people… it was amazing. They were like, 'this is going to be impossible, let's pass'. And then everybody started shouting. So, having the experience that thanks to you… well, yes, thanks to everyone, but also thanks to you, a family did not end up on the street. And tomorrow it may be you, and you will need those people, but you have just experienced yourself that it is possible to stop an eviction. And then, this becomes something normal, because blocking an eviction eventually becomes normal for you. That is absolute empowerment. (Beneficiary member, 26 July 2017, Barcelona)

The personalization of collective victories is easier when the affected person has their mortgage on the same bank as some other member. After having internalized learned helplessness through interactions with those very same incumbents, members feel like they can win not only in abstract terms but in a very practical sense. Having contributed to achieving somebody else's objective against the same person and institution that one faces oneself, encourages members to believe that they will also be able to do so.

> One day, we organized a protest at my bank office and, when the director saw my face, he could not recognize me because I was euphoric. I was happy. Every time I used to go to the bank, I would always enter crying, but

> that day I was so happy. I knew the action was not because of my case, but I still thought 'fuck you!' (Beneficiary member, 4 July 2017, Barcelona)

Through repetitive victories against bank representatives, judicial entourages, and police forces, PAH members build a routine of winning that encourages them to see themselves and the collective as efficacious actors who can win their fight, no matter how big or powerful financial corporations may be.

From a Stigmatized Group to Society's Spare Head

In contrast to being labeled as unemployed defaulters, PAH's members refer to themselves as those *affected by mortgages*. This self-provided label makes for a better and more comprehensive explanation of the past and present lives and identities of PAH members. It clarifies that they ended up facing mortgage problems because of systemic issues, and places emphasis on how they are affected by their grievances, instead of their responsibility for not meeting their mortgage payments.

Through this change, PAH encourages newcomers to see their mortgage problems in the context of something bigger than themselves, which they could not influence. Indeed, one of PAH's main mottos is *No es una crisis, es una estafa* (it is not a crisis, it is a fraud). The word *affected* in PAH's name is a message along those lines. Those trapped in their mortgages are not the perpetrators leading to their own default. Instead, they are people affected by an unfair housing model that, together with the banks' predatory lending practices, pushed them into debt.

Additionally, the identity of *affected by mortgages* gives members the possibility to engage in a wider range of activities other than just those open to a defaulter. The only action one can do to stop being a defaulter is to start paying again. Hence, the identity of defaulter is immobilizing to most people, as it relies on returning to the labor market during one of the worst economic crises of Spanish history. However, the identity of *affected by mortgages* provides members with more possibilities for action, as when something affects you, there are no implicit limitations to how you can react. These reflections about identity and agency were clear in one of the first debates that PAH had related to its name. At the very beginning, the group decided to call themselves 'Platform of Those *Hanged* by Mortgages', a name that they soon decided to change to their current

one, 'Platform of Those *Affected* by Mortgages'. One of the reasons was that the word *affected* implied greater agency than *hanged*.

> At the beginning, we called ourselves the Platform of Those Hanged by Mortgages […] we changed names because if you are *hanged*, you are hanging in the air, there is not much you can do. If you are lucky, you can hope for somebody to take you down. If you are *affected* by mortgages, if there is something that bothers you, you can react and do something about it. (Founder, 23 August 2017, Barcelona)

Identifying as a person affected by mortgages instead of a debtor or defaulter facilitates connecting with the wider public. Paying a mortgage is something that many people beyond PAH's circles do every month. Most individuals paying a mortgage have passed through months when they have had to give up on something. Even those who were doing fine economically, they probably had to avoid going away for holidays to save for the down payment of the mortgage, wait a bit longer to replace their car, or go out less, for instance. Moreover, PAH's framing of the bailout of Spanish banks, arguing that they illegitimately kept the ownership of their housing stock even after receiving substantial amounts of money from the taxpayers' pockets, presents every Spanish citizen as affected by mortgages. The identity of affected by mortgages challenges the stigma that many members feel, as they can now understand their situation as part of something that affects society as a whole.

> My bank is not going to get even a cent more from me because I am not in debt to them. So, in addition to losing my home and all the troubles I have gone through, am I still indebted to them? No, no, I already paid them with all my suffering. […] I am affected by the problem of mortgages. You are too, and we all are, because it was banks who created this mess. And then, they were bailed out… also with your money, even if they have much more money than you do. And nobody bails us out. If you ever have a problem, nobody is going to bail you out. (Beneficiary member, 4 July 2017, Barcelona)

PAH's members do not identify as a group on the fringes of society anymore. Instead, they speak up about an issue that is of concern to all Spanish citizens.

The final step in this process is reached when the identification as somebody affected by mortgages turns into identifying as an activist for the

right to housing. At this stage, the identification of individuals moves from being based on something external that led them to action—affected by mortgages—to a quality that originates from their self and has certain values and proactive behaviors attached. Acquiring 'activist identities' (Fantasia, 1988; Kelly & Breinlinger, 1996) is a defining moment because it is the internalization that their objectives are collective and political, and not strictly driven by self-interest.

> Before I was somebody affected by mortgages because my main objective was solving my case, but now I am an activist for the right to housing. I still want to solve my case, but I also want to change the law. There are many people that never get to know PAH or make it to join the organization, and those people also have a right to housing. This is why I want to change the law, because we all have a right to housing. (Beneficiary member, 13 April 2018, Valencia—phone interview)

The transformation that many members of PAH experience leads them to make their political involvement a salient feature of their identities. Beyond increasing the internal solidarity among PAH members, activist identities encourage members to identify beyond PAH's circles and seek to redress the grievances of the wider collective of people facing evictions and housing precariousness.

Empowerment as an Identity

The idea of the empowered person is one of the most relevant for shaping the identities of PAH members. Being empowered is understood both as a characteristic that individuals have and an objective to thrive towards. As Bacquè and Biewener explain, empowerment possesses two components: 'the power, which constitutes the root of the word, and the learning process to access it. It can refer both to a state as well as to a process' (Bacquè & Biewener, 2015, p. 6 author's translation). Emphasis on empowerment helps PAH members coping with the long struggle that is solving mortgage problems. Becoming empowered becomes an instrumental goal that must be achieved prior to solving one's housing issues. As individuals become more empowered, they gain skills necessary to find a solution to their own mortgage problem.

The characteristics that each member attaches to the identification of being empowered seem to be related to the care needs they lacked the

most. For some members, empowerment has an emotional component, it means becoming more outgoing and self-confident.

> I was a very happy person when I was at university or at school, when I was single… I was super funny. But then this all faded away. I think that PAH gave me my happiness back; it empowered me. (Beneficiary member, 31 July 2017, Barcelona)

For others, empowerment lies in being part of the collective. While, in the past, they had to face their problems alone, the solidarity they experience from other members gives them strength and the confidence that they can achieve more goals than by themselves.

> [Becoming empowered is] to be able to speak to bank clerks. For example, when you arrive at your bank, you are terrified because you don't want to confront your bank clerk, because he has insulted you, he has mistreated you, and so on. But if you have an accompaniment, and you have somebody sitting next to you, somebody who will support you if you don't want to sign something. Then you feel empowered and you are more confident about yourself. Then, you tell the bank clerk they have to sign the deed in-lieu-of foreclosure, because it is your right and that if they don't want to sign it now, they will sign it the next time, or the next one. (Beneficiary member, 18 May 2018, Seville—phone interview)

Finally, for others, empowerment is related to learning the necessary skills to solve their struggle.

> You become empowered when you learn the mortgage law, when you learn to negotiate so you can solve your problem. (Beneficiary member, 21 July 2017, Barcelona)

Individuals immobilized by their grievance struggle to approach a collective and to participate in any organizational activities as long as their care needs are not met. As already discussed, the needs of each individual are different. While all PAH members experience emotional, identity, and participatory care, they may experience one type in a stronger way than the others, seeing a stronger link between that type of care and their process of empowerment, to being able to take ownership of their struggle. Hence, as care relationships influence PAH members, they see themselves closer to their idea of empowerment.

Collective Identity Care

One of PAH's greatest achievements is to provide its members with an understanding community that supports them. Collective identity care is not the same as developing a collective identity. Collective identities generally refer to the identification of other members as being part of the same social group (Polletta & Jasper, 2001). Collective identity care refers to the experience of feeling welcome and understood by a community, which may result in a greater identification with the group.

> The best feeling for me was that when I spoke, everybody understood. I didn't need to give any explanation for people to understand. You say 'I have been evicted' and you don't need to explain more. Everybody understood because everybody knew that the bank has harassed you over the phone, they knew how you have felt. They comfort you and you know that they do it because they know how you feel, because they passed through that, too. For me, that feeling was like, wow, I am in the right place. (Beneficiary member, 31 May 2018, Valencia—phone interview)

The experience of newcomers when they first arrive at PAH's Welcome Assembly and the dynamics they observe among other members make them feel welcome in the group. Newcomers are welcomed by the group in several ways when they present their case at the assembly for the first time. The most obvious one is the name of the assembly where they introduce themselves, which is the 'welcome assembly'. Moreover, when someone arrives for the first time, they are invited to a room where they will be registered in the organization. They are asked to fill a form together with an experienced member, which will serve to record the progress of the person. This episode represents the moment when they formally join, and shows newcomers that PAH is ready to integrate them into the collective. After registration, newcomers introduce themselves and their case into the assembly. In the event that they break down while speaking, members usually comfort them by hugging or using a supportive word. Additionally, the moderator will help them continue with their story by asking questions which they can answer. When the introduction finishes, the moderator often tells newcomers not to worry because 'they are now in PAH and they are no longer alone'. The unconditional support shown by experienced members, who are strangers to newcomers, facilitates their identification with the group and leads to a feeling of being welcomed by the community.

Moreover, being in a space where other people have gone through similar experiences as their own empowers individuals. Listening to similar stories helps newcomers to feel less immobilized by their grievances. When they see that others have gone through similar circumstances, they start to think that they may be able to confront their trouble, too.

> For me, the most important thing about the Welcome Assembly was that I thought that my problem was the worst one, but it was not the case. The Welcome Assembly shows you something that is true for everything in life. You are not the worst, neither the best. When everyone spoke, I saw that there were people that were better off, but there were also others that were worse off. And to me, it was very helpful because, as they say, 'in the land of the blind, the one-eyed man is king'. So, it gave me strength to fight for my case. (Beneficiary member, 12 April 2018, Madrid—phone interview)

The feeling of acceptance by the community is important also after joining PAH. As already discussed, many people trapped in their mortgages went through long periods of isolation. The friendships and networks of support created in PAH encourage them to continue their involvement. These relationships often go beyond organizational activities and become part of all other aspects of a members' lives.

> The bonds that are created are really important. Many people that are part of the assembly do not have a big social network, they don't have friends. It happens to a lot of people. […] In PAH, people start having friendships again, they meet, they have a coffee together; they call each other. These social networks are one of the main pillars of PAH because it is not that people are colleagues, we are friends. (Beneficiary member, 12 July 2017, Barcelona)

The intense experiences that members go through together create these bonds. The empowerment of blocking an eviction, the tensions with the police and the sadness of seeing somebody lose her home are experiences and feelings to which people can rarely relate if they have not gone through them themselves. However, it is precisely this type of experiences what become a daily phenomenon for many members of PAH. Hence, an important part of members' lives has only meaning when they are together.

> Living through an eviction or resisting it, being cleared from a bank… these are things that are difficult to explain to even your closest friends, with

> whom you share a lot. As they are not part of this, they don't get it. When you tell them about this, they make the same face as if I would talk about Star Trek with someone who is not a nerd. So, you discover that you can only behave in certain ways or experience certain emotions through activism. (Non-beneficiary member, 1 September 2017, Barcelona)

One way in which the intense feeling of being part of a community is reflected is in how many members refer to PAH as their family. One example is the fact that the main Telegram group of PAH Barcelona is called *PAHmilia* and when members send a message there, they begin it with the words 'Hi, PAHmilia!' This type of wording is also commonly used among members who have particularly close relationships with each other and who refer to each other as brothers, sisters, mothers, daughters, and sons, depending on the age differences in the dyad.

The community spirit contributes to fostering solidarity among members. The dynamics of the Welcome Assembly encourage individuals to help each other. During these meetings, support is expected to come directly from other members who share similar mortgage problems. Advice does not come from experts or lawyers, but from peers with similar experiences. Giving advice to each other contributes to the internalization of the collective struggle and increasing the perceptions of collective efficacy. Those who give advice do it based on strategies that worked for them, personalizing their rhetoric. This gives members the best proof of efficaciousness, which means that PAH's approach has already worked for others. Moreover, as the person giving guidance presents herself as an expert on the topic, she is encouraged to follow up on the progress of the other members. Contemplating the dynamics of mutual support and solidarity also reinforces members' identification with the group and their expectations of being aided when they need help.

Public actions such as eviction blockades strengthen members' feeling of being welcome and of community. For newcomers to PAH, this is because their eviction is imminent, and the fact that the organization blocks their eviction without asking anything in advance shows them that they can trust the group and the commitment of the rest of members to their cause. Any eviction blockade shows the efficaciousness of the organization in achieving its members' goals. As individuals tend to identify with groups that are perceived efficacious (van Zomeren et al., 2004), newcomers soon relate to the character of the organization and its community, encouraging their participation in collective activities. It may be the case

that newcomers' initial contributions to other people's struggles may follow a self-interested logic and PAH's commonly repeated sentence *Hoy por ti y mañana por mí* (I will scratch your back if you scratch mine) reinforces this message. If members want to receive help from others, they have to engage in collective activities that help others. Indeed, newcomers soon realize that those who are more active in the organization have more people attending to the actions in their support, such as accompaniments and eviction blockades.

> [I became more involved] because I went to an eviction blockade and I saw that the eviction was blocked because we were 30 at the door, and I thought that I also wanted 30 people at my eviction blockade. So, I needed to make myself visible so other people would come to my eviction (Beneficiary member, 19 July 2017, Barcelona)

Collective identities develop when individuals share the same side of a conflict (Melucci, 1995). This is the case even for extreme situations, in which a person initially possesses a negative view of a group sharing the same opponent.

> I remember a guy, I will not say his name, who was a nice guy but kind of racist. He would make racist jokes about how migrants steal social funds and so on. But everything changed the day of his eviction, when he realized that most people confronting the police were migrants. And he has never made a racist joke again. Even more, you can totally see that his circle in PAH is much more mixed now. (Founder, 15 August 2017, Barcelona)

The identification with the organization that follows these dynamics contributes to the sustained participation of its members. Many activists persist in their engagement with PAH even after they have solved their cases. The following quote is from a member from PAH Barcelona who solved her housing problems three years before this interview took place, and who is one of the most active members of the organization, particularly in the Welcome Assembly and Communications Commissions.

> My idea was joining PAH, solving my case, and continue with my life. However, you soon realize that this is not the case, that if you don't help others, others won't help you. So, you realize that you have to think a bit about others too. Not only a bit, but a lot. I joined in July and in four or five

> months; I realized that people helped each other and that I could not be an exception. (Beneficiary member, 20 June 2017, Barcelona)

Even though this member joined PAH based on an individualistic rationale, she soon started to identify with other peers. Even if her contributions to the collective were originally motivated by a selfish logic, the fact that she has turned from a beneficiary to a non-beneficiary activist shows that she increasingly identified with the collective as a consequence of her activism. The bonds she created with other members, as well as her identification with PAH, turned her self-interested engagement into activism following a collective logic.

PAH's Green T-Shirts

PAH's green t-shirts are a particularly relevant tool of identity care for the organization. Symbolic resources, such as clothing, are commonly used by social movement organizations as signifiers of group identities (Helman & Rapoport, 1997). This piece of clothing has become a defining symbol of the group, both in the eyes of its members and for externals. Beyond members carrying them to any action organized by the group, leaders also wear them during any public intervention, including when they have spoken in parliaments and TV shows. Moreover, political representatives, journalists, and celebrities with different ideological backgrounds have used those t-shirts in different ways to express support or disapproval for the organization.

From the perspective of identity care, these t-shirts have two effects. On the one hand, they provide members with a symbolic resource that indicates their shared belonging and fosters their pride in being a member of the group. On the other, they are a symbol of organizational values and ideal self-concepts towards which members strive.

PAH's green t-shirts are part of members' lives since the beginning of their involvement. Newcomers are invited to buy one of these t-shirts on the first day they join the organization and wear it each time they go to negotiate with banks and social services, as well as when they join PAH's public actions. Throughout their involvement, many members adapt the t-shirts to their personal preferences, removing their sleeves, buying bigger ones and wearing them as if they were dresses, or cutting off parts of the shirt, making braids with the fabric. In this way, members can still

show their individuality while simultaneously expressing their commitment to the group.

Additionally, PAH's green t-shirts have a positive impact on members' self-concepts. Collective identities have specific values and ideal self-concepts associated with them (Gecas, 2000). Group members often act according to the roles and values associated with membership. Wearing PAH's t-shirts encourages this behavior. Their fashion has become a powerful tool for constructing a group image that fosters the self-esteem, self-efficacy, and authenticity of its members.

Self-Esteem

The green PAH t-shirts are often the cause of positive interactions with strangers—contributing to the self-esteem of members, which experience a feeling of societal appreciation. It is common that when many passers see a crowd of people wearing green t-shirts; they associate it with PAH and approach the group to show their support. Similarly, as mentioned in the introduction of this chapter based on my own experience during fieldwork, when individual members walk around the street with PAH's symbols, they are often complimented by strangers or approached with questions. More importantly, wearing PAH's t-shirts improves the way bank clerks speak to members. While before it was common that those trapped in their mortgage would receive threats in case they did not pay, wearing PAH's t-shirts as a way of signifying their membership to the organization discourages bank clerks to continue to disrespect them.

> When you show up with PAH's t-shirt, the behavior of bank clerks changes. The way they treat you is very different. Suddenly, you become 'sir' or 'madam' again. They treat you with more respect. (Beneficiary member, 11 September 2017, Madrid)

Several people I spoke with made similar comments with pride. Nevertheless, the examples they gave do not show any particular deference that any other client would not experience. However, this is a significant improvement for someone who has been harassed by those same bank clerks in the past.

Self-Efficacy

PAH's t-shirts also encourage members to feel more efficacious. When newcomers are advised to buy a t-shirt and wear it the next time they go

to their bank, people often make allusions to how the t-shirt is going to help them. During assemblies, it is common to hear references to the t-shirt as being an 'armor' or a 'shield'. People also share concrete examples of how the t-shirt is going to make them more efficacious, such as 'you will be treated differently', 'things will get done faster', 'they will not try to trick you anymore because they know that you are with PAH now'. These examples given during assemblies are generally based on past experiences and encourage new members to anticipate that they will be more efficacious. As seen by the quote below, there are good reasons to anticipate greater efficacy in members' relations with bank clerks:

> When I went to request the deed in-lieu-of foreclosure at my bank, I had to go three times because the first two the director did not want to see me. The third time, when they told me that the director was not available, I put off my sweater to show my t-shirt, took my telephone and called my son pretending he was a *comPAH* and said, 'Okay, call Ana Rosa [a famous morning TV conductor whose program carries her name], because they don't want to see me'. And, as if by magic, the director became available. (Beneficiary member, 6 June 2018, Barcelona—phone interview)

This story also shows that the increased self-efficacy contributes to a process of innovation. As PAH members feel more confident wearing PAH's t-shirts, they are encouraged to try new things, creating unexpected situations for bank clerks.

Moreover, PAH's t-shirts connect rank-and-file members with the impact that PAH's leadership achieves. The green t-shirts appear every time PAH is showcased on the news and when movement leaders have meetings with relevant political figures. Their shared piece of clothing encourages members to have the impression of having a real impact in the world, beyond their individual cases. This is clear by the pride with which many activists explain that some of their leaders spoke on TV and evidenced by the long discussions in the Telegram groups each time a member's story is showcased in the media.

Authenticity

PAH's t-shirt encourages members to experience themselves as authentic. The constant positive interactions that these t-shirts promote inspire members to realize that they are seen differently than common people, even when engaging in normal routines.

> I was coming from an eviction blockade and stopped at an ATM to get some cash. When the security guy of the bank office saw me, he closed the office. I didn't understand what was going on until I realized I was still wearing PAH's t-shirt. I tried to explain them that I just wanted some cash, but they would not open, so I had to go to another bank office. Can you believe they closed the bank office just because of me? [Laughs] (Beneficiary member, 26 July 2017, Barcelona)

This perception of being feared by banks has a particularly relevant meaning. One of the most famous slogans from the 15-M/Indignados movement was *Que el miedo cambie de bando* (let us make fear switch sides). This was chanted as a reference to the distress experienced by people at risk of eviction, workers fearing becoming unemployed and many other precarious collectives, and the perceived indifference from dominant groups and political representatives. This sentence sent the message that collective organization in the squares or through PAH would change the balance of power—and the emotional habitus of each group—in favor of the powerless. Not so long ago, those scared during similar interactions were the activists themselves, but now they see that banks have reasons to fear them.

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Facilitating Commitment Through Participatory Care

We often talk about contentious collective action as a political resource for the less-privileged. Aggrieved individuals who do not have access to institutional, economic, and cultural centers of power, the argument goes, organize politically in social movements to confront their oppression. However, many disadvantaged people and communities do not have the possibility of accessing the types of politics that have traditionally been thought to be particularly handy for them. Somebody who is not fit to stand a long walk cannot join a demonstration; those who are weak cannot join a human chain seeking to prevent police forces from entering a building to block an eviction; someone taking care of a dependent will be discouraged to engage in actions that may result in spending a night at a police station or at hospital after police charges; and elderly people who are not comfortable using a smartphone will rarely be able to join a social media campaign. This is the conclusion that many of my interview partners arrived at well before they talked to me: contentious politics are inaccessible for many of those who need them the most.

> I remember that, during the 15-M [Indignados movement], there were many people saying that *batucadas*[1] were things for hippies, that they were

[1] Batucada is a musical style where an ensemble of percussionists plays music and dance. This type of performance has become common during progressive marches and protests in

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F. G. Santos, *Social Movements that Care*,
https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-031-74296-5_7

> bullshit and that we should get serious and start burning dumpsters, so people would know that shit is real. However, that type of activism can only be performed by a couple of youngsters who study at university. It may be their way of protesting, but it is not accessible to everyone. […] If you want to include mothers and grandparents you cannot do that, because it doesn't go with them, or that may scare them […] If you want to transform society somehow, you need to generate dynamics that are open for everybody. Otherwise, you will stay in your ghetto of 'I can do this stuff because I have certain privileges'. (Non-beneficiary member, 12 July 2017, Barcelona)

The conversation that follows from these reflections is about care. How to address the participatory needs of those who require being able to participate in politics the most?

Care as Tools to Defend Your Rights

Most who arrive to PAH have several participatory needs that the organization addresses. Many lack the tools to be able to take ownership of their struggle; they do not have sufficient knowledge about their rights and how to engage in contentious collective action. Others simply lack the necessary resources to confront their grievance, as they do not have the time and/or the money needed to join social movement activities. For others, risks are too high. Many ways of activism entail dangers that many are not ready to face, or the hazards associated with their grievance are so important that they are unable to confront them. Participatory care consists of organizational efforts and relationships aimed at supporting members, so they can face the challenges of participation and those originating from their lives. PAH provides its members with knowledge and skills, mobilizes resources for their cause and reduces the risks associated with activism and their grievance.

Building Power Through Knowledge

Sometimes, one of the reasons for not participating in contentious collective activities is lack of awareness about the wider perspective of the injustice one is facing or lack of knowledge and skills to contribute to an organization. PAH encourages its members to build knowledge and skills

Spain and has the objective of making the march more enjoyable.

in three ways: provision of information, training, and coaching. Provision of information is the least formalized way of generating knowledge and consists of making information that was previously gathered available to members. Training consists of prearranged workshops, organized with the objective of building certain skills and disseminating specific information. Finally, coaching refers to non-formalized mentorship that takes place during PAH's activities, where a more experienced member guides another through the ways different actions are organized. In combination, these practices contribute to helping members take ownership of their individual struggle as well as contributing to the organizational activities, and training them to take on leadership positions in the long run.

Dissemination of Information

Most mortgage contracts are signed under conditions of information asymmetry. While most bank clerks are university graduates trained in economics and law, and all financial institutions invest considerable amounts of money in their legal departments, those who become indebted to buy a house come from very different backgrounds. The power that knowledge gives to banks is evidenced by several court rulings declaring illegal different clauses present in many mortgage contracts, such as interest rate floors (Consumidores: Condiciones Generales Abusivas; Claúsula Suelo en los Prèstamos Hipotecarios, 2013) and linking interest rates to non-transparent indexes (*Sentencia 19/2015*, 2015; Sentencia *85/16*, 2016). It is unlikely that debtors would have signed abusive terms had they known what they meant. When things do not go as expected and the debtor faces financial constraints, banks are in a position in which they can take advantage of this relative ignorance.

Overcoming the barrier of disinformation is key for newcomers to start participating in PAH's activities and for them to become ready to confront their banks in individual settings. People trapped in their mortgage's ignorance about their rights complicates non-conforming behavior in three ways. First, it blocks access to tools and information they can be used to better their position. Second, it prevents them from assimilating alternative frames of injustice, as bank clerks use these information asymmetries to impose feelings of shame and guilt on debtors, as already discussed in Chapter "From Immobilized to Empowered: Beneficiary Mobilization in PAH". Finally, unawareness of the timeframe that one is facing and what to expect from the future, creates instability and the impression of living

day-to-day, hampering one's capacity to collaborate with others and think strategically.

The first block of PAH's welcome assemblies is focused on the dissemination of information. After an introduction about the organization and its goals, an experienced member explains to the rest of the assembly the foreclosure procedure and the steps that PAH has identified, so all members can have a sense of where they are and what to expect. During this stage, they also speak about the rights of those who are involved in such procedures, such as the right to a legal recourse lawyer to help them with the court case and to be registered in the so-called emergency table–a prerequisite to apply for short and long-term social housing—and encourages the audience to make use of them. Together with this information, they also cover some other resources members can make use of, such as the commonly known as 'code of good practice' (Real Decreto-Ley de Medidas Urgentes de Protección de Deudores Hipotecarios Sin Recursos, 2012), which is an elective code of conduct for banks that was signed by the Spanish Christian-Democratic government during the worst years of the crisis and that was aimed at alleviating some of the suffering of those trapped in their mortgages. Despite the fact that this information is presented in an accessible language, newcomers do not grasp it for the first time. They are generally under considerable stress due to their financial situation and the new environment where they have entered. However, the repetition of this presentation every week helps members to internalize it.

> The first time I arrived at the welcome assembly, I was physically there, but I was not there. I was ashamed about being there and only wished that nobody would notice me. So, even if [an experienced member] explained everything perfectly, I left the assembly knowing as much as I did before I entered. Then, the week after, I heard some things that I thought would apply to my case and then, the third week, I brought a notebook and noted everything down. (Beneficiary member, 21 July 2017, Barcelona)

During assemblies, information is also shared in a peer-to-peer way. Welcome assemblies have time for members to share doubts, as well as to update each other on their progress and challenges. Answers to questions and suggestions about how to proceed come from any member that has had a similar experience. As most cases fall under a few types and assembly participants often cover all of them with their experiences, the information

shared is not only useful for the person who asked, but also for many other people present in the assembly. It is also common to listen to different suggestions presented and debates about which one is best. This process helps to improve organizational knowledge constantly through a process of collective reflection (Santos & Emperador Badimon, 2022).

All the information that has been gathered by PAH during its years of struggle is compiled in written. During the assemblies, members can acquire 'PAH's Green Book' in exchange for a donation. This booklet contains all the information discussed during welcome assemblies as well as all state-wide and regional laws that may apply or be of interest to their members translated to an accessible language. Again, the donation is symbolic and rather seeks to provide newcomers with the opportunity to make an initial contribution to the organization, as all these documents, and many others, are available in PAH's website.[2] Through these texts, members can have access to the information anytime and can still discuss their doubts during the assemblies.

Efforts to make all information easily accessible to members are present across PAH's activities. Even during assemblies, the moderator seeks to translate any intervention from a member that may seem difficult to grasp.

> Many times, when people speak with technical words, I try to find a way to repeat them with normal language. For example, when [an activist who is also a lawyer] spoke the other day and everything was super technical, I saw that many people in the assembly were lost, like 'I am not going to raise my hand and say I understood nothing because it will look bad, but I haven't understood shit'. So, I tried to put the blame on me and said 'Well, this is kind of complicated, let me see if I got it…' and started saying everything again. I understood it perfectly the first time, but I took the most important things and said them normally. (Beneficiary member, 4 July 2017, Barcelona)

These efforts to make information easily accessible are crucial for newcomers' involvement. Assimilating relevant information is not only crucial for members to advance in their struggle and be better able to confront bank clerks and pressure public administrations, this knowledge also helps them to contribute to the activities of the organization because they can be integrated into the strategic discussions and debates. They also become more receptive to the alternative frames developed by the movement, as

[2] They can be found at the following link: https://afectadosporlahipoteca.com/documentos-utiles/.

they are better able to understand the origins and perpetrators of their grievance as well as the possible solutions they can seek.

> I didn't even know what a deed in lieu of foreclosure, a debt forgiveness, and a moratorium were. These words seem now so easy, but it was like 'what are you saying?' But little by little you learn and then you are able to decide what you want to fight for. You decide if you want the deed in lieu of foreclosure or a partial debt forgiveness, so you pay whatever you can, and you keep your home. […] little by little you become empowered and start taking documents to your bank. You explain better to the assembly what is happening with you, so they help you better. (Beneficiary member, 30 August 2017, Barcelona)

In the case of PAH, knowledge is not only power, but it is also empowerment.

Using common language does not only care for members of the organization, helping them to engage in the discussions of the movement, it also cares for them because it makes it easier for the rest of society to empathize with them. Translating complex terms to common language also helped the organization to connect with public opinion.

> We say all our messages in plain language, in a language that my 70-year-old grandmother can speak. If you speak to my grandmother in plain language about what a petition and the deed in lieu of foreclosure are, she may not remember every detail, but she will leave with the understanding of who are the bad guys, that we are the good guys and that we can win this fight. (Non-beneficiary member, 16 June 2017, Barcelona)

When members reproduce the messages they receive in the assembly and from PAH's documentation, they can also feel that their circles and the wider population empathize with them because they can now understand them.

Training

PAH disseminates information in more structured ways through training programs. Building the capacity of the activist base is crucial for the intensity and length of mobilization (Han, 2014) and most SMOs organize workshops and other forms of educational activities with this objective. PAH organizes training programs aimed at building two types of skills: those useful for taking ownership of members' personal struggle and those

expected to contribute to the activities of the organization. Despite this distinction, the knowledge developed in any of the workshops translates into skills useful for both types of involvement.

Training aimed at helping members to take ownership of their struggles is mostly focused on improving the outcome of their negotiations with banks. These workshops are centered on accessible explanations of the content of relevant laws, as well as negotiation strategies applied to their specific cases. These exercises are aimed at providing the necessary knowledge to be able to understand the process and timing of a foreclosure procedure, the rights of mortgage defaulters, and the actions that banks can actually carry forward, as many make threats that they cannot legally implement. They also present different ways of approaching a negotiation and how to react to typical situations. Finally, many workshops have a practical part, where participants rehearse what they have learned. These training programs equip members both to be able to successfully carry their individual negotiations with banks and better contribute to the activities organized by PAH, such as accompaniments and welcome assemblies, where that knowledge can be used to support other peers.

Other training programs are focused on building skills that help members participate in certain types of activism, which require prior knowledge to take part in them. As PAH members come from very different backgrounds, training programs cover a wide variety of topics, and they are generally organized when the need arises. Some of the workshops are about skills related to low-risk activism, such as using Twitter and the internal email rules of the organization, like how to manage the common email account of the local group and communicate with other sections. Others are more advanced, such as how to organize a public action and mediate with the police. There have even been instances that some PAH groups have organized squatting workshops, where they provide the legal and practical skills to engage in this action. This variety of topics allows every member to learn new skills, regardless of previous experiences and preferences.

As PAH is actively proposing legislative changes in relation to housing policy, there are also training programs to teach its members about the details of their bill proposals. Moreover, as this information is new, and only the few people who are originally involved in drafting the proposals know it well, PAH has a system of training trainers in order to reach as many members as possible. For instance, during 2017–2018, PAH launched a campaign to push for a new housing law. This bill, if approved,

would make the deed in lieu of foreclosure compulsory in all mortgage contracts, ban evictions of people with no housing alternative and utility cuts to dwellings under risk of social exclusion, establish rent caps, and allocate more funds for the construction of social housing (Plataforma de Afectados por la Hipoteca, n.d.). As part of this campaign, PAH organized actions on the street to inform about the bill. Prior to these awareness raising activities, the organization needed as many members from as many local groups as possible to be able to explain the details of the proposal to people in the street. To achieve this objective, a workshop about the bill was organized during PAH's 2017 national assembly. In addition to learning about the details of the proposed legislation, those who attended the training were provided with materials to organize similar initiatives for their local groups. Those who attended the training were encouraged to organize training programs back home and received support from local and national leaders to ensure the workshops were successful. As part of this support, there was a coaching system whereby more experienced leaders would support those in charge or organizing those events. In this way, not only were tens of local training sessions organized across Spain, but many PAH members learned the skills to speak in public and organize workshops in the future.

Coaching

Differently from the dissemination of knowledge and training, which often take place in closed and private organizational spaces, coaching commonly happens during a public action. During the action, more experienced members use the opportunity to guide others into the details of leading an activity as they do it. In this way, they have the opportunity to put into practice the information and skills learned during training and see the challenges of taking on certain roles.

One of the most important details when planning an action consists of assigning roles for each task. For instance, during an eviction blockade, in addition to the group who is blocking the entrance of the building with their bodies, there needs to be somebody who negotiates with the judicial entourage, another who coordinates those who are standing at the entrance door of the building, someone in charge of documenting the action and sharing it on social media, and a couple of people who stay inside the apartment to give comfort to those living in the home to be foreclosed. The diversity of roles is similar for any other activity, such as protests in bank offices, accompaniments, and squattings. While everyone

is encouraged to take on any role, there are certain skills they need to master before they can do so. Hence, members need to invest time and effort to overcome that barrier.

While it is possible to learn about these skills through texts, presentations, and workshops, that knowledge is still difficult to implement under the conditions of stress and uncertainty of civil resistance. The behavior of the judicial entourage changes depending on the personality of the public worker, there may be more police than anticipated, the lawyer of the bank may try to break your nerves and those of your peers, somebody in your group may not behave as expected, and one may be unable to deal with all that tension. There are some things that can only be mastered by doing, and some skills become useful once one is used to putting them into practice. Hence, in addition to disseminating information and organizing training programs, PAH has developed a system of coaching based on their commonly repeated expression *uno hace y otro mira* (one does, and another looks).

Uno hace y otro mira is an important way in which PAH builds leadership among its rank-and-file activists. When the roles of an action are allocated, the task of looking is also assigned. For instance, in the case of an eviction blockade, the person in charge of negotiating the postponement of the eviction with the bank representative and the judicial entourage is generally accompanied by one or two people who will stand in silence. This restricted group occupies a privileged learning position, as they can contemplate the arguments, expressions, and reactions of a more experienced negotiator. This is also a moment when their adrenaline and nerves kick in. Looking also involves being face-to-face with the targets of their action and being part of one of the sides of the dialectic confrontation. During these negotiations, there are moments when the parties reconvene. During this time, the *doer* explains the *looker(s)* how they are approaching the negotiations, the reasons why they did or said certain things, how they read the reactions of the other sides and what outcome they expect, as well as the reasons why. Even if this practice is not formalized and does not always take place, it is culturally institutionalized.

During my fieldwork, I had the chance to be among the *lookers* numerous times. During an eviction blockade, *lookers* can volunteer if they want to learn, or leaders may encourage somebody to take that role.

> Soon after I joined, [a leader] told me—come to negotiate with me—, and I said—no, no, I don't know how to do this, and I am scared of doing

> it—.—Just come with me and listen, you don't need to speak—. And I started going with [the leader] and other people who were in charge of the negotiations until I learned to do it myself. (Beneficiary member, 30 July 2017, Barcelona)

The number of people that accompany the negotiator is still very limited, as PAH members arrived at the conclusion that negotiations go better when the other side is calmer and big crowds of negotiators, even if only one person speaks, have the opposite impact. When the judicial entourage arrives, the leader of the negotiating group makes a sign to those who will accompany them, and they approach the group to start talks. The exchange takes place in the street in a circle, under the supervision of the police.

If the eviction is successfully blocked, as it generally happened during my fieldwork, and there are no more eviction blockades planned for the day, all those who want to go together for a coffee. Even if this is a very casual gathering, it is common that, amid the cheerful environment of having blocked the eviction, the *doer* coaches the *lookers* and goes through some of the key moments of the negotiation. Often, this happens as part of the celebration, more like telling a story ('Did you see the reaction from the bank representative when I said this?', 'you really cracked it when you did that thing'). Other times, the conversation is more explanatory and formal. The leader goes through the negotiation, explaining what happened, how she reacted, and other possible scenarios that are common. Yet on other occasions, it is the *lookers* who informally lead the coaching with their questions. Leaders also emphasize that people do not always need to follow what they do, as the way of leading negotiations depends on their personality.

> I learned to negotiate mostly from [two leaders]. [One leader] is very calm and always tries to find alternatives. [The other leader] is very stubborn and if she wants something, she will get it the way she wants. Those are two very different ways of negotiating. One is very calm, the other quite aggressive. So, there are different styles. Mine is more like a hybrid. I am a bit of a Rottweiler if the other person behaves like an asshole, but I am generally quite calm. (Beneficiary member, 30 July 2017, Barcelona)

Coaching also happens during accompaniments, when a group of PAH members go together with another to support them in an interaction with a bank clerk or public authority. In this case, the group of *lookers* does not

need to be restricted, as the purpose of accompaniments is to gather several people to pressure, with their presence, during negotiations at banks or public offices. During accompaniments, the one who is expected to talk is the person affected by the case, but leaders generally intervene to redirect talks if they go the wrong way or because the stress and pressure that the affected person experiences freezes them. Except for these two people, the rest of the group remains silent. During accompaniments, members are not selected or do not volunteer to be coached, as it is the case of eviction blockades, but they offer their help to accompany in the negotiations. Regardless of this nuance, coaching happens in a similar way to eviction blockades.

Despite the apparent informality of coaching, it is of crucial importance for PAH leaders. Many of the interviews I did had references to *teaching each other* and *learning from each other*. Moreover, PAH leaders are conscious that time and errors are needed for learning, but that coaching is an integral part of care and empowerment. In one of the accompaniments I participated in during fieldwork, things went out of hand because one member started interrupting the person in charge of the negotiation and sharing information that was agreed should not be shared. Later, I had the chance to speak about that episode with the person who was leading the accompaniment that day and asked him about how they approach those situations.

> What you must do on the spot is saying nothing to the person because there is nothing worse than crushing a *comPAH* in front of a banker or a public employee. You may try to say that we should speak about that point later, in a gentle way, and try to make the other person understand that it is better if she does not speak. Then, when you are outside, you can reflect on the situation. 'Hey, listen, here you were spot on, but when you did this, maybe it would have been better if you did something else'. […] But you also have to understand that your strength comes precisely because that person, and the other eight, seven, five… are there with you. If they were not there, you would be by yourself. And the strength of PAH is that many people have made mistakes, and they have learnt from their mistakes, and little by little they have become more empowered. You need to be generous to understand that everyone is doing the best they can and the best they know, and that their aim is to contribute and help their *comPAH*. (Non-beneficiary member, 12 July 2017, Barcelona)

Coaching is an integral part of PAH's actions. Foreclosure procedures take a lot of time and PAH members may be able to delay them up until three years. The outcome of each case is not a one-off type of game, but a long struggle where what matters is slowly advancing towards the objective. Except for crucial episodes such as an eviction blockade or a negotiation to obtain social housing once a member has been evicted, even if an action fails to achieve its objective, PAH members know that there will be another opportunity in the future. Hence, PAH's priority is building collective power in the long run. This also means that PAH has enough time to build the skills of its members through coaching, even if sometimes this may delay some individual achievements in the short term.

Making Participation Easy

Participatory care also consists on facilitating engagement in organizational activities by lowering the efforts that members need to do to participate. Han (2014) refers to this process as 'transactional mobilizing': encouraging mobilization by making participation as easy as possible. Organizations facilitate participation by lowering the efforts, time, and money that members need to dedicate to take part in certain activities. The templates that PAH makes available to its members, for all the bureaucratic procedures they need to face during their struggle, are a good example. Instead of each member having to write a document requesting the deed in lieu of foreclosure at their bank office, asking the administration for a legal recourse lawyer, or the courts for a postponement of their eviction, they can fill the available templates with their information and submit them.[3] In addition to saving time and energy for members, templates assure that those that may not have the knowledge to write those requests appropriately can easily do so by filling the models with their information. Additionally, templates increase the probability of achieving the objective of each request, as most have been written by activists who have a training in law, and all have been updated with the experiences of members that have used them, assuring that pleas cannot be denied based on formal reasons.

Another way in which PAH facilitates participation is by reducing the costs that some members may have to pay to participate in some activities.

[3] A full list of templates developed by PAH can be found at https://afectadosporlahipoteca.com/documentos-utiles/.

It should be noted PAH's budget is very limited. Just to provide a measure of this, during the time of my fieldwork, there were assembly debates in PAH Barcelona about the need to raise funds because the only had money left to pay for a couple of months of rent for the basement where they have their office. Unlike many American SMOs, Spanish grassroots organizations do not focus much on raising funds. The reasons for this are out of the scope of this book, but they may have to do with differences in civil society cultures. While American organizations play an important role in institutional politics (Amenta, 2008; Halfmann, 2011; Pastor, 2019) and employ great efforts reaching out to donors (Jenkins & Eckert, 1986; Smith & Lipsky, 2009; S. A. Soule & King, 2008; Walker, 2014), Spanish progressive SMOs are greatly influenced by anarchist thought and tend to see this as a way of cooptation. PAH never supports any political party and they distance themselves from *big money*.

Despite the limited funding, PAH facilitates participation in its activities by coordinating the logistics necessary to join organizational events. For instance, PAH organized a demonstration in Madrid in support of its law proposal on 6 October 2018. To facilitate the participation of those members who did not live in Madrid, local chapters from everywhere in Spain coordinated the rental of buses, selling tickets to cover the price. Members still had to pay for their trip to Madrid, but the price was lower than a normal ticket, as the organization made no profit from them. Similarly, to facilitate that people joined the workshops to make banners and other signs for marches, a group of people is charged with buying the materials for everyone, so members just need to arrive at the assembly space and start designing.

On other occasions, PAH coordinates members' duties, such as childcare, so they can focus on the activity they are engaged in. The assembly space of PAH Barcelona has a room called the *ChikiPAH*, which is a space for kids to play. At the beginning of each assembly, one or two members are charged with taking care of the *ChikiPAH*, so parents can participate without having to pay attention to their sons and daughters.

> We tried to create a space where kids would be taken care for so mums and dads would be calmer. When you are with your children, you are always more nervous and paying attention to them. Also, for a kid, being at a two- or three-hours assembly is horrible. So, we created the ChikiPAH to share among everyone the caring duties of the group. (Founder, 22 June 2017, Barcelona)

Some PAH groups also coordinate after-school support on the premises of the organization. During these gatherings, some parents or younger university-educated members tutor children and help them with their homework.

Through these two initiatives, PAH coordinates members with similar commitments so they can share their duties outside of their activism and have more time to dedicate to the movement. The way that the ChikiPAH facilitates participation is self-evident, as it takes place at the same time and venue as the assemblies. For the case of tutoring, there may not be an organizational activity at the same time as the after-school support. Nevertheless, coordinating childcare in this way allows parents to dedicate time to other activities, having more free time to gather energies and be more relaxed, and seek to create better house dynamics.

Another component of participatory care is making high-risk actions more pleasurable and accessible to every organizational member. For instance, during the occupation of six empty apartments owned by the vulture fund *Norvento* at 477 Aragò St., Barcelona, the flats did not have access to utilities during the first days. During that time, the PAH members coordinated cooking meals for those that were rehoused so they could eat warm food until access to utilities was activated. As I discuss below, this approach to high-risk activism does not only facilitate it, through making it more pleasurable, but it also reduces members' perceptions of being under risk.

Making Participation Safe: Eliminating the Perils of Activism and Life

When we think about risks and social movements, we tend to narrow our attention to those associated with activism, how they affect participation in contentious politics and how organizations mitigate them to foster involvement (Goodwin & Pfaff, 2003; McAdam, 1986; Nepstad & Smith, 1999; Taylor & Raeburn, 1995). While reducing the risks associated with participation and the perception about them is an important component of participatory care, there is also another element that is relevant for social movements, which is addressing the hazards originating from grievances themselves. Care puts life at the center of politics. It includes all the activities that we do so that we can live as well as possible (Fisher & Tronto, 1990, p. 40; Tronto, 1993, p. 103, 2013, p. 19). Hence, participatory

care is also aimed at reducing the risks that organizational members face in their daily lives. In a way, PAH's raison d'être is eliminating hazards in people's lives. Particularly, its aim is to assure everyone's right to decent housing, by reducing the risk of losing their dwelling, which is an issue that vulnerable groups face. More generally, risking an eviction, suffering street harassment because of one's gender or race, or living under conditions of economic precariousness are risks that are not necessarily related to involvement in politics, but that surely hamper political participation. Hence, participatory care includes both the reduction of risks associated with activism and members' lives.

Risks Associated with Activism

Some of PAH's activities could be considered high-risk. Both eviction blockades and PAH's Obra Social, the squatting of empty dwellings owned by banks to rehouse evicted families, are actions of civil resistance that could face police repression and even prison sentences. Eviction blockades consist of impeding the implementation of a court ruling through civil resistance, which is sanctioned by the law. They may also carry members to confrontations with police. Squatting—especially if it can be proven that it was implemented with violence, even to property—can be categorized as usurpation, which is punished by up to two years in prison. Furthermore, most PAH members live in economic precariousness, so even a small fine can destabilize their finances. PAH reduces the risks associated with the activism of its members through activities taking place before, during, and after an action.

Planning to Be Safe

Before an action takes place, the way PAH members plan the event is key to minimize risks. Responsibilities are clearly allocated, and all people involved in the action know what their role is. Duties are clear for everyone participating in the action, and should something unforeseen happen, participants know to whom they should turn. For instance, during a protest in a bank office, there is somebody assigned to talk to bank employees, and emphasis is placed on the fact that the action is against the bank, and not its employees. This type of setting seeks to avoid unnecessary confrontations with people that is unlikely to have decision power over the outcome the action seeks to achieve. There are also people in charge of mediating with police and others to talk to the press. Moreover, as I

elaborate further below, there are people in charge of keeping the group moral up and happy, so everyone is more focused on having a good time while protesting, avoiding unfortunate reactions. Planning avoids the risk of police repression that comes when everybody acts without coordination. Moreover, PAH organizes training programs on non-violence and mediation with police, so even the rank-and-file activists have reflected on how they should react in risky situations.

A crucial component of planning to reduce risks is knowing the law and organizing risky actions in a way that they will be categorized as wrongdoings of lesser importance. PAH has certain rules on how to perform a flat occupation through their Obra Social campaign, and many of them are aimed at reducing risks. First, only a handful of people know that the activity will take place and information about the place and date is restricted only to those who will participate. This is done to protect those who will necessarily damage the property, in this case the door of the apartment, from being discovered in the moment of action. Moreover, those who will be rehoused in the dwelling never participate in the initial stage of squatting. As previously discussed, the Spanish legal code categorizes squatting as usurpation if it can be proven that the person living in the apartment has damaged the property. Avoiding that those who will live in the apartment could be related to any violence frees them from the risk of a prison sentence. Instead, those rehoused are advised to argue that they received a call from a private number telling them about the empty flat and that, when they arrived there, they found the place vacant and the keys inside the key holder of the entry door.

PAH uses its knowledge of Spanish legislation also to adapt its actions to the timings specified there. According to the Spanish legal code, if somebody has been living in a dwelling for more than 48 hours, it can be considered their domicile. Legislation defends the inviolability of the domicile unless there is an in flagrante delicto, a judicial order, or its inhabitants allow entrance to the property. Hence, after a family rehoused through Obra Social has stayed for two days on the property, police forces cannot evict them unless there is a court decision ordering it. To avoid the risk that police forces enter the dwelling without a court order, PAH announces the occupation only 48 hours after it has taken place. Moreover, in case the police decide that the 48 hours start to count down after the occupation has been announced, PAH organizes a schedule of groups to protect the dwelling in case police forces arrive unexpectedly. This group is not only there to mitigate the risk that the family is evicted, but they also

provide comfort to the people occupying the property, so they face their high-risk involvement in a supportive and as safe as possible environment. Furthermore, to avoid any misunderstanding, PAH provides its members with a document they need to stick to the door outside their apartment. This paper contains the definition in the legal code of an in flagrante delicto, which specifies that police agents need to have a direct perception that those residing in the property have committed the offense and that this conclusion cannot be based on deductions or information from third parties (Plataforma de Afectados por la Hipoteca, 2012). By sticking this document to the entry door, PAH members discourage police from entering the apartment and claim a misunderstanding. In sum, through planning with regard to the law, PAH cares for its members decentralizing the dangers of a high-risk activity among several people, as well as avoiding intentional or unintentional misinterpretations of the legal code from bank employees and police forces.

Acting to Be Safe

Risks are also mitigated during an action. A particularly important component of risk reduction is the combination of commitment to non-violence and the celebration of a cheerful mood. Previous research has argued that repression of non-violent campaigns has higher costs for the public image of authorities and the internal morale of police forces (Chenoweth & Stephan, 2011). Commitment to non-violence and cheerfulness, in combination with the social stigma carried by banks, particularly during the financial crisis, and PAH's high popularity (El País, 2013), proved to be a strategic advantage for PAH. For instance, it allowed PAH to push the limits of acceptable disruption.

> We were occupying a bank office the night before the 'dreadlock law'[4] came into force. During that period, we were so empowered and so sure that police could not do anything to us that we decided to wait until after midnight, when the law would come into force, just to make a statement. We

[4] The Organic Law 4/2015 of protection of citizen security, commonly referred to as the dreadlock law, is a law approved by the conservative PP government, arguably to tame the wave of mobilization originated by the 15M/Indignados movement in 2011. According to Amnesty International, this law allows police to apply the law and sanction protesters in an arbitrary manner (Amnesty International, 2014). Social movement organizations and other progressive groups label the legislation as 'dreadlock law' because they argued it was aimed at silencing dissent on the streets through easing repression against protests.

> waited for the police to come and, when they arrived, we left the bank office doing conga dancing. (Non-beneficiary member, 16 June 2017, Barcelona)

To further avoid the risk of repression, PAH members consciously behave in a polite and friendly way with authorities. When police agents arrive at a bank protest organized by PAH, the initial interaction with them generally aims at lowering tensions. There is always somebody who is in charge of greeting them and explaining what the group is doing, the reasons that led PAH to organize the action, and what the collective is planning to do during the event. Depending on how activists perceive that police agents are reacting to the initial interaction, they may attempt to establish some personal connection with them. One of the protests in which I participated took place in a bank office located in Las Ramblas, Barcelona's most touristic street. When the police arrived, somebody told them 'Don't worry, we have you covered! This bank was bailed out with public funds. This money is also ours, so we don't want anybody to rob it either!' This cheerful interaction even made a police agent smile. As police agents are used to being dehumanized by protestors, this type of statements encouraged them to humanize PAH members and their purposes. This is so much the case, that one person experienced in mediating with police told me that 'during the worst years of the crisis, there were even police agents who would tell me "listen, I don't like banks either, but this is my job"'. This kind of human connection reduces significantly the risk of repression.

The cheerful mood present in most actions organized by PAH contributes to lowering members' perception of risks and stimulates participation. Instead of focusing on the risks of going to an eviction blockade or an occupation of a bank office, members often place emphasis on the fun they will have during the event. This strategy is particularly effective for newcomers with no previous political experience, who may face cultural barriers to participate in contentious collective activities or struggle to accommodate those actions with their identities.

Additionally, enjoying one's participation in the organization fosters commitment and long-term engagement.

> Good mood is contagious. There is no better way to get your message across than a good mood. PAH is happy while it is occupying a bank office. That is very badass. And this does not mean that we don't have bad moments during the assemblies, during each foreclosure procedure… Everyone that is occupying a bank office knows why she is going there. […] [Through the

> emphasis on entertainment] we are managing that people come to assemblies every week, even if they have a mess at home. Everyone has plenty of things to do, but there are people that keep coming even after they solved their cases. They come because they made friends; they come because they have fun. (Non-beneficiary member, 20 June 2017, Barcelona)

This leader is right when she takes fun seriously. Passing through a foreclosure procedure is a devastating experience. It affects every detail of one's life and destabilizes one's personal relationships. Hence, for many people trapped in their mortgages, their time in PAH is the only moment when they can feel more at ease and enjoy what they are doing.

Making activism enjoyable does not mean that its political aim becomes unimportant. PAH members go through incredibly difficult moments together and they are conscious about the drama each of them is facing. This is precisely why enjoying their activism is so important. When people are immobilized by their grievances, engaging in non-conforming behavior and dedicating time every week to a purpose is even more difficult than under normal circumstances. Beyond reducing risks perceptions, cheerfulness makes participation and engagement easier while the struggle continues. Furthermore, it also reinforces relationships among members.

> Everyone needs to have fun; everyone needs to have something to do so everyone feels useful. In this way, we also generate bonds among people, and it is easier to be empowered, to create this feeling of *Hoy por ti y mañana por mí* (I scratch your back and you'll scratch mine). (Non-beneficiary member, 20 June 2017, Barcelona)

When members enjoy their time together, bonds of friendship are created, fostering internal solidarity in the group.

Defending Each Other's Safety

Despite the planning efforts and the initiatives to reduce risks during an action, sometimes hazards become a reality. A member may receive a fine, be taken to the police station during an eviction blockade or bank protest, or a financial institution may initiate a lawsuit against an activist. In these cases, PAH reacts in two complementary ways. First, the organization internalizes the eventual costs derived from the risk. Second, it puts pressure on the players whose action has created the costs to avoid future risks.

PAH reduces the risks derived from the activism of its members by being ready to internalize the costs once hazards become reality. Among its members, PAH has lawyers that give free support to those who face legal charges or who have to appeal a fine. On other occasions, there are lawyer collectives, such as Legal Sol, whose activism is dedicated to supporting campaigners when they face legal repression. In the case of fines, the organization internalizes the costs of paying the fines of its members either with its own resources or organizing fundraising campaigns for that purpose.

> In all the cases I know of, which are not that many because people try to behave well, PAH has assumed the fines. It has either been the local chapter with its own resources; we have asked for money from other Catalan chapters, or we have used state-wide funds. When members got the most fines was during the 2013 Escraches[5] campaign and all of them were paid with resources from the state level. When there happened to be no money, we used internet donation campaigns, and we always managed to get the funds. (Non-beneficiary member, 12 July 2017, Barcelona)

These actions give certainty to members that the organization will back them up, should they have to face repression because of their civil resistance.

Beyond addressing the problems that arise due to legal repression, with the objective of avoiding future fines and lawsuits, PAH organizes protests in front of courts and the bank offices that have initiated legal actions against their members. These initiatives bring media attention, and PAH uses this opportunity to expose the history of the member facing charges. The background of most members is similar; a debtor in good faith who is trying to protect their home and is dedicating time to help others do the same. When the reality of PAH members is humanized, it is easier that public opinion sympathizes with them. This was particularly the case

[5] Escraches are 'a form of protest which consists of the public condemnation of those responsible for an injustice with the objective of exposing and upsetting them' (Romanos, 2014, p. 297). The objective of PAH's Escraches campaign was to put pressure on political parties to accept the discussion in the parliament of their official petition to change the mortgage law, which gathered 1.5 million signatures and is, to this date, the biggest official petition in the history of Spain. These actions consisted of a group of PAH members visiting the home of a politician to inform them about the drama of evictions. When politicians do not receive them, PAH members make noise, repeatedly ring their bells, and put up stickers on their doors (Romanos, 2014).

during the worst years of the financial crisis. Moreover, the festive repertoire that PAH uses during protests complicates the job of prosecutors in asking for harsh penalties.

> At the beginning, banks would try to take us to courts, but they don't do it anymore. They don't want people to know that they are evicting vulnerable families, so this is a mess for them. Also, you take a person to court and when the judge asks you what they did, what do you say? That they were singing, dancing, chanting 'Yes, it's possible!' and putting up stickers? [Laughs]. (Founder, 23 August 2017, Barcelona)

The combination of commitment to non-violence, cheerfulness, and protests against legal repression lowers the risks of facing lawsuits and fines. On the one hand, the prosecutor has a difficult job making a strong case in favor of any violence and damage. On the other, protests raise the costs that financial institutions need to face when taking activists to court, as their image is severely damaged. The combination of these factors has decreased the legal risks that PAH members face when they engage in actions of civil resistance.

Mitigating Risks Associated with Members' Lives

Many grievances put issues central to life at risk. The case of people facing eviction is clear: they risk losing their homes. Participatory care also consists of reducing some of the most prominent risks that organizational members face. Eviction blockades, the most central action of PAH's repertoire, are a great example of this. Before the wider political objective of defending everyone's right to decent housing, eviction blockades have the objective of minimizing members' life risk of losing their homes. During many of my interviews, I asked PAH members what the objectives of eviction blockades were. Their first reaction was often confusion, followed by the answer that eviction blockades had the aim of preventing people lose their homes. Only after that answer, they continued to give more abstract political arguments:

> Question: What are the reasons why PAH organizes eviction blockades?
> Answer: What do you mean?
> Q: Well, why do you guys place your bodies at the entrance of a building to prevent an eviction from taking place?

> A: Hmmm, what are the reasons for us? Well… we cannot leave any c*om-PAH* in the street. Also, if anybody is kicked out of their home, they should be offered a viable and dignified living alternative, either by the bank or by public administrations. We have to be where public administrations fail to be, because this should be their task… Also, we cannot allow that financial institutions keep this dynamic of accumulation by dispossession and, if there is a collective behind, they know that they are going to have a much tougher time expulsing people from their homes. (Non-beneficiary member, 12 August 2017, Sabadell)

The initial confusion shown by many respondents indicates that the care component of eviction blockades, assuring members' need of housing, is commonsensical for activists, even for members from more radical flanks that used plenty of political and Marxist jargon during interviews, as the one quoted above. The priority of reducing members' risks associated with life is at the core of the organization.

Reducing members' life risks increases their participation in the collective. For instance, it is already common knowledge for PAH members that the first two or three eviction attempts will be generally easily blocked without much confrontation, just by the presence of five or six PAH activists. This knowledge, and the confirmation that newcomers see by themselves when they participate in eviction blockades, assures members that they have a longer period to negotiate with their bank offices. Thanks to this, even newcomers are more available to help others in their struggle. Reducing members' life risks fosters internal solidarity.

> [Accompanying other people in their negotiations] was my salvation because I stopped gazing at my navel and thinking how miserable I was and how bad my life was going. This does not mean that I would not take care of my case. I went to the bank office, and I told them that I wanted the deed-in-lieu of foreclosure and 5 years of social rent but that I was not going to be everyday telling them the same. As I knew that my foreclosure procedure was going to take long, I had time to push them for a good solution for my case, instead of being waiting for their answer and feeling that they were already giving me a very good deal. So, I would go to negotiations at my bank office, but for other people. For me, they already knew what they had to do. (Beneficiary member, 30 July 2017, Barcelona)

The empowerment that can be appreciated in the quote above is the outcome of several care processes but, as reiterated in this book, even if this

study divides care work in different components for analytical purposes, caring practices happen at the same time and these dynamics should be understood in a holistic way. The activist from the quote above was emotionally empowered not to fear facing her bank office, and she went through a process of identity care to feel efficacious and supported by the collective. However, in addition to these dynamics, knowing that the risk of losing her home was not imminent, and seeing that PAH members managed to reduce that hazard significantly, encouraged her to look beyond her problems and engage in solidary behavior towards her peers and the collective. What her statement points at is that the reduction of her risk of losing her home fostered her solidary activities, as well as helping her to look at her mortgage problem from a distance and plan her negotiations better.

Other risks related to members' lives are those anticipated if PAH's actions do not yield the expected results. The risk of losing their homes, despite their efforts negotiating with banks and the collective attempts to block their eviction, is a hazard that does not originate from their activism, but rather from their life circumstances. A foreclosure procedure puts people's residence at risk regardless of whether they are members of the organization or not. As explained in Chapter "The Origins of PAH: Empathy and Solidarity Mobilization", PAH's Obra Social campaign originated precisely from the failure of an eviction blockade when the foreclosed couple decided to occupy the apartment from which they were evicted. From that moment on, PAH started Obra Social to eliminate the risk of homelessness for its members, even when their eviction could not be prevented.

Despite Obra Social being the most obvious example, other activities contribute to supporting members, once some life risks become reality. Many spontaneous interactions of care appear in the face of danger when instinct leads members to mitigate other people's risks. When a family is evicted, empathy towards that situation triggers intuitive reactions that do not need to be planned. Even a newcomer who has not been socialized in the organizational culture will feel the urge to assist in taking the property of those evicted out of their homes before police seal the apartments. Sometimes, intuitive care practices go even further. During my fieldwork, the apartment of a woman and her son was foreclosed without notification. Ironically, she only found out when she was returning home after an eviction blockade and her street was closed by a police van on each side. As she was wearing PAH's green t-shirt, she was not even allowed to enter the street to pick her things up from her apartment. This practice is illegal,

but the administration argued that they could not notify her because she was not found at home on several occasions. Regardless of whether there were attempts to notify her, this was surely an easier job for the police and the judicial entourage. This woman was a very active member of PAH Barcelona and, in addition to her ten years old son, she had a daughter on the way. The attendance of her eviction blockades was much higher than the average, and more than 100 people would gather in front of her door. The eviction caught both her and PAH by surprise, so nobody had planned how to rehouse her through Obra Social. As finding an empty apartment owned by a financial institution takes several weeks, the organization was not ready to react in a timely manner. Under these circumstances, several members offered to host her and her son in their homes. Finally, she ended up being hosted by another activist who was already in an Obra Social apartment.

For sure, participation in PAH and eviction blockades creates a context where empathy appears easier than under other circumstances. Everyone present in a failed attempt to block the eviction has already freed time to participate in the action. So they can dedicate it to help to move the family's property, too. Moreover, many can imagine themselves being evicted, as it is an outcome that they are struggling against. So, they can easily empathize with the situation. However, what is important about these examples is that these interactions of care that take place within the context of the organization decrease the degree of damage that the risk of eviction may pose to those facing it, and that this happens regardless of the reasons that may motivate the eviction. Additionally, these relations of care foster participation in the organization, as they create strong bonds among members and solid collective identities.

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Care, Solidarity, Coalitions, and Power

The Platform of Those Affected by Mortgages (PAH by its Spanish acronym) has changed Spanish social movements, housing policy and institutional politics. Since its creation in 2009 in Barcelona, it is not present in more than 250 locations across Spain. It has also blocked thousands of evictions and rehoused more than 2500 people in occupied homes owned by financial institutions (Plataforma de Afectados por la Hipoteca, 2017) and collected almost 1.5 million signatures in what became the biggest official petition in Spanish history to this date, and it has forces changes to five regional housing laws (Martínez, 2019). Moreover, it has moved social discourses about housing and the financial crisis towards in the direction of a more social frame, and has improved social perceptions of occupation (Martínez, 2019). Finally, many of its members have become elected representatives, being the two most iconic examples Ada Colau, former PAH's spokesperson and major of Barcelona between June 2015 and June 2023, and Irene Montero, former leader of the organization in Madrid and Spanish Minister of equal opportunities between January 2020 and November 2023.

PAH's successes are impressive, but so were the challenges it faced in mobilizing those unable to pay their mortgage installments and risk losing their homes. Facing eviction takes place in parallel to other economic and social problems that prevent participation in politics. For 'debtors of good faith', default is the consequence of economic impoverishment. Against

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F. G. Santos, *Social Movements that Care*,
https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-031-74296-5_8

the backdrop of the economic crisis started in 2008, many lost their jobs while their mortgage installments kept coming every month. The reality of unemployment and the prospect of homelessness leads many to dedicate most of their day to attempt to find a job, seek support from social services and engaging in low-paid, unstable jobs that provide little money but occupy plenty of time. Beyond economic problems, those experiencing foreclosure procedures are more likely to suffer health problems (Vásquez-Vera et al., 2016), and report higher levels of depression and anxiety (Cagney et al., 2014; Gathergood, 2012). Sometimes, evictions push people beyond their limits, leading them even to commit suicide (15Mpedia, 2018; Houle & Light, 2014).

Different Ways of Experiencing Grievances and Solidarity

As I argued in this book, while most research on social movements and other types of contentious politics focuses on how grievances may mobilize individuals, some forms of oppression are so acute and central to people's lives that immobilized them. Individuals immobilized by their grievance confront structural, biographical, and/or personal factors that prevent them from engaging in politics. First, having 'structural availability', being connected to others, is a major factor for participating in collective action (Klandermans & Oegema, 1987; McAdam & Paulsen, 1993; Snow et al., 1980). Immobilizing grievances may destroy part or all the social networks of those experiencing them. For instance, evictions may be the outcome or the cause of divorce and family problems, and the shame and fear of letting others know about one's default may lead to self-imposed isolation.

Second, 'biographical availability', having the time and energy and being able to find space for political participation among one's alternative commitments, is key to have the motivation to participate in contentious politics (Beyerlein & Hipp, 2006; McAdam, 1986). Immobilizing grievances are often so overwhelming that individuals have no time or energy left for anything else. In the case of mortgage defaulters, being unemployed while seeing the money in their bank accounts disappear mortgage installment by mortgage installment forces people trapped in their mortgages to dedicate most of their time to try to find solutions to their situation. People trapped in their mortgages are often pushed into the 'gig

economy' (Friedman, 2014) and accept unstable and low-paid jobs. Should their economic troubles not be enough, the additional social and health problems people facing eviction experience add to the list of issues that leave them no time and exhaust their energies.

Finally, immobilizing grievances may deter individuals from acting by limiting their 'personal availability'. As I have conceptualized it in this book, personal availability refers to the degree that emotional, self-identity, and knowledge constraints pose barriers to participation in politics. Those facing immobilizing grievances experience emotions that discourage interaction with others and appearing in public. For instance, neoliberal discourses praising the ideal of the 'self-made man' and that link success in life with economic performance lead people trapped in their mortgages to be ashamed of their situation. This shame leads many to hide their economic problems, even from their closest circles. Under this situation, it is impossible for them to even consider gathering with others either in close or public spaces, engaging in public claim-making regarding their grievance. Similarly, those people with low self-esteem, impressions of low self-efficacy, and who feel unauthentic tend to avoid engaging with others (Gecas, 1982). For people trapped in their mortgages, the constant unsuccessful interactions with bank clerks attempting to find a solution to their financial problems and in which they are often treated with disrespect lead them to develop 'learned helplessness' (Abramson et al., 1978). Their repeated unsuccessful attempts push them to internalize that they are unable to achieve any of their goals, discouraging them from even trying to do so, let alone in an innovative way such as joining a social movement.

Beyond preventing individuals from participating in politics, immobilizing grievances also block solidary behavior, understood from a Durkheimian perspective as one's willingness to contribute individual resources—time, money, and energy—to a collective end (cf. Durkheim, 1912; Hechter, 1987). As immobilizing grievances reduce individuals' structural availability and embeddedness in social networks is the prime venue through which people receive information about mobilization opportunities (Klandermans & Oegema, 1987; Onuch, 2015), it is unlikely that those immobilized by their grievances will be able to contribute any private resources to collective ends because they are probably not aware of collective initiatives. Moreover, the limited biographical availability that those immobilized by their grievances have means that

they often do not have time or energy to address their most basic needs, let alone contributing to collective initiatives. Finally, beyond their low personal availability, those who experience immobilizing grievances often associate themselves with 'spoiled identities' (Goffman, 1990 [1963]; Kaplan & Liu, 2000), which discourage them from identifying themselves with those experiencing similar troubles. Hence, beyond decreasing individuals' structural, biographical, and personal availability, immobilizing grievances also hinder the solidarity within the affected collective.

On the opposite side of the spectrum of possible reactions to grievances, we find those that mobilize guided by external solidarity, in support of a collective they are not part of. Even if they do not experience that specific problem in their own skin, the empathy towards the struggle of another collective may lead some to engage in solidary action. There are several reasons why people may participate in social movements, even initiating mobilization, on behalf of others. One reason is that their previous experiences (e.g., previous activist involvements, past personal events, etc.) have led them to develop morals that encourage them to defend the rights of others, either in general or facing a specific grievance (Vecchione et al., 2015). In other cases, religion and ideology may encourage individuals to act in solidarity with others (Mayton & Furnham, 1994; Nepstad, 2004, 2008; Russo, 2018). Moreover, a certain degree of economic security and social comfort may be a necessary but not sufficient condition, as those experiencing economic precariousness or social oppression may prefer to engage in activities aimed at addressing their problems.

External solidarity is what led to the creation of PAH. None of the people who created the organization had a mortgage or housing problems. However, they decided to dedicate substantial amounts of time and energy to fight for the rights of those facing eviction. As I have argued based on the case of PAH, mobilizations originating in external solidarity follow a distinct process inspired by an ethic of care (Tronto, 1993, 2013). Combining studies on the ethics of care and political process models, this book developed a model of mobilization based on the politics of care that served to explain PAH's mobilization and to conceptualize other initiatives originating from external solidarity.

Insider-Outsider Coalitions and Care-Based Mobilizations

In this book, I have sought to argue that coalitions among non-beneficiary, privileged outsiders and a heavily aggrieved collective may be, under some circumstances, a transformative way of addressing certain types of oppression. Experienced activists, university students, those with economic security, and those living in a country where they have citizenship or regularized residence, among others, have resources that less-privileged collectives lack. Their civic skills and basic comforts in their lives allow them to be better able to engage in politics. Conversely, some grievances are so intense that they affect every part of people's lives. These grievances create so much instability that those who suffer from them are immobilized and unable to confront them. In these situations, injustices would persist should people with more advantaged social statuses not act.

Based on the origins of PAH and its evolution, in this book I proposed a model for solidarity mobilizations, inspired by a combination of the work on the ethics of care (Tronto, 1993, 2013) and on interactive and strategic approaches to the political process model (Choi-Fitzpatrick, 2017). This model of mobilization comprises the four steps that Tronto (1993, 2013) identified for the process of caring: attentiveness (caring about), responsibility (caring for), competence (caregiving), and responsiveness (care receiving).

As I theorized in Chapter "Housing Crisis, Care, and Empowerment" and analyzed empirically focusing on the case of PAH in Chapter "Caring Movements and Care in Movements", solidarity mobilizations begin when an individual or group identifies that an external community has a need that should be addressed. In other words, solidarity mobilizations start when a group is attentive to the needs of another external collective and recognizes that care is necessary. In the case of PAH, none of its six founders had a mortgage. Beyond their relative economic stability, the empathy from these solidarity early-risers originated from several sources. In the case of Ada Colau, Adrià Alemany, Ernest Marco, and Guillem Domingo, their prior activism experiences helped them empathize with others. Ada and Adrià were leaders of V de Vivienda, a social movement organization organizing for the right to housing during the housing bubble, while Ernest and Guillem were involved in the Office for Social rights of the social center Ateneu Candela. This initiative was a self-help space for people living under a number of precarious conditions. In both of these

groups, these four people realized that more and more people started to face problems paying their mortgage installments and began already to receive eviction notices for this reason. Differently from many other activists in leftist circles who considered that those who contracted mortgages to buy a house were part of the problem of housing speculation, Ada, Adrià, Ernest, and Guillem managed to empathize with those trapped in their mortgages. The remaining two founders, Lucía Delgado and Lucía Martín, had no prior experience in activism. Their empathy was sparked through conversations with Ernest, their colleague in the Department of Chemical, Biological, and Environmental Engineering at the Autonomous University of Barcelona.

Upon caring about an external collective and identifying a need, solidarity early-risers take responsibility for addressing it. This step involves evaluating the situation, considering potential threats and opportunities in addressing the oppressed collective's grievances through collective action. If conditions appear favorable, solidarity early-risers take responsibility for addressing the identified problem. In the context of social movements, caring for involves recognizing that the roots of a problem are political and that they can only be addressed through collective action. In the case of PAH's solidarity early-risers, they started to gather as much information as they could about the problems that people affected by mortgages were facing, the process of foreclosure following mortgage default, as well as reflecting about possible strategies to reach those affected by mortgages and start mobilizing them. After the evaluation of the relevant actors in their field and the threats and opportunities of mobilizing people trapped in their mortgages, PAH founders decided to reach the affected community.

Following the assumption of responsibility to address the needs of an external collective, caregiving through contentious collective action begins. This process is iterative and relational. After initiating the process of mobilization and caregiving, non-beneficiary and beneficiary constituents interact, evaluate their strategies and adapt them to their learnings and new circumstances. When activists reevaluate their strategies and innovate, they, again, require attentiveness to the needs of the affected collective and a reevaluation of their responsibility, competence, and actions. It may also be the case that, through the process of caregiving, new caring needs are detected, starting other caring processes that may take place in parallel to others already ongoing.

The interactive and iterative component of care is clear in the first attempts from PAH founders to mobilize those trapped in their

mortgages. Motivated by the high turnout of the first assembly they organized, as well as the continued participation in the later ones, PAH leaders decided to organize a demonstration, expecting that many of those trapped in their mortgages that attended the assemblies would also join the action. The day of PAH's first demonstration, according to several leaders, nobody of those affected by the problem of mortgages showed up. This initial failure made PAH leaders realize that those trapped in their mortgages were immobilized by their grievance. PAH's beneficiary constituents were afraid that banks would retaliate if they marched to expose them; they were ashamed of their situation and did not want their families and friends to know about it, so they did not want to go public about their problems on the street; they did not identify with that type of action and could not see themselves taking part in it; they thought demonstrations were dangerous and did not want to put themselves in harm's way, should police repress the march. In other words, people trapped in their mortgages had some needs that had to be addressed before they could be ready to take part in a public action.

PAH's failed first demonstration made leaders realize that immobilizing grievances create a number of needs that had to be addressed before people could develop the necessary internal solidarity and mobilize politically. In addition to approaching care as a logic of mobilization, in this book, I have also pointed out that care is central to interactions among members of a community. As I argued in the book, and also elaborate in the next section of the conclusion, any collective engages in three types of care relationships that are key for facilitating the participation of its members: emotional, identity, and participatory care. First, emotional care encompasses the exchanges among activists that tackle immobilizing emotions while fostering high emotional energy. High emotional energy instills confidence, enthusiasm, and proactivity in individuals (Collins, 2004), which are the types of emotions that researchers have argued motivate participation in social movements (Goodwin et al., 2001; Jasper, 2011, 2018). Second, identity care involves organizational endeavors to preserve and mend members' individual and collective identities. Focused on members' self-concepts, identity care encourages individuals to have greater regard for themselves, as well as to perceive themselves as efficacious and authentic. These self-perceptions have been linked to proactive behavior and participation in collective initiatives, such as social movements (Gecas, 2000). Furthermore, identity care promotes a sense of collective identity, encouraging members to view their peers as part of the same social entity and to

contribute their individual resources towards the group's goals. Finally, participatory care refers to interactions aimed at promoting involvement in a group's activities. Within the range of actions of a movement's repertoire, not all may be equally accessible to specific groups. Factors such as socialization, personality, responsibilities towards others, lack of prior activist experience, or even age and health prevent some individuals from engaging in certain forms of activism. In these cases, participatory care means developing a variety of actions with an approachable level of involvement that allows most social movement members to participate. Parallelly, participatory care also entails equipping members with the knowledge and resources necessary for engaging in such activities.

Even though we can categorize care into the three types described in this book and section for analytical purposes, it remains an all-encompassing process. The borders separating these categories frequently blur, and various care processes interconnect, amplifying one another. For instance, emotional care plays a role in shaping collective identities and transforming activists' self-perceptions, and such identities strengthen solidarity among newcomers and enable intuitive emotional caregiving interactions. However, despite the haziness of the divisions among care types in real-life situations, maintaining the analytical distinction proves beneficial for isolating distinct dynamics. This approach allows for the identification of concrete needs that might impede solidarity and the formulation of tailored organizational strategies to address these concerns.

The last step in the process of mobilization is receiving care and the outcomes it produces. After care activities occur, the individual or group receiving care responds to the interaction. While the care the care process may end at this stage, it is also common that, as some caring needs are addressed, new ones arise. In the context of mobilization, and for care to be considered political, the recipient should progress towards taking ownership of their struggle. This distinction marks the sometimes-subtle difference between care relationships within contentious politics or assistance-based activities. On a micro-level, members exposed to care will gradually engage more in organizational activities and participate in diverse actions. After meeting some of their caring needs, they may replicate the care they received, supporting others in overcoming similar situations. In the case of PAH's beginnings, the dynamics of care that took place within the organization prepared those trapped in their mortgages to engage in public displays of contention, such as demonstrations and eviction blockades, among other activities. At the meso-level, the movement assesses

mobilization outcomes, strategizes, and adapts to new situations and knowledge. The care process may introduce previously inaccessible actions into the movement's repertoire. For instance, while, during its beginnings, PAH failed to organize a demonstration and struggled to encourage its members to initiate eviction blockades, these two actions have become common activities in its repertoire. Lastly, on a macro-level, mobilization can impact the incumbent's behavior, resulting in public policies and legislation, as well as influencing the field's culture and norms. For instance, PAH has effectively prompted changes in housing laws in five Spanish regions (Martínez, 2019). Besides, as this manuscript is being written, the Spanish government is considering a new housing law, incorporating input from several housing organizations, including PAH.

Empowerment in Social Movements

In the book, I have argued that care work is vital for building solidarity among individuals immobilized by their grievances. While all organizations aim to empower their members to varying extents, empowerment strategies are particularly crucial when a group's grievances significantly disrupt their lives, hindering their ability to act politically. As care relations address some individuals' needs that complicate their political participation, they bring them closer to taking ownership of their struggle, advancing in their process of empowerment. In essence, when members of a group care for each other, they contribute to facilitating the participation and empowerment of those people who are struggling the most in confronting their oppression.

For the purpose of understanding empowerment in the context of mobilization in social movements, in this book, I have conceptualized it as the process of increasing the structural, biographical, and personal availability of individuals and communities. Hence, in the context of social movements, empowerment is the result of individuals and groups (1) increasing their embeddedness into activist networks; (2) being better able to combine their personal commitments with their activism involvements in their lives; and (3) replacing immobilizing with activating emotions, developing positive self-concepts and collective identities, as well as building the skills and knowledges to participate in the activities they wish to engage.

Empowerment approaches mobilization as a relational, strategic, and dynamic process. From a relational perspective, by emphasizing the

importance of interactions among members, an empowerment perspective moves away from understandings of mobilization based exclusively on structural factors or individuals' characteristics. While considering those perspectives, empowerment emphasizes activists' agency and capacity to encourage the mobilization of others through relations aimed at encouraging members to take ownership of their own and their community's affairs. From a strategic and dynamic viewpoint, empowerment is a nonlinear process (Christens, 2019). Individuals and groups might progress in exerting control over certain aspects of their lives while struggling with others; they may progress in unintended directions, including against their goals; and, based on their experiences, they will reflect on their actions and adjust their strategies. Hence, empowerment is a complex phenomenon that depends on individual, group, and structural factors, and the strategies that may work in one context may not always work in others.

I have argued that empowerment takes place at the individual and organizational level. At the individual level, people may consciously seek to (re)gain control over their circumstances and contribute to the collective goals of their peers and the organization. For instance, individuals may learn new skills, organize their time to dedicate more to activism, or attempt to manage their emotions by themselves. At the organizational level, organizations can play a significant role in empowering their members through rituals and activities aimed that this purpose, as well as providing an environment that encourages individuals to experience certain ways of feeling, cultivate positive self-perceptions, and acquire new skills.

One example I have focused on through which organizations promote member empowerment is what I termed a system of incremental engagement. This approach incorporates three elements: providing accessible participation opportunities for members at various degrees of empowerment, collectively acknowledging and celebrating individual and group achievements, and offering opportunities for members to build knowledge and skills.

Firstly, members need activism opportunities that align with their empowerment and skill level. Newcomers often begin with familiar tasks that introduce them to the organization's goals and enable them to socialize with peers. In the case of PAH, these involvements often consist of activities that members have done in the past, in contexts different from activism. Some examples of these engagements may be cleaning the assembly space, creating banners for a demonstration or taking on childcare during an assembly so parents can focus on the organizational debates and

activities. As members evolve in their level of empowerment, they can take on other tasks that were initially beyond their reach.

Secondly, acknowledging members' contributions and celebrating successes, both big and small, boosts self-efficacy and encourages engagement. The feeling of accomplishment varies depending on members' level of availability. Less empowered members may conceive of something as a great achievement, while more experience activists may attain a similar goal with little effort. Hence, organizations celebrate milestones of all types, as long as they are relevant to their members. In the case of PAH, they use the term tiny-great victories that provides two types of meaning to celebrations. On the one hand, no victory is small if it is important to anyone. On the other, accomplishing a goal means more than the objective itself. It indicates that victory against seemingly unbeatable opponents is possible because they have managed to win that specific battle.

Lastly, organizations contribute to members' empowerment by offering opportunities to build the knowledge and skills needed to contribute to the movements' activities. PAH organizes workshops on topics ranging from negotiating strategies with banks to how to use social media, so members can develop the capacities to contribute to those activities. Another common way in which PAH builds skills among members is through informal coaching during actions. For instance, during eviction blockades, some members are encouraged to join and observe those in charge of negotiating with the judicial entourage so, beyond learning negotiation strategies, they will also acquire real experience of being present in those actions. Eventually, members will take on more active roles during those negotiations until they are able to carry them by themselves.

This process of incremental engagement also builds power for the organization as a whole. As members acquire new competencies, they can more tackle complex tasks, liberating more accessible roles for newcomers. This enables organizations to expand their leadership while also facilitating the integration of new members into the empowerment process.

Inequalities, Care-Based Mobilizations, and the Role of Non-beneficiary Constituents

Overall, the care-based model of mobilization I proposed can serve to understand other collective endeavors in which the initiators are not part of the group that is expected to benefit directly, should their aims be

achieved. While the ambition of this book was not to provide an overarching model of mobilization, there are numerous collectives following this logic. For instance, during the recent years we have witnesses a growing number of refugee solidarity movements in which people living in the countries where asylum seekers attempt to enter try to help them in their endeavor. Sometimes, they may support those seeking asylum with the paperwork and with the necessities they may have settled in the country. On other occasions, these groups save the lives of many attempting to cross the Mediterranean Sea in precarious rubber boats by rescuing them before they sink into the waters. The peace movements that have appeared across European countries as a reaction to Russia's invasion of Ukraine is another example. Furthermore, as social inequalities grow greater within and across countries (Chancel et al., 2022), it could be expected that this type of mobilizations increase, as the lives of some become so precarious that their grievances immobilized them and, hopefully, the outrage and empathy from other, more privileged, groups leads them to take action.

This being said, the dynamics intrinsic to care-based mobilizations do not come without challenges. As it has been discussed in this work, non-beneficiary constituents should also be mindful of the power dynamics that may arise when they act as allies to other collectives. There is a thin line between transformative politics that empower oppressed collectives and assistance-based initiatives that perpetuate existing inequalities and disempower those expected to benefit from them. As the originally immobilized group starts to become empowered and have the capacity to take ownership of their struggle, solidarity early-risers and other privileged allies should be mindful to liberate spaces for beneficiary members to speak from and by themselves and defend their rights. The ultimate goal of care-based mobilizations that empower a constituency should be for those directly oppressed to become the main actors of their own struggle. Dynamics in which privileged allies become overly attached to their roles may risk reproducing assistance-based logic and reproduce some of the inequalities they originally sought to redress.

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F. G. Santos, *Social Movements that Care*,
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F. G. Santos, *Social Movements that Care*,
https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-031-74296-5

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